

Odisha Day celebrated with cultural performances

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Government on Wednesday organised a cultural programme at the Delhi Secretariat to mark Odisha Day, with traditional dance performances and participation from artists highlighting the state's rich heritage.

The event featured performances of Sambalpuri dance, including the popular Rangabati, along with Ras Jamudali and tribal dance forms, which drew appreciation from the audience.

Delhi's Minister for Art, Culture, and Languages Kapil Mishra extended greetings on behalf of the government and said such events aim to promote national unity. He said the celebrations are being held in line with the vision of "Ek Bharat Shreshtha Bharat," which focuses on strengthening cultural connections across states.

Mishra said that under the leadership of Chief Minister Rekha Gupta, the Delhi government has been organising state foundation day celebrations to showcase India's cultural diversity.

Highlighting Odisha's legacy, the minister said the state is known globally for its ancient civilisation, temple architecture, handicrafts, and classical as well as folk tradi-

tions. He added that Odisha has made significant contributions to the country's cultural and economic development through art, literature, and maritime history.

He also acknowledged the role of people from Odisha living in Delhi, stating that they have contributed to the growth and development of the national capital.

The performances formed the core of the event, with around 15 artists presenting traditional dance forms rooted in Odisha's cultural landscape.

The Sambalpuri dance, particularly Rangabati, was among the highlights, reflecting themes of rural life and folk traditions. Ras Jamudali, another traditional dance form, depicted stories inspired by the lives of Radha and Krishna through expressive movements and music.

Artists also performed tribal dances, adding diversity to the programme.

Officials said the performances aimed to present a glimpse of Odisha's vibrant cultural traditions to audiences in Delhi. The event was organised by the Sahitya Kala Parishad under the Department of Art, Culture, and Languages. A large number of attendees, including officials and members of the public, were present.

Mishra said such programmes play an important role in bringing people from different states closer and help in preserving and promoting traditional art forms.

He added that showcasing the cultural identity of different states in the national capital helps build awareness among younger generations about the country's diversity.



CM Rekha calls for tech-driven farming at IARI Foundation Day

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Wednesday stressed the need for integrating technology with agriculture to achieve the vision of a developed India, while addressing the 122nd Foundation Day celebrations of the Indian Agricultural Research Institute (IARI).

Speaking as the chief guest at the event, the Chief Minister said that the future of India depends on strong agriculture backed by scientific innovation. She praised the role of agricultural scientists and said institutions like IARI have been central in strengthening food security and supporting farmers.

"The convergence of farming and technology is the foundation of a developed India," the Chief Minister said, highlighting

the role of precision farming, climate-smart agriculture, and artificial intelligence in modernising the sector.

She also announced that the Delhi Government will work closely with IARI to improve soil health and expand green cover in the city.

She added that scientific support will be crucial in promoting sustainable urban farming and environmental conservation.

During the event, the Chief Minister released two publi-

cations titled "Improved Crop Varieties for Food, Nutrition and Livelihood Security" and "Precision Floriculture and Landscape Design." She also visited an exhibition showcasing new agricultural technologies and interacted with scientists.

She urged citizens and institutions to plant native trees such as peepal, neem, banyan, and mango. She further said that around 4,200 hectares of the Ridge area have been notified to expand green cover in Delhi.





PWD minister orders removal of Chinese-origin CCTV cameras

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi PWD Minister Parvesh Sahib Singh on Wednesday ordered the phased removal of Chinese-origin CCTV cameras installed in the national capital. This comes after the Centre banned them, citing security concerns. Delhi currently has 2,74,389 CCTV cameras installed by the PWD.

Initiating the removal process, the Delhi minister also said the cameras were installed during the tenure of the AAP and said it raised serious questions on the intent and judgement behind

such decisions. Officials said the replacement will be carried out in phases to ensure no disruption in surveillance coverage while upgrading the system to meet stricter security standards.

“We have taken a decision to phase out a significant portion of the CCTV cameras installed across the city, particularly those sourced from Chinese firms, in line with recent Government directives and broader security considerations. Therefore, we will be gradually replacing cameras with updated systems that meet current technical standards, offer

better data security and are supported by a robust supply and service ecosystem. The transition will be carried out in a phased manner to avoid any disruption in surveillance coverage, which is being simultaneously rationalised,” Parvesh Sahib Singh said.

Announcing immediate corrective steps, he added, “We have approved the replacement of 50,000 Chinese cameras in the first phase. This is a clear course correction. Every Chinese camera installed earlier will be systematically replaced with secure and trusted systems.”



We have approved the replacement of 50,000 Chinese cameras in the first phase. This is a clear course correction. Every Chinese camera installed earlier will be systematically replaced with secure and trusted systems

— PARVESH SAHIB SINGH, PWD MINISTER

The minister said Delhi currently has 2,74,389 CCTV cameras installed by PWD under major phases, including 1,40,000 cameras installed in Phase 1 (September 2020 - November 2022) and 1,34,389 cameras installed in Phase 2 (June 2025 - March 2026).

Critically, all 1,40,000 cameras installed in Phase 1 were Chinese-made (Hikvision) — a company that has faced global scrutiny over security concerns, he said.

Taking a direct and sharp stance, Parvesh Sahib Singh said

“The Aam Aadmi Party installed Chinese Hikvision

cameras across Delhi without thinking about the long-term security implications. Surveillance infrastructure is not just about visibility, it is about control over sensitive data.”

He added, “This was not a routine procurement decision. When you deploy such systems across an entire city, you are making a national security choice. Unfortunately, the Aam Aadmi Party failed to recognise that.”

Drawing a clear contrast in governance approach, the minister stated, “For them, it was about numbers and publicity. For us, it is about secu-

city, accountability and protecting Delhi’s citizens without any compromise.”

Starting April 1, all internet-connected CCTV cameras sold in India will have to get a clearance from the Ministry of Electronics and Communications’ Standardisation Testing and Quality Certification (STQC) framework.

As a part of the new guidelines, companies selling internet-connected CCTV cameras in India will have to disclose information regarding the key equipment used in CCTV cameras, including the origin of the system-on-chip (SoC) or the processor.

LG directs DDA to improve civic infrastructure, services

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi Lt Governor Taranjit Singh Sandhu on Wednesday directed the Delhi Development Authority (DDA) to ensure the availability and development of the best global civic infrastructure and services in all areas and projects under it.

Making this assertion after undertaking an extensive review of major public infrastructure and urban development projects executed by the Delhi Development Authority (DDA) in Dwarka, he also reiterated his vision of development-led governance.

Sandhu said infrastructure projects must improve everyday life for residents through better recreation, mobility, green spaces, and public services, while adding to the physical assets of the city.

The visit focused on the vision to transform the sub-city into a vibrant hub for international events, business, and cultural engagement. Vice Chairman DDA N Saravana Kumar and other



senior officers of DDA were also present during the visit.

As part of the review, the Lt Governor carried out key site visits to Storm Water Channels No. 2 & 5, the Golf Course project at Sector-24, and the 5 Star Hotel Project — a Special Licence Fee Project at Sector-23.

The focus of the visit was Dwarka sub-city, one of Delhi’s most prominent planned urban zones, which has emerged as a benchmark for integrated infrastructure, green mobility, modern public amenities, and quality urban living.

Highlighting Dwarka’s

strategic advantages, Sandhu said, “Dwarka has the potential to emerge as a premier destination for global engagements, given its excellent connectivity through UER-II, proximity to IGI Airport, and world-class infrastructure such as Yashobhoomi, the upcoming Bharat Vandana Park, and the Golf Course.

A comprehensive roadmap must be developed to position these assets as vibrant centres for international conventions, exhibitions, cultural festivals, and business summits. We must actively invite multinational

companies, global institutions, and embassies to organise events here, including CEO roundtables and high-level conferences, supported by robust digital and social infrastructure suited for modern corporate ecosystems.”

During the visit, the Lt Governor appreciated the DDA’s efforts in creating world-class public infrastructure that directly enhances ease of living for residents while contributing to the beautification and modernisation of Delhi’s urban landscape.

He further directed officials to prepare a holistic and time-bound roadmap for leveraging Dwarka’s strategic location and infrastructure by promoting it as a hub for multinational events and investments and to actively engage with global corporations, embassies, and stakeholders for hosting conventions, film festivals, exhibitions, and cultural programmes.

Among the projects reviewed, the Storm Water Channels No. 2 and No. 5

project is a significant urban transformation and rejuvenation initiative that has converted critical drainage infrastructure into green recreational corridors with cycling tracks, walkways, public plazas, solar installations, and community amenities, while simultaneously strengthening sewage treatment and pollution abatement systems.

Sandhu also reviewed the 5-star hotel project in Sector-23 - a special project on an annual licence fee model in which the selected bidder will develop, build, finance, operate and transfer a hotel with a minimum of 200 lettable rooms.

Subsequently, at Sector-26, Dwarka, he reviewed the proposed sites for the development of an IT & ITES Hub along UER-II (Part-D), strategically located near the upcoming ICC Metro Station.

He also visited the Yashobhoomi Convention Centre and its surrounding areas, assessing their potential for hosting large-scale national and international events.

Government to demolish ‘Jinxed’ British-era bungalow

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Government is considering demolishing a ‘jinxed’ British-era bungalow at 33, Shammath Marg in Civil Lines to make way for a state disaster management office, official sources said on Wednesday.

The two-storey structure, lying vacant for years, has acquired a reputation among officials as “inauspicious”, with successive occupants reportedly reluctant to move in. The bungalow once housed Delhi’s first Chief Minister, Chaudhary Brahm Prakash, who moved in after assuming office in 1952 but resigned in 1955 before completing his term following an alleged scam.

In 1993, the bungalow was allotted to Madan Lal Khurana after he became the Delhi Chief Minister. He didn’t shift there; instead, he ran an office from it, couldn’t complete his full tenure, and resigned in 1996. In 2013, the bungalow was allotted to Shakti Sinha,



the then principal secretary (power) of the Delhi Government. But he left it within four months.

Deep Chand Bandhu, former industries minister of the Delhi government, was allotted the bungalow, but he died during his tenure in 2003.

Former Chief Minister Sheila Dikshit reportedly preferred moving to a much smaller bungalow on Mathura Road initially over the jinxed bungalow. Steeped in history, the property dates back to the 1920s, when the British developed Civil Lines as a residential enclave for senior officials.

After Independence, its

proximity to the Delhi Legislative Assembly made it a preferred choice for the chief minister’s residence.

Despite its prime location and expansive layout, the bungalow has struggled to find takers in recent years, officials said. A team from Social Welfare Minister Ravinder Indraj Singh’s office inspected the premises last year, but the minister declined to move there, sources said.

Spread across a large plot, the estate includes four bedrooms, multiple drawing rooms, a spacious living area, fountains, a front lawn, an outhouse, and seven staff quarters.

Railways orders site inspection for Badli ROB after Speaker flags traffic crisis

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Union Railway Ministry has directed officials to conduct a site inspection at Badli Railway Station following concerns raised by Delhi Assembly Speaker Vijender Gupta over severe traffic congestion in the area, where commuters face delays of up to two to three hours daily.

The direction was issued by Union Railway Minister Ashwini Vaishnaw in response to a representation by the Speaker, who highlighted the urgent need for a Railway Over Bridge (ROB) to address the worsening traffic situation in North-West Delhi.

In an official communication to Gupta, the Railway Minister informed that the concerned authorities have been asked to assess the feasibility of the proposed ROB. The project aims to improve connectivity between Badli



Railway Station and Rohini Sector 18 Metro Station, a key junction that handles heavy daily traffic.

The issue was brought to the Minister’s attention by the Speaker after he received a representation from Badli MLA Aahir Deepak Chaudhary. The MLA had sought immediate intervention to ease congestion, particularly for commuters travelling from Rohini to nearby industrial and residential areas such as Samaypur, Siraspur, and Libaspur.

Highlighting the scale of the problem, Gupta said the existing underpass in the area is no longer sufficient to handle current traffic volumes.

He noted that the underpass was built when the population was significantly lower and has since become inadequate due to rapid urban expansion.

According to the Speaker, residents face long traffic jams, especially during peak hours, with delays stretching up to two to three hours. He

stressed that the situation is causing daily hardship for thousands of commuters who depend on this route.

The proposed Railway Over Bridge is expected to provide an alternative route and significantly reduce congestion. Gupta said the project would not only benefit residents of Rohini and Badli but also improve overall traffic movement in the surrounding areas.

He also pointed out that the ROB would strengthen connectivity with Urban Extension Road-II and nearby national highways, making it an important infrastructure upgrade for the region.

The representation highlighted that the congestion affects essential services as well. School buses, public transport vehicles, ambulances, and fire services often get stuck in long traffic queues, raising concerns about public safety and emergency response times.

Government rolls out Lakhpati Bitiya Yojana

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Government has rolled out the ‘Lakhpati Bitiya Yojana’, aimed at supporting the education and long-term financial security of the girl child through phased financial assistance from birth till higher education.

In a gazette notification issued on March 30, the Department of Women and Child Development detailed the ‘Delhi Lakhpati Bitiya Scheme Rules’, which came into force from Wednesday. The new scheme replaces the Ladli Scheme.

Under the scheme, financial assistance of up to ₹61,000 will be provided to eligible beneficiaries in instalments linked to key educational and age-related milestones, and it will mature to ₹1.20 lakh with interest.

The financial assistance will be deposited at various stages beginning at birth and continuing through school and higher education, including diploma and



graduation courses. The amount will be released in instalments but will be encashable only after the girl attains 18 or 21 years of age, depending on the milestone, it stated.

According to the notified structure, ₹11,000 will be provided at birth, followed by ₹5,000 each on admission to Classes 1, 6, 9, 11 and 12.

Further assistance includes ₹10,000 for a one-year diploma course, ₹20,000 for two or three-year diploma courses, and up to ₹25,000 for a four-year graduation programme. The total benefit may go up to ₹61,000.

The scheme was launched on March 2 by President

Droupadi Murmu in the “Sashakt Naari, Samridh Delhi” programme, and a budget allocation of ₹128 crore was proposed for it in the 2026-27 Delhi Assembly session.

According to the notification, eligibility conditions specify that the girl child must be born in Delhi and be a resident of the National Capital Territory for at least three years prior to application. The annual family income should not exceed ₹1.20 lakh, and benefits will be limited to two girls per family. The girl must be studying in a Government, MCD, NDMC or recognised school in Delhi, it added.

The rules also mandate that the beneficiary must remain unmarried till the age of 18 years. Any violation of this condition will lead to disqualification, and the accumulated amount will be returned to the Government.

The scheme allows registration within one year of birth or at key admission stages such as classes 1, 6, 9, and 11, as well as during entry into polytechnic, ITI or higher education courses.

Applications will be submitted online through a dedicated portal, along with documents such as a birth certificate, proof of residence, an income declaration, school admission proof and immunisation records, it stated.

The financial assistance will be deposited in the name of the girl child and credited to her Aadhaar-linked bank account upon maturity, subject to fulfilment of conditions such as completion of Class 12 or attainment of 18 or 21 years of age, the notification read.

Police arrest 267 narco-offenders

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

In a 48-hour crackdown under “Operation Kavach 13.0,” the Delhi Police arrested 267 narco-offenders in 229 cases, detained people and seized significant quantities of contraband, an official said on Wednesday.

The operation, conducted between March 29 and 31 across all 15 police districts, involved simultaneous raids at 3,211 locations by more than 1,000 police teams, including personnel from district units, the Crime Branch and the Special Cell.

Police said drug traffickers, suppliers and organised criminal networks were targeted.

During the operation, 267 people were arrested in narcotic drugs and psychotropic substances cases. Significant quantities of contraband were seized, including 100 kg of cannabis, 1.170 kg of cocaine, 260.65 grams of heroin, 179.11 grams of MDMA, 57 grams of amphetamine, over 2,000 buprenorphine



tablets and 183 injections.

“Over 416 cases were registered under the Delhi Excise Act, and 429 people were arrested. Police recovered a large quantity of illicit liquor and 200 e-cigarettes. 2,993 people were also booked for drinking in public places,” a senior police officer said.

Under the Arms Act, 259 people were arrested in 254 cases. Nineteen pistols, 42 country-made firearms, 79 live cartridges and 191 knives were recovered.

Police also intensified action against gambling activities, arresting 528 persons in 296 cases and recovering

over ₹10.28 lakh in cash.

“Apart from these, 59 proclaimed offenders and 42 auto lifters were arrested. Seventy-three stolen vehicles were recovered during the drive. 3,545 vehicles were seized under provisions of the Delhi Police Act. Preventive action formed a major component of the operation. Around 1,374 people were arrested to prevent potential offences. Additionally, 5,359 people were taken into preventive custody, while 41,394 persons were detained under Section 65 of the Delhi Police Act,” the officer said.

Government sets target to plant over 70 lakh trees

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Government has set a target to plant over 70 lakh trees, shrubs, and bamboo hedges across the city under its Green Action Plan (GAP) for 2026-27, as part of a major push to expand green cover and tackle pollution.

The revised plan assigns plantation responsibilities to 22 departments and agencies, with the Department of Forests and Wildlife designated as the nodal agency to monitor implementation. Progress will be tracked through an online GAP portal to ensure transparency and accountability.

Environment Minister Manjinder Singh Sirsa said the initiative reflects a coordinated effort by multiple agencies to address environmental challenges.

He stated that the

Government is adopting a multi-layered plantation strategy, which includes planting tall trees, shrubs, and ground cover to improve air quality and strengthen ecological balance.

According to official targets, the Forests and Wildlife Department will undertake the largest share, with over 27 lakh plantations. The Delhi Development Authority has been assigned a target of 10 lakh trees, while the Municipal Corporation of Delhi will plant 5 lakh. The New Delhi Municipal Council has a target of 5.05 lakh plantations.

Sirsa said the initiative builds on last year’s plantation drives, which saw participation from a wide range of stakeholders, including students, citizens, public officials, and international representatives.

No upfront fees or site visits needed for new power connections: DERC

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Amid growing complaints over electricity connections, the Delhi Electricity Regulatory Commission (DERC) has stated that no upfront payments or prior site visits by discom officials are required when applying for new connections.

The DERC is mandated to regulate and supervise the electricity utilities of Delhi and their operations, including the supply of electricity by power distribution companies (discoms) of Delhi, namely TPDDL, BRPL, BYPL and NDMC.

In a public notice issued on Wednesday, the Commission stated that the Supply Code Regulations, 2017, lay down the provisions for easy and timely release of electricity connections by discoms.

It lists various ease of doing business steps required for new connections, such as no



upfront payment for new connections and connections to be provided by the discoms without any prior site visit by their officials to the property concerned.

The payment for new connections and meters installed is added to the monthly electricity bills, it said.

Charges for new connections are fixed as per the DERC Schedule of Charges Order, and the discoms can not charge any additional costs, said the notice.

A self-declaration about

the testing of internal wiring through a licensed electrical contractor needs to be submitted by the applicants for new connections.

Importantly, people can approach the consumers’ grievances redressal forum (CGRF) of any discom to complain against violations of supply code regulations, it said. If a consumer is not satisfied with the order of the CGRF, they can move to the office of the Electricity Ombudsman for redressal of the grievance, it added.

IN FOCUS



Union Home Minister Amit Shah participated in the first self-enumeration exercise in India's census history, giving an option to citizens to submit their own information through a special web portal at his office on Wednesday

PIONEER PHOTO

NDA ushered in peace, progress in Northeast, says Sonowal

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Dhemaji/Jorhat

Shipping Minister Sarbananda Sonowal on Wednesday said the Northeast has entered a phase of peace, security and development under the BJP-led government, after years of violence and instability during the Congress rule.

Speaking at an election rally at Gogamukh in Dhemaji, which was also addressed by Prime Minister Narendra Modi, Sonowal asserted that Assam was



ready to deliver a historic mandate for the BJP-led NDA for a third term.

"A region once marked by violence, fear and instability under Congress rule is today firmly on the path of peace and rapid development.

YUVIKA empowering young minds, says Jitendra Singh

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Young scientist programme, Yuva Vigyani Karyakram (YUVIKA), has benefitted a total of 1,320 students so far, reflecting the growing enthusiasm among young learners for space-related disciplines, Union Minister Jitendra Singh said on Wednesday.

In a written reply to the Lok Sabha, the minister stated that the programme targeted Class 9 students across the country, aiming to provide them with a foundational understanding of space science, technology, and applications, while also moti-



vating them to consider space science as a future career option. "Students are shortlisted through an online screening of academic credentials

and merit-based process," Singh said. The programme, first announced in 2019, comprises special provisions to ensure wider access.

The minister highlighted that a 15 per cent reservation had been earmarked for students from rural and remote areas, thereby enabling equitable opportunities and encouraging talent from all corners of the country.

"Initiatives like YUVIKA are aligned with the broader vision of building a scientifically empowered India and strengthening the nation's capabilities in the space sector through early talent identification and nurturing," Singh said.

IndiGo announces ₹75 to ₹10,000 revised fuel charges; airfares to rise

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ New Delhi

The country's largest airline IndiGo on Wednesday announced revised fuel charges ranging from ₹275 to ₹10,000, which will push airfares higher for many domestic and international flights amid the rise in jet fuel prices.

The announcement from the country's largest airline comes on a day when the Aviation Turbine Fuel (ATF) prices were revised, and the Government decided to only partially hike the price by 25 per cent for the domestic flights. From March 14 onwards, the airline has been levying fuel charges ranging from ₹425 to ₹2,300 on domestic and international flight tickets as the fuel prices jumped in the wake of the West Asia conflict.



"Although fully offsetting the fuel price increase would require substantial fare revisions, IndiGo has passed on a relatively smaller amount to customers, keeping in mind the consequential burden on them," IndiGo said on Wednesday and regretted the inconvenience to passengers resulting from the fuel charges.

For domestic flights, the revised fuel charges will be ₹275 to ₹950, and in the case of international flights, the fuel charges will vary from ₹900 to ₹10,000. The charges, which will depend on the distance, will be applicable from 0001 hours on April 2. The fuel charge will be ₹275 for domestic flights on routes that are 0-500 kms long and ₹400 for flights that fly 501-1,000 kms.

The amount will be ₹600 for 1,001-1,500 kms, ₹800 for 1,501-2,000 kms and ₹950 for distances above 2,000 kms. Currently, the airline levies a flat fuel charge on domestic flight tickets.

The airline said it was thankful to the government for the timely intervention, without which April 2026 fuel cost increases would have severely impacted the affordability of domestic air travel.

FROM PAGE - 1

requiring prior Central government approval before any investigation into FCRA offences by law enforcement or state agencies, and a reduction in the maximum imprisonment term for violations from five years to one year.

The government has maintained that the amendments address existing legal gaps in asset management, strengthen oversight, prevent misuse of foreign funds, and enhance transparency and national security. India receives nearly ₹22,000 crores in foreign contributions annually through around 16,000 registered organisations. Meanwhile, the Parliament witnessed a ruckus as opposition parties, including the Congress, Left parties, and Trinamool Congress, staged a visible protest on Wednesday at Makar Dwar in the Parliament premises, holding banners and demanding the immediate withdrawal of the Bill. They described the FCRA Bill as 'draconian' and an attempt to grant sweeping executive powers that could lead to arbitrary action. Strident criticism has also come from church groups and minority organisations, particularly in Kerala, where the Assembly elections are due on April 9, 2026. The Kerala Catholic Bishops' Council and the Catholic Bishops' Conference of India termed the Bill "dangerous, undemocratic, unconstitutional and contrary to natural justice," fearing it could target foreign-funded educational, medical, and welfare institutions run by Christian organisations.

Leaders such as Congress' Manish Tiwari and KC Venugopal in the Lok Sabha, accused the government of excessive delegation of powers and pushing the legislation at a politically sensitive time. Kerala Chief Minister Pinarayi Vijayan (CPI-M) also urged Prime Minister Narendra Modi to withdraw the Bill.

Responding to the allegations hurled at the Treasury Benches, the Parliamentary Affairs Minister Kiren Rijiju defended the move, stating that the Bill was aimed at regulating foreign funds in the national interest and not targeting any religion or community. He accused the Opposition of misleading voters in Kerala for electoral gains. He said that though the Bill had been listed in Wednesday's official agenda for the Lok Sabha, it was not being taken up for discussion on the day. Despite putting it on hold, the Narendra Modi Government has not withdrawn the Bill outright. The pause is seen as a temporary measure to allow tempers to cool amid the ongoing Budget Session disruptions.

The development has come against the backdrop of repeated FCRA scrutiny in recent years, with the government having cancelled or suspended licences of several NGOs over alleged violations. The Bill's fate now remains uncertain, with both sides gearing up for further debate once Parliament resumes normal proceedings.

LS clears Amaravati as AP's sole capital

Earlier, initiating the debate on the bill, Congress MP Manickam Tagore said his party fully supports the legislation but wants special status for Andhra Pradesh. "Let Amaravati develop like Bengaluru, Chennai or Hyderabad. Let Vishakhapatnam, Tirupati and Kurnool also develop. We support Amaravati as the permanent capital of Andhra Pradesh," he said.

Participating in the debate, TDP member and Union Minister of State for Rural Development and Communications Chandra Sekhar Pemmasani appealed to the House to pass the bill unanimously as it will ensure a permanent capital for Andhra Pradesh.

Supporting the bill, BJP member C M Ramesh said this is the first time in the history of independent India that a bill has been brought to Parliament to declare a particular place as the

capital of a state. During his tenure as chief minister, YSRCP leader Jagan Mohan Reddy had announced that Andhra Pradesh would have three capitals — administrative capital at Visakhapatnam, legislative capital at Amaravati and judicial capital at Kurnool — instead of a single capital city at Amaravati. After N Chandrababu Naidu returned to power in 2024, he announced that Amaravati would be the sole capital of the state. YSR Congress Party strongly opposed the legislation. YSRCP member P V Midhun Reddy said 34,000 acres were acquired by the state government for the development of Amaravati as the capital with the promise of giving free developed plots, a housing scheme and free education for the children of the affected people. However, nothing has been given to them so far.

According to the Bill circulated among Lok Sabha members, the provisions of the 2014 Andhra Pradesh Reorganisation Act provide that on and from the appointed day, Hyderabad will be the common capital for Telangana and Andhra Pradesh for a period not exceeding 10 years. After which, Hyderabad will be the capital of Telangana, and there will be a new capital for the successor state of Andhra Pradesh. After the reorganisation law came into being, the Andhra Pradesh government, "after due consideration, consultation, and planning, identified and notified 'Amaravati' as the new capital of that state," the bill noted.

Once the Bill becomes an Act, Amravati will be legally recognised as the capital of Andhra Pradesh with effect from June 2, 2024. It said significant administrative and legislative measures have been undertaken, besides the infrastructural developments in and around Amaravati, with the objective of establishing it as the capital of Andhra Pradesh.

It observed that on March 28, the state legislative assembly passed a resolution requesting the Centre to amend Section 5 of the Reorganisation Act to incorporate the name of "Amaravati" as the new capital of Andhra Pradesh.

The many faces of a 'master of mischief'...

Alarming, the emails were not limited to India; Louis also sent threats to some cities in other countries, underscoring the wide geographical reach of his activities. Multiple states have now approached the Delhi Police seeking transit remand to interrogate the accused in connection with similar cases registered in their jurisdictions. Authorities are working to link various First Information Reports (FIRs) filed across the country based on hoax calls made by Louis.

He is currently in police custody. Delhi Police describe him as technically smart, he allegedly used VPNs, IP spoofing, fake email IDs (reports mention dozens), and possibly dark-web tools to hide his tracks. IP concealment is a powerful privacy tool used daily by millions for legitimate reasons. When combined with other techniques, SIM changes, frequent relocation, disposable accounts, it can make tracing very difficult. His mobile phone and other electronic devices have been seized and sent for forensic examination. Police plan to take him back to Mysuru to recover additional digital evidence and devices allegedly used in the offences. Officers seized multiple mobile phones and electronic devices, which are now under forensic analysis.

"Further disclosures are expected following the forensic analysis, which may shed more light on the full extent of his activities and the techniques used to mask his digital footprint," officials involved in the investigation said. The case has highlighted the growing challenge of

States Focus

Local Body polls announced in Gujarat; voting on April 26

The State Election Commissioner of Gujarat, S Murali Krishna, has announced the schedule for local self-Government elections in the State. Voting will be held on April 26, while counting of votes will take place on April 28. The Model Code of Conduct has come into force with immediate effect. Elections will be conducted for 34 District Panchayats, 260 Taluka Panchayats, 95 Municipalities, and 15 Municipal Corporations. The official notification will be issued on April 9, 2026. The last date for filing nominations is April 11, while scrutiny of nomination papers will be held on April 13. Candidates may withdraw their nominations until April 15. Polling will take place on Sunday, April 26, from 7 am to 6 pm. Approximately 4.18 crore voters are expected to exercise their franchise, with around 9,992 candidates contesting across the State.

CM flags off Hanuman Jayanti procession in Ahmedabad

On the occasion of Hanuman Jayanti, Gujarat Chief Minister Bhupendra Patel flagged off a grand procession from the renowned Camp Hanuman Temple in Shahibaug, Ahmedabad. The celebrations began with a collective recitation of the Hanuman Chalisa in the morning. The Chief Minister performed rituals, offered prayers, and inaugurated the procession by ceremonially launching the main chariot after performing *aarti* and offering coconut. The procession featured decorated elephants, camel carts, large symbolic maces, trucks, and a special tableau themed on "Operation Sindoor," which attracted significant attention.

CM inaugurates modern girls' hostel in Amreli district

Chief Minister Bhupendra Patel inaugurated a newly constructed, modern girls' hostel and dining facility at Devka Vidyapith in Rajula taluka of Amreli district. The event was held in the presence of noted spiritual leader and Bhagwat Kathakar Rameshbhai Oza (popularly known as Pujya Bhaishri), along with other dignitaries. Addressing the gathering, the CM emphasised that the foundation for girls' education in Gujarat was laid by Prime Minister Narendra Modi during his tenure as Chief Minister. The newly developed infrastructure includes a girls' hostel with a capacity of 1,100 beds and a modern building accommodating 580 students, aimed at promoting education among children from economically weaker sections.

tracing sophisticated cyber-enabled hoax threats that cause widespread panic and disrupt public institutions. In the Srinivas Louis case, despite him using multiple concealment methods, coordinated investigation, device seizure coupled with forensic analysis eventually led to his arrest in Mysuru, said a police official involved in the investigation.

"Hoax bomb threats like these are taken extremely seriously by authorities, leading to massive deployment of police, bomb squads, and disruption of normal activities in schools and courts. This case highlights both the ease of sending anonymous digital threats and the challenges in tracing them quickly," the police official added. Delhi Police have emphasized that such acts waste public resources and create unnecessary fear. Further investigation is going as the police are checking for any accomplices, exact number of emails, and full digital footprint. Louis remains in custody, and more details could emerge in the coming days. It's a stark reminder of how personal grievances can spill over into public harm.

Iran conflict may end soon, Trump says...

Press secretary Karoline Leavitt described the upcoming remarks as "an important update," but did not provide additional details on the content of the address. The announcement follows comments made by Trump on Tuesday, in which he expressed optimism about the duration of the conflict. The president stated that he expected the situation to be resolved within "two to three weeks," adding that U.S. involvement would be ending shortly. "We'll be leaving very soon," Trump said, while also suggesting that global energy markets would stabilize afterward. He predicted that gas prices would "come tumbling down" once the conflict subsides. Earlier, Trump also hinted at possible diplomatic openings, describing Iran's current leadership as comparatively less hard-line than its predecessors. However, he underscored that any ceasefire arrangement would hinge on the uninterrupted functioning of the Strait of Hormuz—a critical artery for global energy supplies.

Trump also downplayed concerns about the blockade of the Strait of Hormuz, a critical global shipping route through which approximately one-fifth of the world's oil supply passes. Despite the disruption, the president indicated that the United States would not play a role in addressing the situation. "We're not going to have anything to do with it," he said, adding that the issue would primarily affect other nations dependent on the route. On the other side, Iran's Foreign Minister Abbas Araghchi asserted that the strait lies within the territorial jurisdiction of Iran and Oman, and could be restricted for countries engaged in hostilities with Tehran. He described such measures as consistent with wartime norms.

Araghchi further noted that while some nations have held discussions with Iran regarding passage through the waterway, others have opted to avoid the route due to escalating security risks and rising insurance costs. The Strait of Hormuz remains a focal point of international concern, as its closure has raised fears of prolonged economic and energy impacts worldwide. Analysts and global leaders continue to monitor developments closely ahead of Trump's address. With tensions persisting, the situation remains dynamic, shaped by parallel military developments and ongoing diplomatic manoeuvres, with significant implications for regional stability and global energy markets.

Govt caps jet fuel hike; premium fuel,...

The prices of jet fuel were hiked by 5.7 per cent (₹5,244.75/kL) on March 1 as well. Separately, ATF price for domestic airlines was hiked by 8.6 per cent to ₹1.04 lakh/kL. Indian Oil revised the hike in the ATF prices in metros for domestic airlines in Delhi from ₹96,638.14/kL on March 1, 2026 to ₹1,04,927/kL on April 1, 2026.

The rising prices will further strain airlines

Congress will bring law to protect infiltrators: PM

TONY DAS ■ Guwahati

Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Wednesday alleged that the Congress, if it comes to power in Assam, will bring in a law to protect infiltrators, which the BJP and its allies will not allow. Addressing a poll rally at Gogamukh in Dhemaji district, Modi claimed that the Congress aims to “turn the majority community into a minority and create a permanent vote bank of infiltrators”.

Before the BJP came to power in 2014, the Congress had “tried to introduce a new law at the Centre”, but the NDA had opposed it, he said. “Congress leaders are openly saying that they will bring a new law in Assam to protect the infiltrators and are openly supporting them,” Modi said.

He also accused the grand old party of “trying to divide the country as the Muslim League did during Partition”.

“The Congress have also stabbed the Constitution prepared by Babasaheb Ambedkar,” Modi said.

“For the Congress, there are two families — one in Delhi and another in Assam, and their priority is the interest of their families and not that of the people”, the Prime Minister said.

He was alluding to the Gandhi family and that of state Congress president Gaurav Gogoi.

The Prime Minister said if the BJP returns to power, it will “implement the Uniform Civil Code and safeguard tribals under the Sixth schedule to protect Assam’s identity”.

“The BJP’s 10-year rule heralded a new dawn of ‘seva’ (service) and ‘sushasan’ (good governance) in Assam,” he said. The PM asserted that all are saying that only the BJP-led NDA can build modern infrastructure in Assam.

Modi claimed that the Congress had only built three bridges over the Brahmaputra



PM Narendra Modi attending the Assam BJP's Vijay Sankalp Samaroh in Gogamukh, Assam

PIONEER PHOTO

river in 60-65 years, while “the BJP has constructed five bridges in ten years, which has made the lives and livelihoods of people much easier”.

“It is not that Assam lacks resources, but the Congress, in its quest for power, divided the Assamese society and

did not let the people of the two banks of the Brahmaputra river meet. The NDA Government understood the pain and hardships, and took the initiative of building bridges,” Modi said.

He also assured the people that the Subansiri hydroelec-

tric project will protect Assam from floods.

The BJP, in its manifesto, has announced projects worth around ₹1,800 crore to make Assam free from the deluge, Modi said.

He claimed that more than 22 lakh poor families have

been given pucca houses in the last 10 years of the BJP rule, and the party guarantees to provide the same to 15 lakh more families.

Modi asserted that the BJP’s double-engine Government will ensure 40 lakh women become ‘Lakhpati’ from the present count of three lakh.

The PM pointed out that the BJP’s manifesto has created a roadmap for more Government jobs and self-employment opportunities.

He urged the people to vote for the BJP-led NDA in the assembly polls and said, “Modi guarantees that he will ensure Assam’s progress further”.

“The BJP will make a hat-trick in Assam elections with people’s blessings, whereas the Congress will make a century of defeats in elections,” he added.

Elections to Assam’s 126 assembly constituencies will be held on April 9, with counting of votes on May 4.

Democratic practices rooted in India’s ethos: VP

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ New Delhi

Vice President CP Radhakrishnan on Wednesday said democratic practices in India have been continuous, inclusive, and deeply rooted in society as part of a broader civilisational ethos that values dialogue, consensus, and respect for diverse opinions.

In his address in the Parliament complex after releasing a book “Tides of Time: Bharat’s History through Murals in Parliament”, authored by Rajya Sabha member Sudha Murty, he highlighted that from Vaishali in the north to the Kudavolai system in the south, democratic practices in India have been continuous, inclusive, and deeply rooted in society.

Lok Sabha Speaker Om Birla was also present at the event. The book is a publication of the Lok Sabha Secretariat.

Radhakrishnan, also Chairman of the Rajya Sabha, said these traditions are part

of a broader civilizational ethos that values dialogue, consensus, and respect for diverse opinions, making India the mother of democracy.

He said the murals in Samvidhan Sadan (the old Parliament House building) are not merely works of art but visual narratives reflecting India’s civilisational journey.

Quoting the great Tamil poet Subramania Bharati, the vice president underlined the richness of India’s wisdom, dignity, charity, and cultural depth, noting that such a foundation naturally fosters inclusiveness and respect for all voices.

He appreciated the integration of traditional symbols in the Parliament building.

He also referred to the ceremonial display of the sacred Sengol of the Chola dynasty during the President’s address to a joint sitting of Parliament, describing it as a powerful symbol connecting modern India with its civilisational roots.



VP CP Radhakrishnan, Lok Sabha Speaker Om Birla, Deputy Chairman of the Rajya Sabha Harivansh Narayan Singh, Secretary General of the Rajya Sabha Pramod Chandra Mody, Secretary General of the Lok Sabha Utpal Kumar Singh, and MP Sudha Murty during the launch of Murty’s book “Tides of Time” in New Delhi on Wednesday

PTI

Lt Gen Dhiraj Seth assumes role as Vice Chief of Army Staff

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ New Delhi

Lieutenant General Dhiraj Seth on Wednesday here took charge as the Vice Chief of the Army Staff on Wednesday. The decorated military officer succeeds Lt General Pushendra Singh.

At a ceremony held on the South Block lawns, the general officer reviewed a guard of honour as he assumed the key leadership post in the Indian Army.

A day earlier, Lt Gen. Seth relinquished his previous appointment as the general officer commanding-in-chief of the Southern Command.

He also laid a wreath at the Southern Command War Memorial to honour the sac-



Lt Gen Dhiraj Seth took over as Vice Chief of the Indian Army

PTI

rifices made by soldiers.

In his message to all ranks of the Pune-based command, the general officer exhorted them to sustain its operational edge by embracing technology absorption, refining warfighting competencies for multi-domain opera-

tions and strengthening the foundations of a future-ready force, officials said.

Lt Gen. Seth served as the 51st general officer commanding-in-chief of the elite Southern Command from July 1, 2024, to March 31 this year.

When India carried out Operation Sindoor — the decisive military action in the wake of the Pahalgam terror attack — last year, Lt Gen. Seth was at the helm of the Southern Command.

Along with two other top officers from the Navy and Air Force, he also witnessed the key tri-services exercise, “Trishul”, held off Gujarat’s Porbandar coast in November last year.

An alumnus of the National Defence Academy (NDA),

Khadakwasla, and Indian Military Academy, Dehradun, Lt Gen. Seth was commissioned into the 2nd Lancers on December 20, 1986.

The general officer has commanded the Skinner’s Horse, 98 Armoured Brigade, Counter Insurgency Uniform Force, 21 Corps and Delhi Area.

He has been an instructor and assistant adjutant at the NDA and the chief instructor at the School of Armoured Warfare, Armoured Corps Centre and School, Ahmednagar.

Lt Gen Seth has served with the United Nations Angola Verification Mission (UNAVEM-III) from 1995-96 as the operation officer, the officials said.

26 Maoist attacks reported in 2026, 52 Naxals killed: Rajya Sabha

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ New Delhi

As many as 26 incidents of violence perpetrated by Maoists have been reported in the country this year as of March 15, resulting in deaths of five civilians, one security force personnel and 52 Naxals, the Rajya Sabha was informed on Wednesday.

In a written reply, Minister of State for Home Affairs Nityanand Rai said, “The number of Left Wing Extremists (LWE)-affected districts reduced gradually from 126 in 2013 to two in March, 2026. 01 district has been kept under the category of ‘District of Concern’,

where the violent activities of LWE have been brought under control, but a very small number of cadres are still present. These districts are on the verge of becoming free from LWE.”

“Presently, 35 districts are categorized as ‘Legacy & Thrust’ districts, which are no more LWE affected, but support to these districts is required for consolidating the position and continued support in respect of security and development measures for some more time. 04 districts of Bihar (Aurangabad, Gaya, Jamui, Lakhisarai) are categorized as Legacy & Thrust districts,” he said.



Union Minister of State for Home Affairs Nityanand Rai speaks in the Lok Sabha during the second part of the Budget session of Parliament in New Delhi on Wednesday

PTI

The LWE perpetrated violence incidents have come down from high of 1936 in year 2010 by 88 per cent to 234 in 2025, he said.

“Resultant deaths of Civilians & Security Forces have also come down from high of 1005 in year 2010 by 90 per cent to 100 in year

2025. In 2025, security forces have neutralized 364 Naxals, arrested 1022 and facilitated 2337 surrenders. The number of Police Stations reporting LWE related violence has significantly reduced from 465 Police Stations in 2010 to 119 Police Stations in the year 2025,” Rai said.

The minister said there has been a special focus on the financial choking of LWEs and the unearthing of the nexus between CPI (Maoists) and its financial supporters. For effective action towards choking of funds and other resources to LWE, coordinated actions are being taken by state police in cooperation with central agencies by various means.

Govt plans Lok Sabha seat hike, women’s quota bill in April session

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ New Delhi

The Budget session of Parliament is unlikely to be adjourned sine die on Thursday as the Government is planning to summon it again for two-three days during the second fortnight of April to bring a bill to increase the number of Lok Sabha seats to 816 so that 273 of them could be reserved for women.

The budget session, which started on January 28, was supposed to end on April 2 but the Government is contemplating to extend it for two-three more days, albeit with a gap. Sources said chair of both Lok Sabha and Rajya Sabha are likely to adjourn the respective houses and make the announcement that it would meet on a specific date.

“The House will not be adjourned sine die but will be adjourned with the announcement that it will meet again on a specific date. We will meet again very soon, in this month itself,” sources said.



During the extended period, the Government is expected to table the Constitution amendment bill that will tweak the Nari Shakti Vandan Adhiniyam, commonly known as women’s reservation law, in Parliament.

Home Minister Amit Shah discussed the plan with some NDA constituents and some non-Congress Opposition floor leaders. But consultations with the principal Opposition party Congress and another major party TMC were yet to take place.

The provision to provide 33 per cent reservation to women in Lok Sabha and state assemblies was brought by amending the Constitution in 2023, but it will come into effect after the completion of the delimitation exercise.

Rare earth corridors to boost domestic supply: Jitendra Singh

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ New Delhi

The dedicated rare earth corridors proposed in Odisha, Kerala, Andhra Pradesh, and Tamil Nadu aim to reduce import dependence and enhance domestic capability in the strategic sector, Union Minister Jitendra Singh said on Wednesday.

In a written reply to a question in the Lok Sabha, the minister said the corridors would focus on mining, processing, research, and manufactur-



ing and help align these initiatives with national priorities, such as becoming self-reliant and achieving net-zero emissions by 2070.

“India’s import reliance on key minerals used for the production of items in strategic sectors such as electronics, renewable

energy, electric vehicles, and defence manufacturing can be regulated through the RE corridor by boosting local sourcing enhancing strategic self-reliance,” Singh said.

The minister also stated that a joint working group (JWG) consisting of members representing all stakeholders had been constituted for formulation of guidelines (SOP) to establish dedicated rare earth corridors in the identified states.

“The JWG is expected to examine all aspects before finalising the SOP,” he added.

J&K Police file chargesheet against 2 for social media conspiracy

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Jammu

A Counter Intelligence wing of Jammu and Kashmir police on Wednesday filed a chargesheet against two accused persons before a designated NIA court in Srinagar, alleging their involvement in a conspiracy to misuse social media platforms for spreading fabricated narratives, promoting separatist ideology, and attempting to disturb public order in the region.

According to a statement issued by the Counter Intelligence Kashmir (CIK), on 01 April 2026, CIK produced a charge sheet (challan) before the Court of the Special Judge



designated under the NIA Act, Srinagar, against the accused namely Dr. Umer Farooq Bhat, S/o Farooq Ahmad Bhat, R/o Bugam, Kulgam and Shahzada Akther, W/o Dr. Umer Farooq Bhat, R/o Bugam, Kulgam

in connection with FIR No. 05/2025 registered at Police

Station CIK Srinagar under Sections 152, 62(2) of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita (BNS) and Sections 13, 38, 39 of the Unlawful Activities (Prevention) Act (UA(P) Act), it reads.

The case was registered on the basis of credible and reliable information indicating that accused Shahzada Akther,

in a well-planned criminal conspiracy with members of the proscribed terrorist organisation Dukhtaran-e-Millat, and in active connivance with her husband Dr. Umer Farooq Bhat, was involved in the deliberate creation and dissemination of false, fabricated, and distorted narratives regarding the situation in Kashmir, it reads.

Investigation revealed that the accused persons, acting in concert with members of the proscribed organisation, were engaged in the misuse of social media platforms, including encrypted messaging applications, to manipulate facts and spread misleading information.

Govt warns GLP-1 weight loss drugs have serious side effects

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ New Delhi

The GLP-1-based weight loss drugs are prescription medications used to treat type 2 diabetes and obesity, but carry serious side effects and must only be taken under the supervision of a qualified medical specialist, the Government said on Wednesday.

Highlighting that multiple variants of GLP-1 drugs have been recently introduced in the Indian market, and concerns have emerged regarding their on-demand availability through retail pharmacies,



online platforms, wholesalers, and wellness clinics, the Government said the CDSCO has intensified its regulatory surveillance against its unauthorised sale and promotion and warned stricter inspections and surveillance will continue in the coming weeks. “Businesses that break

the rules will face license cancellation, fines, and legal action,” it said.

The GLP-1 drugs (glucagon-like peptide-1 receptor agonists) are developed to treat both type 2 diabetes and obesity by correcting hormonal imbalance - stimulating insulin release and suppressing excess

glucagon — to bring blood sugar back under control.

The drugs regulate blood sugar and appetite and are also used to treat obesity. Essentially, they slow down the gastric emptying, increasing the feeling of fullness. This decreases patients’ appetites and thereby leads to their weight loss, an official statement said.

To prevent unauthorised sale, unsupervised use, and other malpractices, the Drug Controller of India has intensified its regulatory surveillance, warning that the drugs can lead to serious side effects if not taken under strict medical supervision, it said.

Former AAP leader HS Phoolka joins BJP

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ New Delhi

Senior Supreme Court advocate and former Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) leader HS Phoolka, best known for representing 1984 anti-Sikh riots victims in their quest for justice, joined the BJP on Wednesday. The move is being seen as a shot in the BJP’s arm as it gears up to oust the AAP Government from Punjab in the Assembly polls due next year.

Phoolka joined the party in the presence of Union Minister Hardeep Singh Puri, Delhi minister Manjinder Singh Sirsa, BJP national general secretary Tarun Chugh, Punjab unit chief



Sunil Jakhar and party chief spokesperson Anil Baluni.

Welcoming Phoolka into the BJP fold, Puri said his induction would add strength to the party.

“His joining will further strengthen the party and our efforts in Punjab,” he said, describing Phoolka’s entry as a significant addition to the party’s commitment to justice and accountability and citing his contribution in helping victims of the riots get justice. Chugh also expressed confidence that his entry would bolster the BJP’s organisation in the state.

The BJP, Phoolka said, had consistently backed his legal fight for the victims of the 1984 anti-Sikh violence. Only the BJP under Prime Minister Narendra Modi can address the challenges Punjab is facing under the AAP rule, he added.

States Focus



TMC USED MUSLIMS FOR VOTES IN BENGAL: AIMIM CHIEF OWAIISI

AIMIM chief Asaduddin Owaisi on Wednesday alleged that the ruling TMC and other parties used Muslims for votes in Bengal, but did nothing for the community's development. Owaisi, addressing a poll rally at Naowda in support of candidates of Humayun Kabir-led AJUP, also claimed that in the past 50 years, members of the Muslim community had voted for the Congress, Left Front and the TMC, but their condition did not improve. "For the sake of Muslims in West Bengal getting greater representation in political decision making, and for their true development, we have joined hands with Kabir. Together, we will give a jolt to Mamata Banerjee and her party," he asserted.



DMK-LED ALLIANCE SET FOR COMFORTABLE VICTORY: SURVEY

A ground survey by independent research group, Lok Poll, projects a comfortable victory for the DMK-led alliance in the upcoming 2026 Tamil Nadu Assembly Elections. The survey, released on Wednesday, claimed to have utilised stratified random sampling across a sample size of 1,17,000 respondents (approximately 500 per constituency). It predicts the DMK-led alliance will secure between 181-189 seats with a dominant 40.1 per cent vote share. The ADMK-led alliance is projected to bag 38-42 seats with a 29 per cent vote share, while actor Vijay's TVK is expected to make its debut with 8-10 seats and a significant 23.9 per cent vote share.

ECI officers entrusted to reject TMC nominations: CM Mamata

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Kolkata

Trinamool Congress supremo Mamata Banerjee on Wednesday alleged that newly appointed officials by the Election Commission of India (ECI) were entrusted to reject nominations of her party candidates and urged them to be cautious while filing their nominations.

Addressing a poll rally at Nanoor in Birbhum district of West Bengal, Banerjee also lashed out at the BJP for allegedly misusing central agencies for its political benefit.

"Everything has been changed; it's a new setup here. The newly appointed officers by the ECI are entrusted to reject your nomination; so be cautious while filing your nominations," Banerjee



West Bengal CM Mamata Banerjee greets the gathering during a public rally ahead of the State Assembly elections in Birbhum on Wednesday

PTI

said at the rally.

The West Bengal chief minister also urged people, especially women, not to vote for the BJP.

"They (BJP) are anti-women,

that's why their names are being deleted in SIR citing logical discrepancy," she said.

Banerjee also welcomed the Supreme Court's observations on SIR and said that she

was "happy" with it.

Earlier in the day, the apex court said the appellate tribunals will be deciding appeals that will be filed by the persons whose names have been excluded from the voter lists and those of the authorities of the poll panel against the alleged wrongful inclusions.

Later, speaking at another rally in Burwan, the CM alleged that the BJP was asking people for their bank account numbers and cautioned them not to share them.

"This is the game plan of the BJP — to pay people cash before the elections and then make a fool of them after the polls," she said.

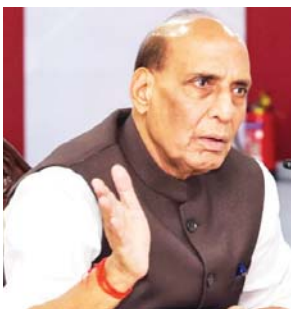
The elections to the 294-member West Bengal assembly will be held in two phases — on April 23 and 29. Votes will be counted on May 4.

Rajnath slams State Govt, says 'God not safe in Kerala' over Sabarimala row

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Kochi

Senior BJP leader and Defence Minister Rajnath Singh on Wednesday launched a scathing attack on the ruling LDF in poll-bound Kerala, alleging that "God was not secure" in the State known as God's own country, as the Left front betrayed Lord Ayyappa for a few pieces of gold — a reference to the Sabarimala gold loss cases.

Singh, speaking at a public meeting in Paravur assembly constituency as part of the BJP-led NDA's poll campaign, said that "just like Judas betrayed Jesus Christ for a few pieces of silver, the LDF



has betrayed Lord Ayyappa for a few pieces of gold".

He contended that if this was the plight of God, the situation of the common people would be much worse and assured that there would be a time-bound CBI probe into the alleged misappropriation of gold from the shrine

when the BJP-led NDA comes to power in Kerala.

He demanded that the Kerala Government should explain how there was a lapse in safeguarding gold of the Sabarimala shrine, and said that it amounted to betrayal of the religious beliefs of devotees which cannot be countenanced.

"Those who stole the gold from the doors of the Sabarimala shrine, will be shown the door by the people of Kerala," he asserted.

Singh also alleged that while some CPI(M) leaders stole the gold from the shrine, certain Congress leaders helped them sell it, "which

shows that both LDF and UDF are the same".

The senior BJP leader also accused the Left Democratic Front (LDF) and the United Democratic Front (UDF) of betraying the people of Kerala, dividing society, "destroying" the state's economy and not fulfilling their promises to the public.

Under the successive rule of LDF and UDF, the debt on Kerala has risen to nearly Rs five lakh crore now, he claimed.

He said that while both fronts accuse the Centre of withholding funds to Kerala, the BJP Government between 2014 and 2024 has given ₹1.5 lakh crore to the state.

BJP releases chargesheet against DMK over corruption

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Chennai

BJP's Tamil Nadu election in-charge Piyush Goyal released a "chargesheet" that accused the DMK Government of systemic corruption, financial mismanagement, and harbouring an explicit anti-Hindu bias. BJP also accused the State Government of illegal sand mining and deep-rooted graft across departments.

Unveiled at the BJP State headquarters in Chennai on March 31, the chargesheet alleged that there were "massive irregularities" in the DMK regime, including over ₹1 lakh crore in State liquor marketing operations, thousands of crores in highway tenders, and wide-

spread municipal scams. The "chargesheet" claimed the financial health of the State has collapsed, with the total debt burden surging past ₹10 lakh crore.

The "chargesheet" accused Chief Minister MK Stalin's administration of systemic corruption, financial mismanagement.

Challenging the ruling party on its electoral pledges, the BJP document asserted that the Government failed to fulfil over seventy per cent of its promises.

It claimed the administration abandoned commitments to reduce fuel prices, provide cooking gas subsidies, and cancel the NEET examination. Furthermore, it accused the Government of betraying women by scrap-



ping popular welfare schemes introduced during the previous regime, such as gold for marriage and subsidised two-wheelers. A significant portion of the BJP's list of charges targeted the ruling alliance for what it termed an anti-Hindu ideology. It compiled quotes

attributed to prominent leaders, claiming a sustained campaign to insult the faith of the majority, referencing alleged derogatory remarks regarding Sanatana Dharma and Hindu deities.

Additionally, the chargesheet alleged severe failures in social justice, citing a significant increase in crimes against Scheduled Castes and highlighting the delayed investigation into the Vengaiyaval incident (in December 2022, residents of Vengaiyaval, alleged that human faces had been dumped into overhead drinking water tank that supplied water to the Dalit neighbourhood) to claim the administration has failed marginalised communities in the state.

CM Stalin accuses BJP of plotting violence in Tamil Nadu

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Tiruchirappalli (Tamil Nadu)

Chief Minister MK Stalin on Wednesday accused the BJP of conspiring to carry out violence in Tamil Nadu, allegedly on the lines of Uttar Pradesh and Manipur and asserted that it was outmanoeuvred.

Addressing a DMK rally here for the upcoming Assembly polls, Stalin, the president of the ruling DMK, listed schemes implemented in Tiruchirappalli region by his Government.

He referred to initiatives including Panchapur bus terminus, mini-stadium, jallikattu arena, model schools and combined drinking water schemes. Soon after his party forms Government again, a mega library named after

Kamarajar, a TIDEL park and an Olympic Academy will be inaugurated in the region, and Tiruchirappalli's development is a challenge to the Capital city of Chennai, he said.

During the past 5 years, for Tiruchirappalli, ₹26,066 crore worth of projects have been completed and "that is why I have come seeking your votes," Stalin said.

Asserting that his regime successfully implemented assurances made ahead of the 2021 Assembly polls, including fare-free travel for women in buses, he underscored that 9 lakh students received an assistance of ₹1,000 per month for higher education.

In January this year, a ₹3,000 cash gift was provided to all rice ration card-holders for the harvest festival Pongal.



He referred to the disbursement of ₹5,000 to 1.31 crore women beneficiaries in February — ₹1,000 assistance per month; provided for 3 months in advance in addition to ₹2,000 summer grant — and the assured pension plan announced for State Government employees (TAPS).

BJP CONSPIRACIES WILL FAIL: DEPUTY CM

Tirupattur: Tamil Nadu Deputy CM Udhayanidhi Stalin on Wednesday said the BJP's "conspiracies" will be defeated and TN team will ensure a win in the April 23 election. Campaigning for the party candidates in Natrampalli and Vaniyambadi in Tirupattur district, he said the BJP was aware that it cannot win at the hustings and so was planning to make an entry through the polls. "We will defeat the conspiracies of the BJP which wants to rule Tamil Nadu from Delhi with old and new slaves, in the 2026 Assembly elections," Udhayanidhi said.

Security forces neutralise terrorist in Ganderbal operation

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Jammu

In the ongoing anti terrorist operation in the central Kashmir district of Ganderbal, a joint team of security forces Wednesday neutralised one unidentified terrorist without suffering any collateral damage.

Srinagar based Chinara Corps Wednesday posted on X, "During the night of 31 Mar 26, the cordon was tactically reorganised amidst the intermittent firing underway. Own troops effectively retaliated with calibrated response resulting in one terrorist eliminated".

A joint operation was launched by the Army and J&K Police on the basis of specific input about the presence of terrorists in the Arhama area of Ganderbal late



A security personnel stands guard during a search operation in Ganderbal, Jammu and Kashmir on Wednesday

PTI

Tuesday evening.

According to a statement of the Indian Army, as the alert troops reached the suspected spot during the cordon and search operation, the hiding terrorists resorted to indiscriminate firing, ensuing in a fierce encounter between the security forces and the terrorists.

The spokesperson further said, during last night the cordon was tactically reorganised amidst the intermittent firing underway.

The calibrated response of the security forces resulted in the elimination of one unidentified terrorist. There are no reports of any casualties from the security forces' side. Till the time of filing the report the operation was in progress.

Karnataka CM predicts Congress's victory in bypolls

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Davanagere (Karnataka)

Karnataka Chief Minister Siddaramaiah on Wednesday expressed confidence that Congress candidates will win both the Bagalkot and Davanagere South assembly bypolls in the State by a huge margin, as the Government's five guarantee schemes will help the party.

Asserting that Karnataka's economy is in good shape, he accused the BJP of making negative statements for political gain. The CM is in Davanagere to campaign for Congress candidate Samarth Mallikarjun, after campaigning for Umesh Meti in the Bagalkot segment for the last two days.

Bypolls for the Bagalkot and Davanagere South Assembly con-



stituencies will be held on April 9.

"I'm confident that we will win in both constituencies by a big margin because of our Government's good work. Our guarantee schemes ('Shakti', 'Gruha Lakshmi', 'Gruha Jyoti', 'Yuva Nidhi' and 'Anna Bhagya') are helping us. The BJP opposed guarantee schemes because they are programmes for the poor and they always oppose such initiatives," Siddaramaiah said.

The PM was seen walking along with 19 women workers and plucking tea leaves as taught by the labourers.

"Today, in a tea garden in the morning in Dibrugarh, one gets a glimpse of the culture of the tea garden families. Their contribution to Assam's progress is unparalleled," he said.

Modi, in another post on the social media platform, said, "We are very proud of the efforts of each and every tea garden family. Their hard work and perseverance have enhanced Assam's pride."

He also asked the women if their children were studying, and they replied in the affirmative.

Responding to a query from the Prime Minister about whether their children are engaged in sports, the women labourers said several of their wards were interested in playing football.

"The women at the tea garden in Dibrugarh sang a song, which pays homage to 'Jagat Janani Maa'. It is amazing how they remain so connected with their culture and roots," the PM said.

Priyanka Gandhi slams Himanta, says one family looting Assam

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Guwahati

Congress leader Priyanka Gandhi Vadra on Wednesday slammed Assam Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma and alleged that "only one family is looting" everything in the resource-rich state, while the people "don't have anything". Vadra also alleged that the BJP Government is functioning by threatening the people.

Addressing an election rally at Nazira in support of Leader of the opposition and party candidate, Debabrata Saikia, she launched a scathing attack on Prime Minister Narendra Modi and charged him with

Vadra claimed.

She also attacked the BJP Government for failing to fulfil the promise of hiking daily wages of tea garden workers and stressed that the people from the gardens are struggling in the same way.

"Various tribal communities have been demanding ST status for years. The BJP had promised to accord ST status to them, but they failed to give it," the Lok Sabha MP said.

She also alleged that women of Assam are forced to attend the rallies of the PM and CM with threats that their names will be removed from various Government schemes, especially the flagship poverty alleviation



being a "slave" of the US.

"One family is looting everything in Assam. And when they are not looting, mines, lands and every other asset are being handed over to big industrialists," Vadra claimed.

Alleging massive corruption on every front during the BJP-led Government in Assam, she raked up several old scams such as Sarada, Smart City and NC Hills.

"The BJP said they have given a double-engine Government. In reality, it is a double-ghulami (slavery) Government. PM Modi is engaged in slavery of the US, and Himanta Biswa Sarma is engaged in slavery of Modi,"

scheme 'Orunodoi'.

"PM Modi and CM Himanta are ruling the country and State with fear and threats. Our fight is against that fear, and for protecting Assam's culture and civilisation," Vadra asserted.

Addressing her second election rally at Tingkhong in support of her party candidate Bipul Gogoi, Vadra said Assam has land, mines, history, nature, forest and every other resource.

"This land has given you everything. But still the people don't have anything. Only one family is prospering in Assam," she told the gathering.

PM Modi visits Assam tea gardens, plucks leaves with workers

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Guwahati

Prime Minister Narendra Modi visited a tea garden in Dibrugarh district in poll-bound Assam on Wednesday and plucked leaves along with women workers.

Modi asserted that tea is the "soul of Assam", and described his visit to the estate, where he plucked the leaves and put them into a traditional basket, as a "memorable experience".

The PM also interacted with the women workers who

helped him learn how to pluck tea leaves.

He also called one of the women workers, attired in traditional white and red bordered sarees, his "guru".

"Tea is the soul of Assam! The tea from here has made its way across the world. This morning in Dibrugarh, I went to a tea garden and interacted with women working here. It was a very memorable experience," Modi posted on X.

He shared photographs and a video of his visit to the Manohari estate.



PM Modi with tea plantation workers in Assam on Wednesday

PIONEER PHOTO



Andhra Pradesh Chief Minister N Chandrababu Naidu with others during a meeting on the Amaravati Quantum Valley in Amaravati

PTI



**TRANS GLOBE
ADVISORS**

**Your Trusted
Management
Advisory**

www.transglobeadvisors.in

Order Order

Delhi Court dismisses defamation case against Nirmala Sitharaman



Nirmala Sitharaman, Somnath Bharti

A Delhi court on Wednesday dismissed the criminal defamation complaint filed by ex-AAP MLA Somnath Bharti's wife against Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman, saying there was no imputation against the complainant. Additional Chief Judicial Magistrate Paras Dalal described the complaint as a 29-letter word "floccinaucinihilipilification", meaning something valueless or worthless, while observing that the "complaint is nothing but the word, wherein a valueless or worthless material has been stretched too long." The magistrate said Sitharaman's statements were nothing but political opposition and antagonism aimed at the Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) and the INDIA bloc.

The court said, "Nothing was aimed at the complainant Lipika Mitra (Bharti's wife), and there is no imputation against her. Since no prima facie offence has been made out from the complaint of facts, this court declines to take cognisance of the offence." The Magistrate said the necessary ingredients of criminal defamation were not made out. "The press conference and averments made by the respondent (Sitharaman) are nothing more than political discourse amongst rivals and competing parties," he said.

The complaint had claimed that Sitharaman made "defamatory, false and malicious statements" in a press conference on May 17, 2024, with the sole intention to tarnish the reputation of Bharti and weaken his chances of winning in the general elections. According to the complaint, the utterances were made "solely with an intent to hurt the complainant and her husband" for political gains to the BJP's candidate and political loss to the complainant's husband during the 2024 Lok Sabha election.

verka®			
THE PUNJAB STATE COOPERATIVE MILK PRODUCERS FEDERATION LTD.			
SCO 153-155, SECTOR 34-A, CHANDIGARH-160022. EPABX No. 0172-5041812,66			
Notice Inviting Tender			
www.verka.coop			
e tender are hereby Invited for the purchase and supply of following items:-			
Sr. No.	Name of Work/Item	Period/Tentative Qty	
1.	For Verka Head office, Chandigarh Construction of parking in front of New Milk Bar Complex at Verka Patiala Dairy.	Four Months	
2.	For Verka Mohali Dairy Hiring of Agency for packaging of dahi pouch/Cups/Matkas, Lassi pouches, Kheer cups, Ghee, Paneer and Yoghurt, Packaging and recombination of White Butter and Reconstitution of SMP.	As per day to day requirement of Market	
3.	For Verka Patiala Dairy Hiring of:- a) 1.5 MT insulated vehicle for transportation of Fresh Milk and Fresh Milk products for route no.8 Punjabi University, Tripuri, Urban estate, local Patiala etc. b) Private Car for quality control section.	One year	
4.	For Verka Sangrur Dairy Pest Control services	01.05.2026 to 30.04.2027	
5.	For Verka Ferozepur Dairy Hiring of:- a) Mahindra Pick up/ Maxi Truck or equivalent to lift can milk from various societies/ dairy farms to MCC/Milk plant. b) Ice-Factory for chilling of milk at or around Jalalabad. c) Providing of Un-skilled, Semi-skilled, Skilled, High skilled, A to D category workers & suitable/ eligible personal for different posts through outsourcing.	Annual/ 07 No's	
6.	For Verka Jalandhar Dairy a) Outsourcing the activity for housekeeping (Sanitation & Cleaning) and Horticulture work. b) Ventilation Fan (Motor 1.5 HP) c) Steam Coal having calorific value not less than 5500 kcal/kg.	02 Years/ 01 No. 02 Years	
7.	For Verka Hoshiarpur Dairy Hiring of vehicle for supply of LN2 Gas and A.L. activities and other works related to procurement section.	100 No's 2000 MT (700-800 MT per month)	
8.	For Verka Gurdaspur Dairy a) Operation, repair & maintenance of pouch packing machines (Milk, Lassi & Dahi) online coding machines, photocell sensors and crate washers. b) Labour contract for different outsource jobs in production section, engineering section, marketing section, cleaning & housekeeping of factory. c) e-Auction for old unserviceable items, old gatta and LDPE film etc. d) Supply, installations & commissioning of condensate recovery unit for wood/biomass briquettes fired boiler capacity 3TPH. e) Hiring of Diesel car (5 Seater Bolero Camper or its equivalent). f) Supply & Installations of new puff panel for new dahi incubation room.	30,000 Ltr to 50,000 Ltr per day Annual	
9.	For Verka Amritsar Dairy Hiring of:- a) Route vehicle for lifting of milk from DCS to MCC capacity- 01 ton to 02 ton. b) Insulated single portion road Milk tankers (capacity- 10000 Ltrs) for transportation of milk from BMC/ MCC.	01 No. 01 No. 01 No. 01 No.	
10.	For CFP, Bhatinda, Khanna Labour job contract for different activities for production section, store section and marketing section.	02 Years/ 06 No's	
11.	For CFP, Ghanina ke Banger Wall shop painting in the state of Punjab, Himachal Pradesh and Jammu & Kashmir (U.T.).	Annual	

NOTE:
1. For complete details regarding above tender (NT), please visit our website i.e. www.verka.coop & e Tendering portal i.e. eproc.punjab.gov.in.
2. Corrigendum, if any, will be uploaded on website only.

1018/12/2026-27/10107

General Manager (Purchase)

SC raps Union Govt for unnecessary appeals

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Rapping the Centre for getting into unnecessary litigation, the Supreme Court on Wednesday imposed costs of ₹25,000 on it for challenging a Punjab and Haryana High Court order setting aside a CISF official's dismissal. Upholding the High Court ruling, a bench of Justices BV Nagarathna and Ujjal Bhuyan also granted the official back wages after finding the punishment disproportionate.

"We fail to understand why the Union of India has challenged the order of the high court division bench. We hear pendency, pendency. Who is the biggest litigant? Cost should be imposed," Justice Nagarathna said.

"Why can't there be an opinion that if the high court found it disproportionate and granted relief, setting aside all the orders, we shall not go to the Supreme Court? He took medical leave, but he also had to deal with an elopement in his family," she observed.

Referring to her recent statement in a conference organised by the Supreme Court Bar Association about



Justice BV Nagarathna, Justice Ujjal Bhuyan

the Government being responsible for the backlog in cases, Justice Nagarathna said the court had taken the SCBA conference very seriously.

"It was not just to go to some resort and come back. We made preparations, and we did homework. We spoke. Not to forget," she said. There were two charges levelled against the CISF official — for absence from duty for 11 days, and that he had committed an act of indiscipline by conniving with a woman, the daughter of a CISF constable, to flee from Mumbai and attend her wedding with his younger brother. The High Court had noted that the absence period of 11

days was explained as the official was on sanctioned medical leave during such period. "With regard to the other charge of the lady running away with the brother of the respondent-petitioner, it has come on record that the lady herself appeared during the disciplinary proceedings and stated that she had no grievance against the respondent-petitioner.

"It is otherwise not in dispute that the brother of the respondent-petitioner had married the lady concerned. It has, therefore, been found that in fact there was no misconduct on the part of the respondent for which he could be removed from service," the high court said.

Bhojshala case: SC asks MP HC to consider objections to survey

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court on Wednesday said the Madhya Pradesh High Court will consider the objections raised by the Muslim side relating to the ongoing Archaeological Survey of India's survey, including videography and colour photographs of the disputed Bhojshala Temple-Kamal Maula Mosque premises in the State.



Bhojshala Temple-Kamal Maula Mosque premises

While the top court did not interfere with the High Court's proceedings, it emphasised that all objections regarding the scientific survey must be heard in accordance with the principles of natural justice.

A bench comprising Chief Justice Surya Kant and justices Joymalya Bagchi and Vipul M Pancholi heard senior advocate Salman

our objections," he said. The bench noted that the High Court had already addressed the procedural timeline for these objections. Justice Bagchi observed that while some objections were listed in the survey report, others remained to be addressed. He noted that the videography would be played in court, allowing all parties to contest its correctness.

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi High Court has directed the removal of 'defamatory' posts over the alleged molestation of a journalist on a flight, saying that using social media to circulate the allegations and reveal the identity of the perpetrator before any formal investigation was a severe transgression of his fundamental right to live with dignity and fair trial. Justice Vikas Mahajan, in an interim order passed on a lawsuit by the man, asked the woman journalist as well as certain online platforms not to publish the "defamatory allegations" against him till the next hearing in May.

The court said the narrative set by the media houses and digital platforms breached the contours of the FIR registered in the matter as they did not merely report the allegations in the FIR but prematurely adjudicated it by labelling the plaintiff a "culprit" and "molester". The court also expressed concern over a tweet by

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Mumbai

The Bombay High Court on Wednesday asked Editor Arnab Goswami and Republic to bring down the rhetoric during his reporting about industrialist Anil Ambani. While hearing Ambani's plea alleging defamation, Justice Milind Jadhav clarified that he was not stopping the media house from carrying any news story, although it should not have rhetoric. "Otherwise, I will pass the order. Of course, you are the fourth estate, but no adjectives which will be disparaging", the judge clarified.

At the end of the day, disparaging remarks are insinuating below the belt. There will be nothing below the belt. Please run your stories,

HC junks Anita Advani's plea seeking recognition of 'relationship' with Rajesh Khanna as marriage

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Mumbai

The Bombay High Court on Wednesday dismissed a plea filed by actor Anita Advani seeking recognition of her alleged relationship with late Bollywood superstar Rajesh Khanna as a marriage. A single bench of justice Sharmila Deshmukh dismissed the appeal filed by

Appellate tribunals to decide on pleas against exclusion or inclusion in Bengal SIR: SC

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Nineteen appellate tribunals headed by former chief justices and high court judges will decide on the pleas of those excluded from the voter list during the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of the electoral rolls in poll-bound West Bengal, the Supreme Court said on Wednesday. The court said the tribunals will also adjudicate upon the pleas of Election Commission (EC) officials, who may be aggrieved by the inclusion of persons in the voter list by adjudicating authorities, including 700 judicial officers from West Bengal, Odisha and Jharkhand.

A bench of Chief Justice Surya Kant and Justices Joymalya Bagchi and Vipul M Pancholi took note of two communications received from the chief justice of the Calcutta High Court, updating the progress of the exercise. Highlighting the "extraordinary exercise" of adjudicating the objections in the ongoing SIR process, the CJI said approximately 47.4 lakh objections out of a total of 60 lakh were disposed of as on March 31.

The bench said according to the communications received from the chief justice, "as on March 31, 2026



till 4:04 pm, 46,60,135 objections have been decided in the entire State, against the total number of 60,06,675 objections filed. We are informed that as of today, the disposal has crossed 47,30,000".

It noted that on March 20, the poll panel notified the constitution of 19 appellate tribunals that will be working from the Dr Shyama Prasad Mukherjee National Institute of Water and Sanitation, Diamond Harbour Road in Kolkata, an institute run by the Department of Drinking Water and Sanitation, Ministry of Jal Shakti, for the next eight weeks.

"It goes without saying that, as and when required, the Election Commission of India will either seek further extension from the Ministry of Jal Shakti and/or identify alternative premises in consultation with the parties," the bench said.

"We, however, clarify that, in any case, the appellate tribunals shall function at Kolkata," it said.

The bench said the chief justice of the high court has also highlighted the issue of alleged non-availability of "reasons" for the rejection of the objections by the adjudicating authority.

The poll panel assured the court that the tribunals will have access to the records of the parties before the judicial officers while deciding on the appeals against exclusion or inclusion from the voter list.

"To eliminate any doubt, we request the appellate tribunals to revisit the full records, including the reasons assigned by the judicial officers while adjudicating the objections, before making a decision on the appeals filed before them, and also to inform the parties of these reasons," the bench said.



Anil Ambani, Arnab Goswami

your stories are in fact what the nation wants to know," the judge said.

Ambani argued that the channel's reports on his financial transactions have caused irreparable damage to his reputation. "These are continuous, and it is like a smear campaign," said Ambani's lawyer, seeking a temporary injunction.

Senior Advocate Mahesh Jethmalani, appearing for Republic TV and Goswami,

asked the Court for time to file a detailed reply. "Everything I have said is true and, secondly, fair comment," said Jethmalani.

The Court, however, disagreed with the "fair comment" argument. It permitted Republic to file its reply. "In the reply, you can say that every word that I have used is fair. But till you file a reply, refrain from using those words. Otherwise, it will not be fair," the judge



Anita Advani, Rajesh Khanna

Advani challenging an order passed by the Dindoshi sessions court in Mumbai in 2017, rejecting her civil suit seeking similar relief after

Khanna's death in July 2012. Advani had claimed she was in a live-in relationship with Khanna for several years till she was evicted from his bungalow 'Aashirwad' in the metropolis in 2012 by his estranged wife Dimple Kapadia, also a veteran actor, daughter Twinkle Khanna and son-in-law Akshay Kumar. In 2013, Advani filed a complaint before a magistrate under

provisions of the Domestic Violence Act (DVA) against Kapadia, the Bollywood couple's daughters Twinkle and Rinkie and their son-in-law and superstar Akshay Kumar.

Advani claimed she was evicted from Khanna's suburban bungalow after his death and sought monthly maintenance and a three-bedroom flat in Bandra, an upscale area in Mumbai.

HC directs removal of social media posts over 'molestation' of journalist

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi High Court has directed the removal of 'defamatory' posts over the alleged molestation of a journalist on a flight, saying that using social media to circulate the allegations and reveal the identity of the perpetrator before any formal investigation was a severe transgression of his fundamental right to live with dignity and fair trial. Justice Vikas Mahajan, in an interim order passed on a lawsuit by the man, asked the woman journalist as well as certain online platforms not to publish the "defamatory allegations" against him till the next hearing in May.

The court said the narrative set by the media houses and digital platforms breached the contours of the FIR registered in the matter as they did not merely report the allegations in the FIR but prematurely adjudicated it by labelling the plaintiff a "culprit" and "molester". The court also expressed concern over a tweet by

actor Richa Chadha endorsing and amplifying the "unverified allegation", observing that her conduct transcended mere free expression and acted as a "catalyst for public shaming and digital vigilantism".

The court said, being a public figure, Chadha has a legal and moral responsibility to verify the veracity of facts before "leveraging her platform to amplify grave accusations" and asked her not to precipitate the issue in future. Her counsel said she has already removed the tweet.

The plaintiff's counsel submitted that he was a highly reputed corporate professional with an unblemished career spanning over two decades, who had been subjected to a 'trial by media'. The counsel said that while travelling from Delhi to Mumbai on an IndiGo flight on March 11, the defendant woman abruptly woke up the plaintiff from his sleep and falsely accused him of inappropriate conduct.

It was claimed that upon landing, the woman



launched a false, malicious, and defamatory attack on the plaintiff by publishing a post on X, which was subsequently amplified and sensationalised by other defendants without any independent verification. The plaintiff's lawyer submitted that the allegations have a striking resemblance to the narrative in the woman's earlier documentary project on harassment in public transport. The woman's counsel said truth was the absolute defence in cases of defama-

tion and opposed the passing of a gag order.

The court observed that the "overhasty public disclosure" by the defendant woman prima facie suggested an attempt to sensationalise the issue and subject the plaintiff to a trial by public opinion, rather than a bona fide pursuit of legal redress. It said that the woman broadcast the allegations on social media platform prior to setting the criminal law in motion, as the post was published at

09:39 am while the FIR was registered at 12:27 pm, and the two were also "at variance" with respect to the plaintiff's identity.

The court said posts following the incident harmed the reputation of the plaintiff, who was suspended from his workplace and that he would suffer irreparable loss and injury if relief was not granted at this stage.

"While defendant number 1 (woman) has an unindereed right to report a grievance, but using social media

to circulate allegations of inappropriate touching and revealing the identity of the plaintiff along with his photograph before a formal investigation even commences, in a prima facie view of this court, is a severe transgression of the plaintiff's fundamental right to live with dignity and have fair trial," the court said.

"This court is of the prima facie view that the allegations in the post published by defendant number 1 (woman), along with disclosure of plaintiff's identity and his photograph, article published by defendant nos. 3; post/article published by 'OBNews' and 'Pardafassh Media' on the social media platforms of defendant nos. 5 and 6, respectively; and the tweet re-posted by defendant no. 7 (Chadha) sensationalised the issue at hand and has prematurely labelled the plaintiff as the culprit even when an FIR has been registered, and the matter is under investigation," the court concluded. The court also asked ABP and NDTV to take down their posts on this matter.



Editor's
TAKE

Battle for Assam hinges on infiltration politics

As Assam Assembly Elections 2026 approach, the political discourse in the state has sharpened around a familiar and emotive theme-'infiltration'

As April 9, the election day in Assam, approaches, the atmosphere in the state is politically charged, and tempers are running high on both sides. The past elections in the State have been fought more on emotive issues than on issues of livelihood and people-centric issues. The NDA campaign spearheaded by Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma is focusing solely on the infiltration issue and has prominently placed it in their election manifesto. The issue of infiltration is not new to Assam, and the BJP has previously utilised this issue. The BJP has once again placed the issue of illegal immigration at the centre of its electoral narrative. Senior leaders, including Amit Shah and Himanta Biswa Sarma, have repeatedly asserted that the state faces a persistent threat from "infiltrators."

This issue is also the issue of national security and change in the demographic contours of the state. The BJP is promising to identify and repatriate such individuals to the place they belong. The BJP is also saying that it has freed vast lands in the state from encroachment in the last ten years and showcasing it as evidence of decisive governance. This is despite the fact that these claims are yet to be corroborated by official data, which remains elusive.

Neither the Assam government nor the Union Ministry of Home Affairs has maintained verifiable and consolidated figures on the number of individuals identified, detained, or deported over the past decade. This absence of verifiable data has provided Congress leader Gaurav Gogoi an opportunity to question the credibility of the BJP's claims, arguing that the issue is being raked up for electoral gains, whereas the reality on the ground is different.

The Congress wants to exploit the anti-incumbency and thus has focused on governance issues such as unemployment, inflation, and social welfare, to shift the narrative away from the emotive identity politics. The other things that the BJP-led National Democratic Alliance (NDA) is banking on are a mix of welfare delivery and strong leadership. The Congress and its allies are attempting to build a coalition around economic concerns and institutional accountability. Yet, the 'infiltration' is the main issue in Assam today.

Assam's contemporary history has hovered around identity – the Assam Movement and the subsequent updating of the National Register of Citizens (NRC) – has made questions of identity and migration deeply sensitive. This theme resonates with the people across regions and communities. As polling day approaches, the key question is whether voters will prioritise emotive appeals linked to identity and security, or vote for livelihood and governance issues.

The lack of official data raises broader concerns about transparency in democratic discourse. The Assam elections are not just a contest for power in a 126-member Assembly; they are also a test of how narratives shape electoral choices in contemporary India.

Delhi Film Festival: A system in the making

The inaugural International Film Festival Delhi (IFFD) 2026 transforms the national capital into a vibrant, global hub for cinema, bridging the gap between mainstream Bollywood, regional excellence, and international storytelling



CHAITANYA K PRASAD

Delhi has always been a city of stories. Political, cultural, deeply personal, something is always unfolding here. This March, cinema found its way back into that mix in a big way. The Delhi International Film Festival 2026 didn't just begin; it arrived with scale, energy, and a certain confidence that felt long overdue. For a city that once hosted the International Film Festival of India before it moved to Goa, this feels less like something new and more like something reclaimed. But the real question isn't about how it started. It's about what it becomes. Because putting together a large festival is one thing. Building something that people take seriously year after year, that's where the real work begins. Right now, the festival has attention. It has curiosity. But what it needs next is identity, structure, and consistency. If Delhi is to build a serious cinematic identity, the festival must resist becoming a one-off showcase. The first step towards institutionalisation lies in temporal discipline. The festival must anchor itself firmly to a fixed calendar window, a defined geography, and a stable identity. Just as Cannes is inseparable from May and Venice from late August, Delhi must claim its own moment in the cultural calendar. A late-March positioning works strategically, it avoids overlap with global heavyweights while aligning with India's academic and cultural cycles, but this must now be codified and protected. A festival that shifts in time and space each year risks losing not just recall, but relevance. Once that foundation is in place, the next big shift has to be in how the festival programs itself. Right now, it feels like a wide, fairly inclusive mix, and that's understandable for a first edition. But going forward, it has to feel more intentional. Less like a collection, more like a point of view. The difference between a good festival and a great one is not how many films it shows, but how clearly it knows what it wants to say through them. That means building sections that feel thought-through. Bringing in more director-led storytelling, where the craft and perspective matter as much as the narrative itself. Giving real, central space to women-directed and women-centric cinema, not as a token category, but as a core part of the programming. And also leaning into films that engage with real, lived issues, social, political, environmental. Because the festivals that stay with you are the ones that reflect the moment you're living in. At the same time, Delhi has the opportunity to



VOICES FROM THE NORTH-EAST, INDEPENDENT FILMMAKERS, SMALLER INDUSTRIES, THEY SHOULD FEEL CENTRAL, NOT PERIPHERAL. AND ALONGSIDE THAT, OTT CAN'T BE IGNORED. IT'S NOT A PARALLEL WORLD ANYMORE; IT'S PART OF THE SAME ECOSYSTEM

The author is a Commentator and Writer on Cinema, Branding, Media Management and Geo-Strategic Communication. Inputs provided by Zoya Ahmad and Vaishnavie Srinivasan

dailypioneer

@Chatty111Prasad

The Pioneer

do something most festivals in India haven't fully managed yet, to become a space where cinema is not just screened, but developed. There is so much raw talent in this city, students, theatre actors, independent creators, people experimenting with storytelling in ways that don't always find platforms. The festival can step into that gap. Script labs, pitching forums, casting platforms, youth sections, these aren't add-ons, they're what can make the festival feel alive beyond the screenings. What can really set Delhi apart, though, is how deeply it involves its own people. Right now, a lot of the festival still sits within designated venues. But cinema has the ability to move, to travel, to meet people where they are. Open-air screenings across neighbourhoods, community-led programming, student participation, and these things can turn the festival into something the city feels a part of, not just something happening around it. The more people feel included, the stronger the festival becomes. There's also a strong case for going deeper within India itself. If the festival wants to be global, it has to first be rooted. Regional cinema needs more than representation; it needs prominence. Voices from the North-East, independent filmmakers, and smaller industries, they should feel central, not peripheral. And alongside that, OTT can't be ignored. It's not a parallel world anymore; it's part of the same ecosystem. Bringing it into the festival, giving it space, engaging with it seriously, that's just being honest about where cinema is today. At the same time, the global cinema showcase this year has been one of the festival's strongest signals of intent. Bringing films from across continents, diverse storytelling styles, and different cinematic languages onto one platform has helped position Delhi as outward-looking and internationally aware. The current edition has seen a notable focus on regions such as Saudi Arabia and parts of Africa, alongside a wider mix

of international entries from Europe, Asia, and beyond. But going forward, this needs to become sharper and more curated. Instead of broad representation, the festival could move towards focused country spotlights, director retrospectives, and region-specific showcases that offer deeper engagement rather than surface-level exposure. Building sustained partnerships with global festivals and film bodies can also ensure that Delhi is not just screening international cinema but becoming part of its circulation. The goal should be to move from access to influence.

If Delhi really wants to move into the league of major festivals, it also needs to think beyond screenings and build an industry layer. Spaces where filmmakers meet producers, where ideas find backing, where collaborations begin. That's what gives a festival weight. And in doing so, it doesn't have to compete with the International Film Festival of India. It can actually complement it, where IFFI remains the flagship, Delhi can become more agile, more industry-facing, and more experimental. A lot of this, of course, depends on how the government chooses to take this forward. Not just as an annual event to organise, but as something to build over time. That means consistency in funding, long-term thinking, and a structure that exists beyond individual editions. Because festivals like this don't become important overnight, they grow into that space. Right now, the Delhi International Film Festival has done something important: it has made people look. It has been shown that Delhi can host something of this scale and do it well. But attention doesn't last. What lasts is substance. The next edition doesn't need to be bigger. It just needs to be clearer. More confident about what it stands for and where it wants to go. Because if Delhi gets this right, it won't just be another stop on the festival circuit. It will become a place where cinema actually feels like it belongs.

The Pioneer
SINCE 1865

PIC TALK



A man with his cheeks pierced by a metal rod takes part in a procession during the 'Panguini Uthiram' festival, in Bhopal

PHOTO: PTI



AJIT KUMAR BISHNOI

2ND OPINION

Think of a person who has offended you. He has now realized his mistake, and comes to apologize sincerely. What will you do? You will certainly give it a thought, and if the offence is not intentional you may forgive. Now expand this phenomenon to our situation. Throughout our life, we face many setbacks, problems, troubles, etc. Why does it happen? I will explain in this article and its solution.

This Creation is based on dharma (highest religious principles formulated by God). In simple language it is: "What you sow is what you reap." Then, it is logical to accept that whatever adversities we face must be due to our infringing dharma in the past. We all have a past including previous lives when we have done many sinful and impious acts. These all must bear bad fruits. Why else are we here in the 'duhkhalaya' (place of misery). (The Bhagavad-Gita



8.15) These bad fruits include two kinds of punishments. One is of fixed type of something bad happening like a major disease. The other is faulty 'svabhava' (nature), which is being lusty, greedy, hateful, etc. Such nature makes us act in bad ways, and we get into trouble repeatedly. Unfortunately, our reaction is equally faulty. We lament, blame others for our woes and even blame God. Our overinflated ego does not allow us to admit that we must have acted badly earlier as we are presently doing also. This is gross ignorance. What should ideally be done? We must go to the authority, who can condone our past mistakes. I am referring to God – the Controller. Wise persons have done so in the past and benefitted. Ravan was

The Pioneer
SINCE 1865

stressful to become pure and watch all my acts by the body, senses and words, but it can be done. I am glad to state that I am doing quite well.

The writer is a spiritual teacher and a popular columnist

BEYOND ELIMINATING EXTREMISTS: ADDRESSING THE ROOTS OF NAXALISM

The editorial on the government's claims of eliminating Naxalism (1-4-26) is welcome. It is widely understood that Naxalism is essentially a social issue, though its methods of addressing inequality through violence remain unacceptable. No meaningful social or economic transformation can be achieved through coercion, and such approaches inevitably turn predatory. This explains why extremist groups have gradually lost public support and declined in both size and activity.

However, their persistence points to a deeper reality—the continuing distress of the marginalized communities they claim to represent. The crucial question is whether the economic condition of these sections has improved enough to naturally erode extremism, or whether

governments have merely focused on eliminating insurgents while neglecting the root causes. Evidence suggests that poverty and inequality remain widespread. Millions still depend on free rations, unemployment is rising, school dropouts are increasing, and access to basic needs remains limited for a vast population.

At the same time, wealth concentration is growing, with rising numbers of billionaires even as India ranks poorly on global hunger and corruption indices. This widening gap reflects policy priorities that seem skewed. In a democracy, violence has no place. Yet, the real objective must be the eradication of extreme poverty and inequality, not just extremist groups.

A G RAJMOHAN | ANANTAPUR

Please send your letter to the info@dailypioneer.com. In not more than 250 words. We appreciate your feedback.

Mamata mimicks Modi's style

Trinamool Congress (TMC) supremo and West Bengal Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee has adopted a strategy of projecting herself as the face of the party across all 294 constituencies, urging voters to "consider me your candidate."

This approach closely mirrors Prime Minister Narendra Modi's centralised campaign style in national elections. In response to Home Minister Amit Shah's detailed "charge sheet" (Abhiyognama) against the TMC government, Banerjee has turned the narrative around by highlighting his "clean chit" to portray him as a victim of conspiracy. TMC leaders dismissed the document as an outsider's attack and countered with their own grievance list, citing withheld funds and rising prices.

Banerjee has further accused the BJP of manipulating electoral rolls and even plotting against her life, while calling for a chargesheet against Modi and Shah. Her rhetoric invokes issues like riot incitement, drawing parallels with how the BJP once used the Bofors scandal against the Congress, despite Rajiv Gandhi's later exoneration.

In Indian politics, "clean chits" often transcend legal closure to become tools of political messaging, with parties interpreting them to suit their narratives.

BIDYUT KUMAR CHATTERJEE | FARIDABAD

Thoughts on Autism awareness day

A person with autism tends to withdraw into a shell due to impaired ability to communicate with the surroundings. Also termed Autism Spectrum Disorder (ASD), speech and non-verbal interaction are seriously hampered compelling the affected to go through a repetitive behaviour. Diagnosable as early as one year, proper scientific intervention can mitigate the developmental problems to a large extent. The wide spectrum of autism also means an individual can live with the two extremes—seriously challenged or perfectly normal.

There are specific milestones in a child's developmental curve, and parents should know what to expect of their little ones at appropriate stages in life. "What" and "when" are two crucial words. "Autism", is "autos" from Greek and forced "self-isolation" is a big "no". Known to run in the family, the unknown cause of autism makes it interesting to professionals who have relied mainly on behavioural therapy and language therapy to corner the disorder denoting a marked shift from the past. Correcting accompanying deficiencies and psychological disorders go hand-in-hand towards improving the child's quality of life. April 2 is Autism awareness day.

GANPATHI BHAT | AKOLA

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Census begins, caste data to be included

The importance of the census, an institution with roots stretching back over two millennia to ancient empires, cannot be overstated. In modern India, it is the backbone of governance, guiding everything from infrastructure development to welfare schemes. When resources are limited, their allocation must be informed by evidence: which regions still lack electricity, where educational deficits persist, and how economic disparities are distributed. The new data will also illuminate demographic trends, including the uneven success of family planning initiatives across regions.

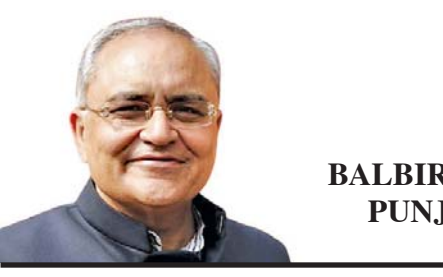
At last, we have a national census that includes castes. The two-phase mammoth task, beginning April 1, has several firsts to its credit. This is the first time since 1931 that nationwide caste enumeration is being undertaken. It is also the first fully digital exercise, with enumerators using mobile applications to record responses, making the process more efficient and less prone to errors. The digital format also enables faster data processing and analysis. The inclusion of caste in the nationwide census - delayed from its original 2021 timeline due to the Covid-19 pandemic - is a welcome development. It marks a vital step towards evidence-based policy making in India.

YASH PAL RALHAN | JALANDHAR

The Jihadist mindset relentlessly haunts India with internal support

The tendency to dismiss historical references as irrelevant does little to advance understanding. On the contrary, it risks repeating past mistakes. The events of 1947, remind us that the line between disorder and organised subversion can be perilously thin

FIRST
Column



BALBIR
PUNJ

The arrest of Ahmad Lone by the Delhi Police on March 29 is not merely another routine success in counter-terror operations. According to media reports, his intended targets included Delhi Kalkaji Temple and the bustling Connaught Place-symbols of both faith and urban life in the national capital. Acting under instructions from handlers based in Pakistan, Lone was allegedly engaged in recruiting Indian Muslim youth for the Lashkar-e-Taiba.

Only a few days earlier, security agencies had apprehended twelve suspects linked to ISIS and al-Qaeda in a coordinated operation across multiple states. Among them were individuals from ordinary professions-a bike-taxi driver, a restaurant employee, and even a laser-marking technician. Their presence in such networks underscores a sobering reality: radicalisation today does not wear a uniform; it often operates covertly, beneath the surface of normal life.

This is not an isolated incident. In November last year, a devastating explosion in a moving vehicle in Delhi caused significant casualties, carried out by Dr. Umar Un Nabi. Investigations led to the recovery of over 3,000 kilograms of explosives, weapons, and bomb-making equipment from Faridabad.

Several other doctors from Faridabad's Al-Falah University were detained. These terrorists were not impoverished and illiterate but belonged to a highly educated and privileged segment of Indian society-challenging the common narrative that poverty and lack of opportunities drive beleaguered Muslims to radicalism.

Around the same time, Gujarat Police arrested Dr. Ahmed Mohiuddin Syed and his associates for allegedly attempting to produce ricin-a lethal toxin-with the intent of contaminating food and water supplies. These sordid incidents reveal a method, a pattern, and above all, a mindset. So, none - poor, rich, unlettered, or highly qualified - are immune to the influence of the toxicity of Jihad - which has a theological underpinning.

The temptation in public discourse is to interpret these developments through the



THE PARTITION OF INDIA IN 1947, EXECUTED EXPLICITLY ON RELIGIOUS LINES, AND THE LATER EXODUS OF KASHMIRI HINDUS, STAND AS STARK REMINDERS THAT HISTORY IS NOT MERELY A CHRONICLE OF THE PAST

The writer is an eminent columnist, former Chairman of the Indian Institute of Mass Communication (IIMC), and the author of 'Trust with Ayodhya: Decolonisation of India' and 'Narrative ka Mayajal'

 dailypioneer

 @balbirpunj

 The Pioneer

lens of recent political narratives. Some claim that such terror acts are violent responses to perceived anti-Muslim policies by the Modi Government. However, this oversimplified and politically convenient perspective ignores the complexity of a phenomenon that has persisted for centuries. Such opportunistic thinking and time-serving analysis prevent civil society from finding meaningful solutions to this long-standing issue.

In fact, subcontinent Muslims' rancour against Hindus has a long history, extending beyond the birth of Bharatiya Jana Sangh or the Bharatiya Janata Party. A segment of Muslims had grievances with Congress in pre-partition India when it was led by Mahatma Gandhi, Pandit Nehru, and Sardar Patel. Leveraging that Muslim resentment, the British created Pakistan by partitioning away one-third of India. And the jihadists' war against residual India began right after independence.

A brief recall of the events of September 1947 in Delhi helps us understand this ongoing vicious phenomenon. Contemporary accounts suggest that what unfolded in the capital was far more than spontaneous rioting. V. P.

Menon, who served as Secretary to the Government of India in the Ministry of the States, observed, "the capital buzzed with rumours of a deep-laid, long-prepared Muslim conspiracy to overthrow the new Government of free India and to seize the capital." This was not paranoia; it was an assessment grounded in intelligence inputs and subsequent discoveries.

J.B. Kripalani, then President of the Congress, provides even more revealing testimony. He wrote: "Searches of Muslim houses by the police had revealed dumps of bombs, arms and ammunition... Sten-guns, Bren guns, mortars and wire-less transmitters were seized." Kripalani also noted that in several instances, "arms were recovered from mosques and adjoining localities".

The makeup of the police force further complicated the situation. As Kripalani noted, "the bulk of the police force was Muslim... a number of them in their uniforms and with arms had deserted." Delhi, in those days, was not just a city in chaos; it was a capital under siege, confronting the threat of internal subversion.

This detail is crucial. It indicates that the

violence was not entirely spontaneous; it had elements of preparation and coordination - a mindset that continues to rock India to this day.

It is also a harsh but undeniable truth that most of those who demanded Partition and tirelessly worked for the creation of Pakistan neither left India nor did the supporting political class-including communists-a creed ironically near extinct in the land of their dreams-but still shaping narratives in the country they had worked hard to break.

Had such divisive elements left India, the residual separatism and religious radicalism might have faded, or evolved-like in Indonesia or Malaysia-into a more culturally rooted, civilisationally aligned form. Instead, that process was stalled. The Marx-Macaulay mindset, in the name of 'secularism', blunted any natural assimilation.

The result is stark: for some, democracy has not become a vehicle of reform and empowerment, but merely a tool to consolidate religious identity in a toxic form. Dr. B. R. Ambedkar once cautioned in a different context, "The Muslims have no

interest in politics as such. Their predominant interest is religion... Muslim politics is essentially clerical and recognises only one difference, namely, that existing between Hindus and Muslims."

For over a millennium, the Indian sub-continent has witnessed waves of incursions shaped by a doctrinal zeal that often fused faith with conquest. From Muhammad bin Qasim's invasion to the campaigns of Mahmud of Ghazni, Muhammad Ghor, Babur, Aurangzeb, and Ahmad Shah Abdali, historical records recount episodes of violence, iconoclasm, and coercion. Afghanistan, once a centre of Hindu-Buddhist civilisation, underwent a profound transformation.

The Partition of India in 1947, executed explicitly on religious lines, and the later exodus of Kashmiri Hindus, stand as stark reminders that history is not merely a chronicle of the past-it is a force that shapes the present. Concepts such as 'Ghazwa-e-Hind', though not universally accepted, continue to find resonance in radical circles. It is this ideological substratum that provides continuity between past and present manifestations of extremism.

These historical episodes are not invoked to inflame passions, but to illuminate patterns. The parallels with contemporary developments are instructive. Today's networks-whether linked to Lashkar-e-Taiba, ISIS, or al-Qaeda-operate within a globalised ecosystem, drawing upon narratives that transcend national boundaries. The individuals involved may differ in profession and education, but the ideological thread that connects them remains consistent.

The tendency to dismiss historical references as irrelevant does little to advance understanding. On the contrary, it risks repeating past mistakes. The events of 1947, as documented by contemporaries like Kripalani and Menon, remind us that the line between disorder and organised subversion can be perilously thin.

The arrest of Ahmad Lone is thus both a warning and a reminder. It underscores the persistence of threats, but also the capacity of the state to respond. Whether India can navigate this terrain successfully will depend on its willingness to engage with its history honestly, to confront ideological extremism without equivocation, and to reaffirm the principles that bind its diverse society together.

History does not repeat itself in identical form, but it often rhymes. To ignore its echoes is to invite its consequences.

Last frontier: The ideological battle against Naxalism



ARADHITA
SINGH

What began as a radical peasant uprising nearly six decades ago and evolved into one of the country's most persistent internal security challenges appears to be approaching its final phase. While the armed movement is nearing its collapse, the ideological battle that underpins the Naxal ideology remains far from over.

The Naxal movement traces its origins to the Naxalbari uprising in West Bengal in 1967, where a peasant revolt ignited the broader Maoist insurgency. By 1969, the formation of the Communist Party of India (Marxist - Leninist) under Charu Mazumdar gave organisational structure to this revolutionary impulse. However, the movement soon faced decline in the 1970s due to state crackdowns, internal divisions and leadership losses. The insurgency re-emerged in the 1980s-1990s through groups such as the People's War Group (PWG) and the Maoist Communist Centre (MCC), eventually culminating in their merger in 2004 to form the CPI (Maoist). This marked the beginning of the movement's most violent phase, between 2005 and 2010. This is the phase where Maoists controlled vast stretches of land across eastern and central India, called the 'Red Corridor'. From being described as the 'single biggest internal security challenge facing the country,' the discourse around Naxalism has evolved significantly in recent years. Repeated assertions by the Hon'ble Prime Minister and the Union Home Minister have emphasised that the movement is now in its terminal phase, with a clear national objective of eliminating Left Wing Extremism by March 2026. Recent data highlights a clear pattern of decline in Maoist capabilities and a weakening morale of existing cadres. Arrests and Surrenders have surged, reflecting internal demoralisation and a shrinking support base.

Large-scale attacks - once the hallmark of Maoist operations - have significantly decreased, now replaced by sporadic, localised violence lacking strategic coherence. Coordinated security operations, improved intelligence, and sustained political focus and will have reduced the insurgency to a shadow of its former self. Perhaps the most striking indicator is the contradiction of the movement's geographical footprint.

From 126 affected districts in 2013, the number dropped to 38 by 2024 and further to 11 in 2025. This is about a 91% reduction in districts affected by Left Wing Extremism in 12 years. This dramatic rollback is not merely a security success; it represents a structural weakening of the insurgency's ability to sustain itself. The 2026 target represents not just political will and ambition but actual measurable progress on the ground.

While evidence paints a picture of a movement in terminal decline - the data revealing a shift from Maoist actions to defensive and reactive behaviour - history offers a cautionary lesson. Instances within our country and abroad provide examples of how 'ideas are bulletproof'. Ideas are inherently more resilient than armed formations. They exist beyond territory, weapons, or organisational hierarchies to survive. Even as Naxal violence declines, the ideological narratives that sustained the movement continue to circulate. These narratives often reframe violence as legitimate resistance against perceived state oppression, thereby diluting moral condemnation and sustaining sympathy for the cause. The disconnect between the security operations' success and ideological persistence presents India's next major challenge beyond 31st March 2026. Maoist ideology is not confined to the remote forested regions. It thrives within a broader urban ecosystem that includes intellectual spaces, academia, theatre, cultural platforms and digital spaces. These narratives are disseminated through debates and activism, often romanticising armed violence.

Cultural mediums play a powerful role in shaping public imagination, portraying the Naxal movement with moral sympathy while questioning the state's legitimacy. This ecosystem is not necessarily a coordinated conspiracy, but rather a layered network of influences that collectively sustain and legitimise Maoist thought. Its resilience lies in its decentralised nature and its ability to operate independently of the insurgency's physical presence.

Maoist narratives spread through certain identifiable channels. Digital media has amplified the reach of these ideas, enabling them to transcend geographic boundaries and target new audiences, especially the youth. Young people are particularly vulnerable to ideological influences due to the role of peer networks, campus movements, and emotionally resonant narratives. These narratives shape and sway public perceptions more powerfully than factual counter arguments, making ideological contestation a long-term endeavour.

As security forces 'reclaim' the erstwhile Naxal territories, the State is faced with its most consequential challenge of demonstrating that

governance can bring tangible gains to the lives of the communities affected by the Naxal violence. It wouldn't be an exaggeration to suggest that the durability of peace in these areas will be incumbent upon the perpetual delivery of peace, justice and development by the government institutions. Roads, schools, healthcare facilities, and digital connectivity are not mere developmental projects - they are instruments of legitimacy. Economic revival is equally critical. Restoring markets, livelihood, and local economies integrates these regions to the national mainstream, fostering peace and stability.

The post - 2026 phase requires a strategic shift from conflict management to peace consolidation. This involves a long-term commitment to inclusive governance, sensitivity to local cultures, conflict mapping and sustained engagement with affected communities. A transition from a security-centric approach to a service-delivery model is essential.

This must take precedence as it would appropriately address the root cause that was once exploited by Naxal narratives, leading to Maoist mobilisation. Equally important is the need for a fact-based public narrative that counters misinformation and acknowledges, along with the surrendered cadres, the victims of Naxal violence. Youth-focused skill development programmes can further serve as a powerful tool for preventing radicalisation by creating economic opportunities.

India's progress against Naxalism is undeniably remarkable. What was once described as the country's 'single biggest internal security threat' has now been reduced to a limited law-and-order challenge confined to a few districts. However, this is not the end of the journey against the Naxal movement. The final battle lies not in the realm of the 'jungle and zameen', but in the realm of ideas. Without addressing the ideological ecosystem that sustains Naxalism, there is a risk that the movement could re-emerge in new forms. Durable peace rests on the pillars of opportunity, legitimacy and trust. Development must create opportunities; governance must build legitimacy, and sustained, area-specific engagement must foster trust between the state and the tribal communities of the region.

We may have won the battle of arms, but the war of ideas continues, and Bharat's success in eliminating Naxalism from its soil ultimately would depend on its success in winning both.

The writer is Research Fellow at India Foundation

 dailypioneer

 @Aradhita0702

 dailypioneer

The strategic value of coal: Why India Needs more of it



ANANDAJIT
GOSWAMI

In an era defined by climate action and the global push toward clean energy, coal is often cast as the elephant in the room. Yet, recent geopolitical upheavals, wars in the Middle East, and the ongoing liquefied petroleum gas (LPG) and gas crisis have forced policymakers to realise a more complicated reality: coal, despite its environmental costs, remains indispensable to global energy security, especially for emerging economies like India to realise Viksit Bharat 2047 vision in the short and midterm. The resurgence of coal is not a failure of climate ambition or climate action; rather, it is a mirror showing the reflection of structural vulnerabilities in the global energy system, which has never been fair for the Global South and for countries like India, which is aiming to aspire for its Viksit Bharat ambitions by 2047. The war in Iran, the Middle East, disruptions in global gas supply chains, and volatile LPG prices have exposed the fragility of overreliance on imported fuels for many countries worldwide. This has raised the point that a transition to a cleaner world by 2070 cannot happen without ensuring energy supply security and creating a fair global energy system.

Hence, dependence on coal will remain in the short- and medium-term until 2055. In the meantime, coal-to-gas, chemical, and liquid-fuel pathways need to be explored more aggressively for countries like India to improve energy security and mitigate current or future energy supply constraints. Gas supply for LPG, widely used for cooking and heating in developing nations, has always been subject to international price fluctuations and supply disruptions. Reliance on imported LPG creates fiscal pressure on countries like India and exposes households to price shocks. The need to convert coal to synthetic fuels such as methanol and dimethyl ether (DME), which can partially replace LPG in cooking and industrial applications, has only grown and can help stabilise prices by reducing dependence on imported gas. This is more pertinent if the future global geopolitical vulnerabilities increase.

Coal continues to supply the bulk of India's electricity for households and industry. This supply dependence arises against the backdrop of intermittency issues with the availability of electricity from solar and wind in India, due to inadequate, suboptimal storage facilities. The situation on that front is gradually improving. However, until the optimal levels of storage and the grid infrastruc-

ture's intermittency issues are solved, coal will remain the source of base load power and will continue to do so if the manufacturing and service sector's share of GDP rises in the future. The risks of grid instability on the Indian Power Grid increase every day during the peak demand period, while the renewable-source-based electricity supply dips in the evening. The backup is often provided by hydro and wind to a large extent. However, the situation can worsen if peak demand continues to rise with future economic activity, without concomitant storage and grid infrastructure support. Hence, coal is a strategic support in such a case.

With the advent and investment in coal gasification technologies, dependence on LPG for cooking and industrial applications can decrease if the availability and off-take of methanol and DME increase, thereby enhancing national energy security and resilience. Coal creates local pollution, but it can't be seen as a binary choice between coal versus renewables or clean energy. India's people-centric clean energy transition will be a symbiotic coexistence of coal and clean energy, placing people at the core by addressing inequality, industrialisation, and urbanisation. Coal will evolve during such a transition, generating cleaner products through gasification. Supercritical and ultra-supercritical power plants will have to be introduced to significantly reduce emissions per unit of electricity generated in this pathway. Carbon capture, utilisation, and storage (CCUS) and methane capture will be part of the pathway while supporting the lives, livelihoods, and identities of coal ecosystem communities.

Abrupt coal phase-out will create trauma, memory, and identity loss for communities, which will be more personal and beyond the metric of income.

India, if it is to reach Viksit Bharat by 2047, cannot afford a collapse of communities owing to abrupt coal phase-downs or phase-outs. Communities have to evolve and enter a transition process through reskilling, rehabilitation, and repurposing efforts around coal mines.

Coal provides the people of India with the energy autonomy to attain Viksit Bharat by 2047, while we still take gradual steps towards scaling and deploying renewable energy technologies and their infrastructure. A world that is becoming more fragile, politically multipolar, with geopolitical vulnerabilities, only reminds us that coal's relevance is not about nostalgia but about navigating and negotiating the peaceful present and future of India. Hence, Coal is surely not an elephant in the room but a solution for India and its Viksit Bharat Goals.

The Pioneer
SINCE 1865

The writer, Research Lead, ACPET, Director, Manav Rachna Centre For Peace and Sustainability

 dailypioneer

 @TheDailyPioneer

 dailypioneer

iexceed

Appzillon™

AI Powered Digital Banking Solutions

WWW.i-exceed.com

BLASÉ CAPITAL

2FA FROM FRAUD



Beginning yesterday, the central bank introduced several measures to counter online frauds, and reduce illegal payments. One of the most prominent among them is the so-called ‘two-step factor authentication (2FA),’ which is mandatory for digital payments and, according to media reports, will “fundamentally change how users pay via UPI, cards, and mobile wallets.” The mode will become tougher and more complex, even as it turns safer and secure. Over the past few years, the central bank has repeatedly expressed concerns over the rising number of online frauds such as phishing, and SIM-swap scams. It concluded that the single step OTP (one-time password) regime was fraught with risks, and users were being taken for rides by fraudsters based faraway in small towns, and even villages. The scandals were highlighted, and were publicly known because of several OTT series in the recent past. The public was scared, and afraid to opt for online deals.

Every digital payment will be verified at least twice, or in what is being called the use of two independent factors. Of course, OTP will remain the main one, possibly the first one. But it will be followed by another verification such as PIN, password, biometrics, or secure token. Thus, the payments will take longer, and consumers will need to carefully input both steps correctly. But it will make life safer for the users. According to a media report, this will lead to a risk-based system. Deals via trusted devices, or routine small payments “may remain quick and seamless.” But high-risk transactions, large payments, or new devices “may trigger additional verification steps.” Accountability norms for banks are tightened to place more responsibilities on them. Hence, the payment platforms will become safer and secure. Thus, the onus shifts to both the users, and banks, rather than just users.

However, there are a few tricky areas. In most cases, online frauds, including phishing, work because the users are taken in by the criminals because the former believe implicitly in the latter. In other instances, they are completely fooled. According to experts, in phishing, “attackers deceive people into revealing sensitive information, or installing malware such as viruses, worms, adware, or ransomware. Phishing attacks have become increasingly sophisticated, and often transparently mirror the site being targeted, allowing the attacker to observe everything while the victim navigates the site, and traverses any additional security boundaries with the victim.” Clearly, whether it is a one-step OTP, or 2FA process, the fraudsters can either goad the users into revealing them (information), or observe everything online. “Modern phishing campaigns increasingly target multi-factor authentication (MFA) systems, not just passwords. Attackers use spoofed login pages, and real-time relay tools to capture both the credentials and one-time passcodes,” explains information on a public-domain website.

In some instances, phishing kits are designed in such a manner to deliberately and consciously bypass, and overrule 2FA by “immediately forwarding stolen credentials to the attacker’s server.” A blog post (2024), which is two years old, reveals the unprecedented rise of “adversary-in-the-middle” phishing attacks, which intercept session tokens, and allow the attackers to substitute as the victims. Phishing techniques and vectors include email spam, vishing (voice phishing), target phishing (spear phishing, whaling), smishing (SMS), quishing (QR code), and cross-site scripting.” Thus, this clearly establishes that the phishing techniques are way ahead of the central bank’s 2FA, and India is way behind the criminals. This is invariably the case as legislators, regulators, and law-enforcers, are inevitably two steps, or two-factors behind the fraudsters. In a sense, the regulator’s 2FA can easily be side-stepped, or jumped by the 3FA-4FA criminal system. The hands of the law may be long, but the minds of outlaws are large.

Social engineering is an integral part of phishing and online frauds. This involves a system that tricks the users to perform actions such as clicking a link, open an attachment, and reveal sensitive information. The criminals pretend to be trusting entities, or create a sense of urgency. The former may, for example, ape a renowned bank or payment mode. The latter may shock the users that their electricity or water, or other utilities may be shut down within 24 hours. “An alternative technique to impersonation-based phishing is the use of fake news articles to trick victims into clicking on a malicious link. These links often lead to fake websites that appear legitimate, but are run by attackers who may try to install malware,” explains a website. Thus, 2FA, or more complexity will not solve the problem because online frauds involve not just objectivity, authentication, but subjectivity (emotions and sentiments). Central bank plays a limited role.

A few years ago, a teenage hacker, and his accomplices set up a fake website that resembled Twitter’s (now X) internal VPN provider used for remote working employees. Posing as a help desk, they urged employees to submit their credentials. Using these, the hackers seized control of high-profile accounts such as those of former president, future president, corporate account of a renowned tech firm, and future owner of X. They approached other users, and legitimately (though illegally) promised to double returns on bitcoin. They collected more than a dozen bitcoins, or more than \$1,00,000 then. Imagine, if similar techniques were used in India. 2FA will become F-minus.

The Pioneer

NEW DELHI | THURSDAY | APRIL 2, 2026



BUSINESS10

Challenges before Nepal’s regime

Rapper-economist combo to boost growth, woo investments

OUR TAKE

Jayanta Bhattacharya
Senior Journalist

Within hours of assuming office, the Balen Shah-led regime in Nepal began to prioritise future tasks, especially those related to the economic challenges looming ahead. On March 29, it released a ‘Good Governance Blueprint, 2082,’ which proposed extensive policy, legal, and structural reforms to woo investments, and create an investment-friendly environment. “The blueprint, released with the target of preparing a basis for economic growth under private sector leadership, has indicated removing obstacles to the mobilisation of internal and foreign investment, and transforming the state’s role from regulator to facilitator,” stated a report on a news website.

Balen Shah chose Swarnim Wagle, a 51-year-old economist with academic degrees from the London School of Economics, Harvard University, and Australian National University, as his finance minister to steer the country’s economy. Earlier, Wagle was a senior economist at the World Bank, and worked as the chief economic advisor for Asia and the Pacific at the UNDP. In his political career, the former Nepali Congress leader joined the Rastriya Swatantra Party (RSP) in 2023, after falling out with the former’s top leadership. His appointment reminds us of India’s choice of Manmohan Singh in 1991.

Rank-wise, Wagle will be second only to Prime Minister Balen Shah. “At the core of the government’s economic agenda is... a choice widely seen as an attempt to reassure markets and development partners,” according to a past media report. Days before the new cabinet took oath on March 27, a World Bank’s report, ‘Unlocking Nepal’s Growth Potential,’ examined the Himalayan nation’s past growth since 1996, challenges it faced now, and included recommendations for accelerated growth. While it remarked that Nepal “continued its remarkable success in reducing poverty, and has virtually eradicated extreme poverty,” it found the economy struggling “to keep pace... and has not generated enough quality jobs in the non-agricultural sector.”

According to the document, “In 1995, an esti-

mated 55 per cent of Nepal’s lived in extreme poverty, defined by the \$2.15 per day threshold. By 2023, this figure had plummeted to just 0.37 per cent. The speed and scale of Nepal’s success in eliminating extreme poverty are unparalleled among its peers.... The broad-based and deep reduction is evident in the poverty headcount ratio measured at \$6.85 per day, which fell from 90 per cent to below 50 per cent over the same time.” The key factor was migration, and the inflow of remittances.

“By 2021, over seven per cent of Nepal’s population had migrated abroad mainly in search of employment due to limited domestic job opportunities. Most of these migrants are young men, primarily seeking work in Gulf Cooperation Council (GCC) countries and Malaysia. This large-scale outmigration led to a substantial increase in remittances, and the number of households receiving them. By 2023, remittances accounted for around a quarter of Nepal’s GDP, playing a crucial role in sustaining the economy and lifting many out of poverty. The direct impact of remittances on poverty has been significant,” it added.

According to other reports, remittances remained “strong over the past two years, with monthly inflows exceeding 100 billion Nepali rupees (close to ₹62 billion).” Official data indicates that more than a trillion Nepali rupees came into the nation by mid-January of the fiscal year. However, “the sobering reality” is that the economy struggled to generate domestic quality jobs. Between 1996 and 2023, the economy grew at an average real annual rate of 4.2 per cent, which is respectable, but lagged that of peer nations. “Within South Asia, Nepal’s growth rate ranks just sixth out of eight countries. Both structural and aspiration peers outperformed Nepal as well,” the Bank’s report stated.

Another media report stated that among the key indicators, inflation was under control, remittances were high, and foreign exchange reserves a “more than adequate,” which were “positive signals.” But the “economic momen-

tum is slow, (although) there is no immediate risk of a crisis.” But one of the major concerns is the “inability to channel excess liquidity in banks into productive investment. Another challenge is reviving weakened domestic consumption.” The World Bank is hassled about the constraints on growth and job creation. Any economy that is built on remittances, or post-box economy, as Kerala was once dubbed, is unsustainable, as examples from the Indian states indicate.

“Overall labor productivity remains low. Weak competition in logistics and transport, as well as subpar infrastructure have limited exports, which have not contributed to... growth over the past decades. Appreciating real exchange rates and domestic trade policies, including high tariffs and excise taxes, have further constrained exports. The manufacturing sector has been in steady decline... while the tourism sector, a key growth and job opportunity, remains underdeveloped. The development of hydropower has progressed slowly.... Limited infrastructure, regulatory challenges, and digital literacy gaps are holding back... digitalisation,” stated the Bank’s document.

According to the Bank, “Nepal’s Rupee was pegged to the Indian Rupee in 1993 (at about 1.6 NPR), without any subsequent adjustments to the peg. Higher inflation in Nepal compared to the main trading partners, India and the United States, has appreciated bilateral RERs. While average inflation... decreased over the past decades, the average inflation differential compared to India still turned positive after 2014 and led to a real appreciation.” Before the national elections, Shah’s party promised to review the exchange rate with India.

More importantly, the existing policies did not lead to high growth rates, even as incomes, while growing, remained below the peers. The last plan document envisioned an annual growth of more than seven per cent until 2029. Baseline projections estimate the long-term growth to hover around four per cent. At the latter rate, Nepal’s income levels will reach only 65 per cent of structural peers’ levels, and less than a third of its aspirational peers by 2050. “Bridging this gap requires a decisive policy shift,” suggested the Bank’s report.

Hence, unlocking opportunities is a good and great first step for the new Balen Shah regime. However, as luck has it, the government assumes power when the world is embroiled in geopolitical, diplomatic, military, economic, and social crises. This explains why a recent media report warns, “Amid these conditions, rising tensions in the Middle East pose a growing risk to remittance inflows from Gulf countries. This could further suppress domestic demand, and impact foreign exchange reserves. The government will need to act to mitigate these risks.” Clearly, the risks are higher, red signals are flashing frenetically, and the remittances-based economy is under pressure. Can Shah wrap a new rap to revive the lives of ‘Sadak Balak’?

(The author has more than three decades of experience across print, TV, and digital media)

MUSSSAIB RASOOL MIR and SANTOSH KUMAR

The MAGA base reelected Donald Trump on the promises to end unnecessary interferences, and “endless wars” in foreign lands that dragged on for years, and hurt the domestic purchasing power. The US president built his image around the rhetoric of calling the previous wars as blunders that cost Americans blood and treasure. He famously opposed the wars in Iraq (2003), Afghanistan (2001-2021), Libya (2011), and the tendency of the presidents to change regimes in nations that were far from their spheres of influence.

The arrival of Trump as a “Peace President” was heralded as a gamechanger for geopolitics and world affairs. Yet, in his first tenure, he engaged in catastrophic decisions like bombing Iran (2020), airstrikes on Al-Qaeda, support to the Saudi Arabia-UAE interventions in Yemen and Syria, and sending troops to Syria and paratroopers at a base in Kuwait. During his second tenure, the 12-day war between Israel and Iran in June 2025, and the current more than one-month-old Iran war, which started one of the most ravaging multinational war after World War II, shows that Trump’s foreign policy can be characterised by an aversion to diplomacy, and a knee-jerk reliance on hostility.

An interesting feature of the ongoing war is Schrodinger’s dilemma. This diplomatic situation, which mirrors the probabilistic uncertainties of quantum physics, arises when there is ambiguity about the causes, impacts, rationale, and exits related to a war. In the case of the present crisis in West Asia, the public is left in a condition of perpetual uncertainty due to the leaders’ contradictory claims that the war is resolved while acting as though it is growing. Schrodinger’s wars are those which keep lurking, and remain incomplete, without a clear strategy on how to end the war.

So, temporary diplomatic measures substitute for concrete thought-out ones to end a particular phase of fighting, and postpone the war for the next level of escalation. Rhetoric, false victory parades, and biased media narratives emerge as useful tools to make the absurd phenomenon sound reasonable and rooted in strategic wisdom. This paradoxical thinking has engulfed the strategic thinking of nations, starkly evident with the Trump theatrics. What is interesting is that in most wars and conflicts related to Trump, he proclaims that he has ended them successfully. In reality, they lie low, and simmer for bigger clashes.

These Schrodinger’s wars, as we call them, witness brief pauses, yet the problem, the root cause, remains unaddressed, and brings

Trump’s Schrödinger’s problem

Ambiguity exists about Iran war’s causes, impacts, rationale

forth a series of fresh escalations. The paradoxical and contradictory stance to re-start an unfinished previous Schrodinger war in West Asia, does a de-service to the strategic realism and efforts at international peace negotiations. The lack of clarity is evident not only with the president but with the officials who crusade for the war to continue. Robert A Pape, an academician, made this argument to show how escalation favours Iran, and deliberate horizontal escalation by Iran has successfully worked.

Pape argues that “the initial strike (by Israel-US) may have solved a tactical problem, but it created a strategic one.” This is why a Schrodinger’s war collapsed the strategic thinking of the US, and its closest ally, Israel. Political pundits and commentators reason that the American war on Iran has backfired. In an article in the reputed Foreign Affairs magazine, Nate Swanson explains the reasons for the failure of strategic reality. Implicit in his arguments is Trump’s Schrodinger behaviour when he writes that

“Trump likely wants to declare victory soon.” But the success remains elusive, even as there is an urgency to declare the winners and losers by the administration without achieving the goals.

Over the past few weeks, the demands and guarantees regarding Tehran, initially total annihilation, roll back or end of nuclear enrichment, opening the Strait of Hormuz, and a peace minus Strait, have changed. Some demands related to nuclear and shipping issues were non-issues as Tehran fulfilled them before

the war. By dishonestly walking out of ongoing peace negotiations, and attacking Tehran, the US failed at a regime change. Last summer, Trump declared during the 12-day war that the US B2 bomber strikes ‘obliterated’ Iran’s nuclear programme. This was supported by the director of national intelligence, Tulsi Gabbard, before the Senate Hearings in March 2026.

Unable to decide why the US went to war, and what the goal of the war is, the admin-

istration behaves in a contradictory fashion. As David A Graham of The Atlantic magazine writes, “Now it cannot even decide whether the war is still going on.” In an interview during the first week of the war, Trump confidently declared, “I think the war is very complete, pretty much.” Yet, a post by the department of defense on X the same day stated, “We have Only Just Begun to Fight.” Such messages and conflicting signals can frustrate any war strategy.

Schrodinger’s wars inherently pose a threat to rational game theory. Aaron David Miller and Daniel C Kurtzer point in an article in Foreign Policy magazine that failed negotiations “reveal that the negotiating structure that US President Donald Trump has created to deal with conflict is a hot mess.” They argue that assigning important posts to relatives, sons-in-law, and best friends reveal the deep lack of strategic thinking minds. They add that family and friends “are no Kissinger. And when it comes to strategic thinking, Trump is no Richard Nixon (former president who tried détente with the USSR and China).”

The bottom line is that the war that Trump started has no good ending. At some point, he needs to choose the logic and stability of the market, or a continuation of war. What will be interesting to watch is how the Iranian elite military moves forward. The decapitation strikes on Iran, and Trump’s ‘little excursion’ phrase legitimised the Iranian guards, which now has the support of the majority Iran. Tehran does not seem to be in a mood to end the war on normal concessions after the Trump war legitimised their otherwise shattering credentials.

By doing this, Trump created a legacy which only he feels will be remembered for its good conclusions. His war and diplomacy legacy may well turn out to be an acknowledgement that he, as we said before, is no Nixon, who with his national security advisor and secretary of state, the renowned Henry Kissinger, pulled off three history-defining moments. They opened the pathway to China, initiated Paris peace accords on Vietnam, and worked on three disengagement accords after the 1973 Arab-Israeli war.

(Mir is senior research fellow, Central University, Punjab, and Kumar is assistant professor, Central University, Punjab)



R to L - Prof. Nirmal Kumar Ganguly, Former Director General, ICMR; Mr. Sushil Kumar, Former Secretary, Ministry of Mines; Mr. Anil Rajput, Chairperson, Advisory Council, Illness to Wellness Foundation and Dr. Piyush Jain, National Secretary, Physical Education Foundation of India felicitating winner students who participated in the drawing competition organised by the Illness to Wellness Foundation

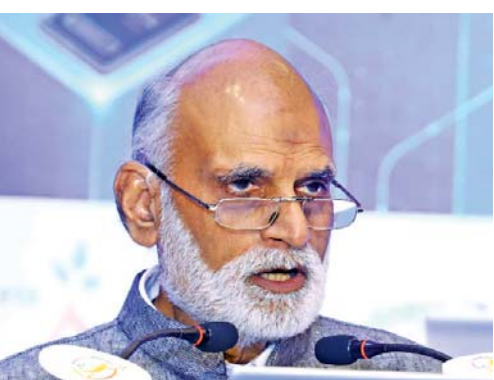
Digital Push Meets Traditional Wisdom: India's Holistic Healthcare Vision Takes Centre Stage at ITW Summit



Mr. Rajesh Bhushan, Former Secretary, Ministry of Health & Family Welfare, Government of India and Chairperson, Governing Council, Illness to Wellness Foundation



Dr. Manoj Nesari, Senior Chief Medical Officer (SAG), CGHS, Ministry of Health & Family Welfare, Government of India



Mr. Anil Rajput, Chairperson, Advisory Council, Illness to Wellness Foundation



(Padma Bhushan) Dr. T S Kler, Member, Advisory Council, Illness to Wellness Foundation and Chairman & HOD — BLK-Max Heart & Vascular Institute



Dr. Ravi Gaur, Co-Chair, FICCI Digital Health Task Force & Healthcare Awards and Founder — DRG Path Lab

As India grapples with a rising burden of lifestyle diseases and evolving healthcare needs, policymakers and health experts are increasingly turning toward a blended model—one that combines cutting-edge technology with the country's deep-rooted traditional knowledge systems. This vision took centre stage at the 4th Annual Summit on "Advancing Holistic Health through Innovation, Technology, and Tradition," organised by the Illness to Wellness Foundation, where leaders across government and healthcare outlined a roadmap for shifting India's healthcare focus from treatment to prevention.

Setting the tone for the summit, Prataprao Ganpatrao Jadhav, Union Minister of State (Independent Charge) for the Ministry of AYUSH, Government of India, emphasised that India's traditional systems—such as Ayurveda, Yoga, Unani, Siddha, and Homeopathy—have long promoted a balance between mind, body, and soul. He noted that when these systems are combined with modern medicine, they can help move healthcare beyond treatment toward complete well-being. Highlighting the growing prevalence of lifestyle diseases like diabetes and hypertension, he underlined that healthcare must begin at home, through daily habits and preventive practices, while also leveraging technology to scientifically validate and globalise India's traditional knowledge.

Building on this perspective, Rajesh Bhushan, Former Secretary, Ministry of Health & Family Welfare, Government of India and Chairperson, Governing Council, Illness to Wellness Foundation, stressed the need to redefine healthcare beyond curative approaches. He noted that healthcare must include preventive, promotive, palliative, and rehabilitative aspects—many of which are rooted in community settings. With India's vast and diverse population, he highlighted the importance of strengthening health-seeking behaviour and integrating public and private healthcare systems with traditional AYUSH practices. Bhushan also pointed to the growing role of digital infrastructure, including initiatives like ABDM and ABHA, along with artificial intelligence, in improving efficiency, interoperability, and access to healthcare services.

Reinforcing the importance of convergence, Anil Rajput, Chairperson, Advisory Council, Illness to Wellness Foundation, said that integrating traditional knowledge with modern medicine and emerging technologies is key to building an evidence-based and scalable healthcare model. He emphasised that policy alignment alone is not enough, and that community-level awareness and behavioural change are critical to driving the shift from illness to wellness.

Adding a deeper perspective on holistic health, Dr Manoj Nesari, Senior Chief Medical Officer (SAG), CGHS, Ministry of Health & Family Welfare, Government of India and Former Advisor, Ministry of AYUSH, highlighted traditional Indian concepts such as aarogya and swasth, explaining that true health goes beyond the absence of disease. He noted that a healthy individual is one who is physically fit, mentally balanced, well-nourished, and aligned with their natural state, while also contributing meaning-



L to R — Mr. Santosh Kumar, Founder, Santosh Yoga Foundation; Ms. Ishi Khosla, Founder, Cellac Society of India; Dr. Ishwar V. Basavaraddi, Professor, Center for Yoga; Dr. Rajesh Kesari, Member, Advisory Council, ITWF; Vaidya Shikha Prakash, Ayurvedic Consultant and Dr. Brender Sharma, Director (AYUSH), Government of NCT of Delhi



L to R - Dr. Sneha Sharma, Founder, Anvaya Healthcare; Dr. Rajesh Kesari, Member, Advisory Council, ITWF; Dr. (Prof.) Mina Chandra, HoD Psychiatry, Dr. RML Hospital; Ms. Richa Sharma, Principal, Ramjas International School; Ms. Anjali Malik, Principal, Jaypee Public School, Noida; and Ms. Swati Chawla, Director of Global Operational Wellbeing, Teleperformance



Mr. Prataprao Jadhav, Union Minister of State (I/C), Ministry of Ayush & Minister of State for Health and Family Welfare, Government of India, under the leadership of Prime Minister Narendra Modi, is committed to strengthening the integrated healthcare ecosystem. "Today, healthcare is not limited to hospitals; it must begin at home for individuals to focus on their overall well-being," Jadhav said while addressing virtually the 4th Annual Illness to Wellness Summit in the national Capital.

The Hon'ble Minister appreciated the efforts of the Illness to Wellness Foundation, FICCI, and The Pioneer for organising the summit.

fully to society and the environment.

Further emphasising the need for integrated care, Dr T S Kler, Chairman & HOD - BLK-Max Heart & Vascular Institute, said that healthcare systems must not only treat diseases but also build awareness around prevention, noting that many premature deaths today are linked to lifestyle and environmental risks.

Echoing the call for a systemic shift, Dr Ravi Gaur, Co-Chair, FICCI Digital Health Task Force & Healthcare Awards and Founder - DRG Path Lab, highlighted the importance of creating a culture of health ownership, stressing that stakeholders must focus on awareness and belief in preventive, person-centric healthcare.

Engaging Young Minds: Drawing Competition Highlights

A key highlight of the summit was the student drawing competition organised by the Illness to Wellness Foundation, reflecting its ongoing

commitment to grassroots engagement. The initiative, which has reached over 150 schools and nearly 40,000 students across the NCR region over the past three years, aims to instil awareness about health, hygiene, and environmental responsibility among young minds.

This year's competition saw participation from more than 50 schools across Delhi-NCR, with students presenting creative interpretations of themes such as health and hygiene, air pollution, and environmental sustainability. Notably, the event also encouraged participation from specially abled children, reinforcing inclusivity in public health awareness efforts. The summit featured a dedicated award ceremony recognising the winning entries, alongside a showcase of selected artworks that highlighted both creativity and consciousness around wellness.

Deep-Dive Discussions: From Mental Health to Digital Care

Beyond keynote addresses and ceremonial segments, the summit hosted a series of thematic sessions exploring critical dimensions of holistic health.

One of the central discussions, titled "Mindful Living: Mental Health for Work, Learning, and Life," focused on the growing importance of mental well-being in an increasingly high-pressure world. Experts highlighted the need to address stress, burnout, and emotional resilience across workplaces and educational institutions. The conversation underscored the importance of building supportive environments and normalising mental health discussions as part of everyday life.

Another key session on "Digital Health for Prevention and Well-being" examined how technology is reshaping healthcare delivery.

Panelists discussed the role of telemedicine, digital health infrastructure, and AI-driven systems in enabling early diagnosis, improving accessibility, and making healthcare more efficient and patient-centric. The discussion reinforced that digital tools are not just enablers of treatment but critical drivers of preventive care.

The third major session, "Integrating Traditional Practices for a Healthy Lifestyle," brought the spotlight back to India's rich heritage of wellness practices. Experts explored how yoga, meditation, Ayurveda, and nutrition can be seamlessly integrated into modern healthcare systems. The panel also discussed how digital platforms can help revive and scale these traditional practices, making them more accessible to contemporary audiences.

A Converging Vision for India's Health Future

Across sessions and speeches, a common thread emerged—the urgent need to redefine healthcare in India. Rapid urbanisation, changing lifestyles, and rising stress levels are contributing to an increased burden of chronic diseases, making preventive and holistic approaches more critical than ever.

The summit highlighted that the future of healthcare lies in convergence: combining cutting-edge technology with time-tested traditional knowledge, supported by strong policy frameworks and community participation. From digital health ecosystems to lifestyle interventions, from institutional reforms to grassroots awareness, the discussions pointed toward a multi-layered approach to building a healthier nation. Equally important was the emphasis on shifting mindsets—moving from reactive treatment to proactive wellness, from hospital-centric care to community-driven health, and from isolated interventions to integrated systems.

As stakeholders across government, healthcare, academia, and industry came together, the 4th ITW Summit reinforced a powerful message: India's path to a healthier future will not lie in choosing between tradition and technology, but in harmonising both to create a more inclusive, preventive, and sustainable healthcare ecosystem.



L to R — Dr. Rajiv Tandon, ED, The Health Continuum; Dr. S. K. Meher, Head Health-IT, AIIMS; Dr. Sudhir Kumar Kalhan, Member, Advisory Council, ITWF; Dr. Prabhukalyan Dash, Scientist B, ICMR- NIRDHDS; Ms. Hema Jagota, Member, FICCI Health Services Committee; Dr. Kaushlendra Singh, Cluster Head Operations, Motherhood Hospitals and Dr. Prashant Kulshrestha, Expert, Digital Health

FROM THE WORLD

PAKISTAN

Afghanistan talks begin

Pakistan and Afghanistan's Taliban Governments have resumed talks in China, which is mediating between the two sides to broker a durable ceasefire after more than a month of fighting, two Pakistani officials said on Wednesday. A third person who is in a position to know about China's mediation efforts said the talks were aimed at ending the current fighting. Representatives from both countries are meeting in Urumqi, in northern China, the officials told The Associated Press, speaking on condition of anonymity because they were not authorised to brief the media. China has not commented. Pakistan's Ministry of Foreign Affairs neither confirmed nor denied the latest development.

BURUNDI

Fire panic in military camp

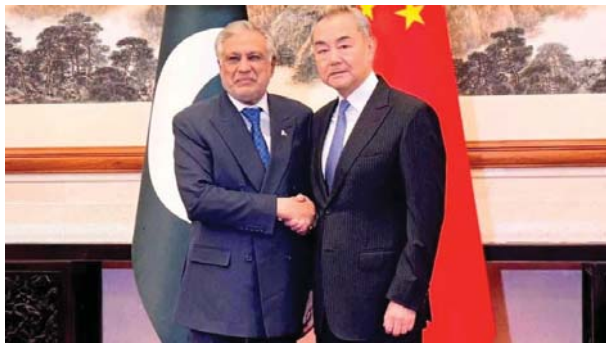
Residents of an area near a military camp in Burundi fled on Tuesday night after explosions were heard coming from the camp, due to what the army spokesperson later said was a fire caused due to an electrical fault at the armory. A fire caused by a short circuit in the ammunition storage room led to the detonation of explosives at the military camp located in Musaga, in the suburbs of the commercial hub of Bujumbura, said army spokesperson Gaspard Baratuza. The huge fire was visible from miles away, and residents could be seen fleeing from areas near the camp in videos shared on social media. "We would like to reassure the public that this is in no way an enemy attack, despite some rumours that have begun to circulate," Baratuza said. Electricity within the camp and neighbouring areas was cut off as civilians moved away from the camp. "We ask residents of the Gasekebuye, Kanyosha, Kinindo areas and surrounding neighbourhoods to remain calm and not give in to panic," Baratuza said By Wednesday morning, calm returned to the area, according to the local government administrator.

China, Pakistan propose peace plan for West Asia

KJM VARMA/SAJJAD HUSSAIN
■ Beijing/Islamabad

China and Pakistan have put forward a five-point proposal to end the West Asia conflict, calling for the restoration of peace and stability in the Gulf region and safe passage of ships through the Strait of Hormuz.

The peace proposal was put forward on Tuesday after Chinese Foreign Minister Wang Yi held talks with Pakistan's Deputy Prime Minister and Foreign Minister Ishaq Dar, who undertook a one-day visit to Beijing to discuss regional developments. The two reviewed the situation in the Gulf and West Asia region, and Dar briefed



Wang about his recent talks with the foreign ministers of Türkiye, Egypt and Saudi Arabia to promote talks between the US and Iran to end the ongoing conflict.

Following the Dar-Wang talks, the two countries put forward five proposals on

restoring peace and stability in the Gulf region and West Asia, as well as safe passage through the Strait.

The proposals included the immediate cessation of hostilities, initiation of peace talks as soon as possible, ensuring the safety of

non-military targets and safety of navigation, and safeguarding the primacy of the UN Charter.

"China and Pakistan call for immediate cessation of hostilities and utmost efforts to prevent the conflict from spreading. Humanitarian assistance must be allowed to all war-affected areas," according to a joint statement.

They called for starting peace talks as soon as possible. "Sovereignty, territorial integrity, national independence and security of Iran and the Gulf states should be safeguarded. Dialogue and diplomacy is the only viable option to resolve conflicts," the statement said. (PTI)

Oil, gas prices won't immediately return to normal even if Iran war ends, EU warns

MENELAOS HADJICOSTIS
■ Nicosia

Skyrocketing oil and gas prices in Europe as a result of the ongoing Iran war won't return to normal levels any time soon, even if peace is declared tomorrow, the European Union's energy commissioner warned Tuesday. Commissioner Dan Jorgensen said although there are no immediate oil and gas supply shortages in the 27-member bloc, there's pressure on diesel and jet fuel supply as well as "increasing constraints" in global gas markets that are resulting in higher electricity prices.

"What I find extremely important is to state as clearly as I can, that even if that peace is here tomorrow, still

we will not go back to normal in a foreseeable future," Jorgensen told a news conference after a meeting of EU energy ministers.

He said the EU's executive arm is preparing a string of measures designed to help families and businesses weather the huge spike in oil prices that have resulted in about a 70% price hike for gas and 60% for oil in Europe.

Since the start of the war, the EU's bill for imported fossil fuels has jumped by 14 billion euros, according to Jorgensen. Closely coordinated action between all EU members is necessary to "avoid fragmented national responses and disruptive signals to the markets," he said. The "toolbox" of measures now in the works will



be unveiled "quite soon" and will include ways to make it easier for states to decouple gas prices from electricity prices, the commissioner said.

He added that a tax cut on electricity, as suggested by Commission President Ursula von der Leyen is also being weighed. Jorgensen said

although he doesn't foresee a repeat of the 2022 natural gas crisis where companies reaped huge profits from a massive gas price hike, a one-

time "windfall tax" on such companies "is a possibility".

There are now "good opportunities" for member states to financially support vulnerable groups or industries now under "extraordinary stress" and that the Commission would make "these possibilities even simpler and wider," said Jorgensen.

Jorgensen also encouraged EU members to consider the International Energy Agency's 10-point plan which includes work from home, reduced highway speeds, encouraging public transport and increasing car sharing.

He said the EU stands by its ban on Russian gas purchases, which is meant to reduce dependence on Russian gas and choke off funding for

Russia's war in Ukraine.

Reliance on Russian gas dropped from 45% before the war to 10% now and will be reduced to zero once imports from other suppliers ramp up, especially from the US. The EU is looking at new energy sources from Azerbaijan, Algeria and Canada as well as smaller producers around the world.

The commissioner warned the EU should never "repeat the mistakes of the past allowing Putin to weaponise energy against us and blackmail member states". He added that "it would be totally unacceptable" for the EU to continue buying energy that would "indirectly help finance the terrible war that Putin is conducting in Ukraine". (AP)

USCIS completes H-1B cap selection process for FY 2027

SAGAR KULKARNI
■ Washington

The US Citizenship and Immigration Services (USCIS) said it has met the annual quota of 85,000 H-1B cap beneficiaries for FY-2027 and completed the regular and advanced-degree selection lotteries.

The agency said it had notified all prospective beneficiaries with selected beneficiaries that they are eligible to file an H-1B cap-subject petition for those beneficiaries.

The H-1B visa programme is used largely by US technology companies to hire foreign workers. Indian professionals, including tech workers and physicians, form one of the largest groups of H-1B visa holders. "H-1B cap-subject petitions for FY 2027, includ-



ing those petitions eligible for the advanced degree exemption, may be filed with USCIS beginning April 1, 2026, if filed for a selected beneficiary and based on a valid registration," a USCIS statement said here on Tuesday.

It said the period for filing the H-1B cap-subject petition will be at least 90 days and asked petitioners to include

a copy of the applicable selection notice with the FY 2027 H-1B cap-subject petition.

The USCIS said it would accept the new edition of the I-129 form that was published on February 27 this year.

The H-1B selection process is shifting to a wage-based model, where applicants with higher salaries and skills are given priority. (PTI)

India receives first batch of light machine guns from Israel

HARINDER MISHRA
■ Jerusalem

A leading Israeli small arms manufacturer has delivered the first batch of light machine guns (LMGs) to India under the 'Make in India' initiative with technology transfer.

The first batch of 2,000 NEGEV 7.62x51 LMGs, part of a larger contract for 41,000 units, was delivered over the last weekend, with an additional 4,000 scheduled for delivery later this year, the Israel Weapons Industries (IWI) said in a press release.

The delivery was carried out by PLR Systems, a joint venture between IWI and Adani Group, the first private company in India to manufacture small arms and ammunition. "The milestone follows the successful completion of the technology



transfer process under India's 'Make in India' initiative and reflects IWI's commitment to delivering advanced systems in accordance with contractual schedules and the highest quality standards, while supporting India's defence manufacturing ecosystem," the company said.

The NEGEV 7.62x51, one of the lightest 7.62 mm light

machine guns in its class with a semi-automatic mode, is deployed by the Israel Defence Forces (IDF) and is designed for reliability in harsh operational environments, offering high precision and effective target acquisition.

Its lightweight design and use of 7.62 mm ammunition enable it to penetrate fortified cover, making it suitable for

urban combat and critical missions. The weapon offers both semi-automatic and fully automatic modes and can be mounted on helicopters, vehicles and naval platforms for operational flexibility.

Equipped with Picatinny rails and tritium night sights, it is designed for improved targeting in low-light conditions, while compliance with NATO standards ensures durability. The NEGEV LMGs are also compatible with a computerised weapon system, aimed at enhancing operational effectiveness by enabling precise engagement of threats under stress, the release said.

Amid expanding India-Israel defence ties, PLR Systems has also secured a contract to supply 170,000 close-quarter battle (CQB) carbines, with the first 18,000 units scheduled for delivery this year. (PTI)

The Pioneer

Classified

CHANGE OF NAME

I, No. 4382866W, Rank: Sepoy, Khupman Amom, 1 Assam Regiment aged about 29 years, Aadhar Card No. 5043 6958 3711, a resident of Wangoo Naodakhong Chingya Leikai, P.O. Moirang. P.S. Kumbi, District: Bishnupur, Manipur have changed my name from Khupman Khual to Khupman Amom vide affidavit Dated 30 March, 2026 before notary Imphal West, Manipur, Govt. of India.

PD(721)C I, Uma W/o Sunil Kumar, residing at 258, Bhera Enclave, Paschim Vihar, S.O. West Delhi, Delhi - 110087, do hereby declare that the names Uma and Uma Khincheri refer to one and the same person.

PD(722)C I, Hira Wati W/o Shri Chandra Mani Maurya R/o House No F-65, Gali No. 6, Wazirabad Village, Burari, North Delhi - 110084, have changed my name to Hirawati Maurya.

PD(724)C I, Maurya Seema Gauri Shankar D/o Shri Gauri Shankar Maurya R/o House No F-65, Street No 6, Wazirabad Village, Burari, North Delhi - 110084, have changed my name to Seema Maurya.

PD(725)C I, Chandra Mani S/o Shri Babu Lal Maurya R/o House No F-65, Gali No. 6, Wazirabad Village, Burari, North Delhi - 110084, have changed my name to Chandra Mani Maurya.

PD(726)C I, Vivek Kumar S/o Shri Chandra Mani Maurya R/o V M's Cottage, F-65, Street No. 6, Yamuna Biodiversity Park, Wazirabad Village, Burari, North Delhi - 110084, have changed my name to Vivek Maurya.

PD(727)C I, Keshar Dev S/o Rameshwar Lal, R/o- I-360, Jhuggi Lakhipark, Jahangirpuri, Adarsh Nagar, Delhi-110033, have changed my name to Keshar Chand (both are same person).

PUBLIC NOTICE
Notice is hereby given that I, Abhishek Goel S/o Mr. Vinod Kumar Goel, intend to purchase property bearing No. E-341, Gaur Cascades, Rajnagar Extension, Ghaziabad, Uttar Pradesh - 201017. Any person(s) having any right, title, interest or claim in respect of the said property are required to intimate the same in writing with supporting documents within 10 days from publication of this notice, failing which such claim shall be deemed waived and the transaction shall be completed without further reference. Abhishek Goel Ph. No. : 9811294791

PUBLIC NOTICE
Known to all that my client Smt. Rekha owner of Plot MCF No. 4327 area 65.5 sq yds, Kharsa Mu. No. 10/25/2/2, Mu. No. 16, Killa No. 3/1/1, Village Gaunchi, Faridabad, and My Client Have lost original Sale deed No. 5423, dated 21.01.2010 in favour of Smt. Deepika Sharma, now My Client wants to sell aforesaid property. And it is informed that any deal with said documents by any person except my said client and said institution regarding said property, shall be deemed as null and void. If any person having any claim, right in said property then he may contact and handover the same and apprise his claim to undersigned within 15 days of this publication.

AD RPM LEGAL SOLUTION
Ch. No. 760 - Dwarka Court Sector-10, Dwarka, New Delhi-75
Mobile :- 9899013918

PUBLIC NOTICE
This is to inform the general public that Mr. Devraj Aggarwal S/o SH. P.R. Aggarwal R/o 17/96 Street No.5 Than Singh Nagar Anand Parbat Delhi-5 intends to purchase the property bearing No. 211 2nd & 3rd Floor with roof Right Vivekanand Puri Sarai Rohilla Delhi-110007 That property is being purchased from Mr. Ram Bilas Swarni S/o Prabu Ram Swarni who claims to be the lawful owner of the property. Any person or any entity having any claim, right, title, interest, dispute, or objection against the above-mentioned property is hereby requested to notify the same in writing along with supporting documents to the undersigned within 07 days from the date of publication of this notice. If no claim is received within the stipulated period, it shall be presumed that the property is free from all encumbrances, and the transaction shall be completed accordingly without any further reference.

DEVRAJ AGGARWAL
981081751

PUBLIC NOTICE
This is a notice to public at large that Our Client Raju Sharma S/o Late Sh. H K Sharma R/o C-178, 2nd Floor, Hari Nagar, Delhi- 110064 has severed all his relations with his elder son, Mr. Jasini Kumar Sharma. Our client has disowned his above named son from all his properties movable and immovable including property being C-178, 2nd Floor, Hari Nagar, Delhi- 110064. Anyone dealing with Mr. Jasini Kumar Sharma for any legal or financial matter will do so at their own risk and responsibility. Our client or his family members will not be responsible for any of the acts, deeds or liabilities in any manner whatsoever.

For And, Law Office,

Yudhvir B. Arya, Advocate
(E. No. D-2624/1999),
Ch. No. 531, S Block,
Delhi High Court, New Delhi-03

Public Notice
Notice is hereby given that one Mr. Mohit Jain (hereinafter referred to as the said Mortgages) have agreed to create mortgage in respect of the Property more particularly described in the Schedule hereunder written in favour of my client PNB Housing Finance Ltd., Sector-3, Noida. The Owner/Seller Mrs. Roma Kumar & Mrs. Bhavi Kumari has lost/ misplaced the Lease Deed executed by New Okhla Industrial Development Authority in favour of Mr. Babu Singh Madhur S/o Mr. Behari Singh, registered on 01.02.2003 in the O/o Sub Registrar Noida as per Book No. 1 Zild No. 1115 Page No. 867/880 & Document No. 689-90 in respect of the Leasehold Residential MIG House No. 32admeasuring area 112.5 sq. mtrs. in Block-C situated at Sector-15 in Noida Distt. Gautam Budh Nagar (U.P.). Any person having any claim against or in respect of the said property more particularly described in the Schedule hereunder written in favour of my client PNB Housing Finance Ltd., by way of sale, exchange, mortgage (equitable or deposit of title deed or otherwise), gift, trust, inheritance, family arrangement, maintenance, bequest, partnership, possession, lease, sublease, tenancy, license, lien, charge, pledge, easement or otherwise howsoever, are hereby requested to notify the same in writing to me with supporting documentary evidence at the address mentioned below within 7 days from the date hereof, failing which the claim, if any, of such person will be considered to have been waived and/or abandoned my client shall proceed with the disbursement of loan and creation of mortgage on the scheduled property.

Schedule showing the description of the property: Leasehold Residential MIG House No. 32a measuring area 112.5 sq. mtrs. in Block-C situated at Sector-15 in Noida Distt. Gautam Budh Nagar (U.P.). Date: 1.04.2026 Place: Ghaziabad

PUBLIC NOTICE
Notice is hereby given that my client Suraj Kumar Gound is in process to purchase the Residential Portion of Plot No. A-13/2, Measuring 25 Sq. Yds., Kharsa No. 661/2 Mi, situated at Krishna Vihar Colony, Village Brahmapur urf Bhopura, Pargana Loni, Tahsil & District Ghaziabad, UP (taking loan from Piramal Finance Ltd.) from Manoj Kumar, who inherited the same after the death of his mother, namely nanki vide will dated 6.6.2011 (doc. no. 193), Nanki acquired the said property vide sale Deed dated 6.6.2011 (doc. No. 4914). All persons having any claim against or in respect of the said Property, or any part thereof, by way of sale, exchange, mortgage (equitable/registered or otherwise), gift, trust, inheritance, family arrangement, maintenance, bequest, partnership, possession, lease, sublease, tenancy, license, lien, charge, pledge, easement or otherwise howsoever, are hereby requested to notify the same in writing to us with supporting documentary evidence at the address mentioned below within 7 days from the date hereof, failing which the claim or claims, if any, of such person or persons will be considered to have been waived and/or abandoned.

KamalKant Gupta (Advocate)
Unit No. FF-2, First Floor, Mahaluxmi Metro Tower Sec-4, Vaishali, Gz., U.P., Mob. 9810063351

PUBLIC NOTICE
Notice is hereby given that my client Suraj Kumar Gound is in process to purchase the Residential Portion of Plot No. A-13/2, Measuring 25 Sq. Yds., Kharsa No. 661/2 Mi, situated at Krishna Vihar Colony, Village Brahmapur urf Bhopura, Pargana Loni, Tahsil & District Ghaziabad, UP (taking loan from Piramal Finance Ltd.) from Manoj Kumar, who inherited the same after the death of his mother, namely nanki vide will dated 6.6.2011 (doc. no. 193), Nanki acquired the said property vide sale Deed dated 6.6.2011 (doc. No. 4914), whereas Manoj Kumar is not having the following documents: 1. Copy of Khatooni in the name of Babita Devi 2. Copy/ Original of Regd. GPA, ATS and WILL dated 12/07/1988 executed by Babita Devi in favour of Manoj Kumar (GPA-Doc No. 4474). 3. Copy of SMC/Legal Heir Certificate of Late Nanki, 4. CTC of Probate about WILL dated 06.06.2011, 5. Copy of HTR in favour of Manoj Kumar. All persons having any claim against or in respect of the said Property, or any part thereof, by way of sale, exchange, mortgage (equitable/registered or otherwise), gift, trust, inheritance, family arrangement, maintenance, bequest, partnership, possession, lease, sublease, tenancy, license, lien, charge, pledge, easement or otherwise howsoever, are hereby requested to notify the same in writing to us with supporting documentary evidence at the address mentioned below within 7 days from the date hereof, failing which the claim or claims, if any, of such person or persons will be considered to have been waived and/or abandoned. **KamalKant Gupta (Advocate)** Unit No. FF-2, First Floor, Mahaluxmi Metro Tower Sec-4, Vaishali, Gz., U.P., Mob. 9810063351

Security forces kill 13 terrorists in Pakistan

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Peshawar

Pakistani security forces have killed 13 terrorists in two separate operations in the northwestern Khyber Pakhtunkhwa province, the military's media wing said on Wednesday.

The operations took place on Monday and the terrorists belonging to Fitna al-Khawarij were neutralised, the Inter-Services Public Relations (ISPR) said.

Fitna al-Khawarij is a term the state uses for terrorists belonging to the banned Tehreek-e-Taliban Pakistan.

In the first intelligence-based operation (IBO) conducted in the Bara area of



Khyber district, security forces killed 10 terrorists.

In another IBO conducted in Bannu district, three terrorists were killed by security forces. The ISPR said sanitisation operations are being conducted to eliminate any other khawarij found in the area. Khyber Pakhtunkhwa has seen a rise in terrorist attacks over the past year.

Securing Iran's enriched uranium by force would be risky, complex: Experts

STEPHANIE LIECHTENSTEIN
■ Vienna

Should the US decide to send in military forces to secure Iran's uranium stockpile, it would be a complex, risky and lengthy operation, fraught with radiation and chemical dangers, according to experts and former Government officials.

US President Donald



Trump has offered shifting reasons for the war in Iran but has consistently said a primary objective is ensuring the country will "never have

a nuclear weapon". Less clear is how far he is willing to go to seize Iran's nuclear material. Given the risks of inserting as many as 1,000 specially trained forces into a war zone to remove the stockpile, another option would be a negotiated settlement with Iran that would allow the material to be surrendered and secured without using force. (AP)

Systematically crushing Iran: Netanyahu

HARINDER MISHRA
■ Jerusalem

Lauding “enormous accomplishments” in the war against Iran, Israel Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu said Tuesday evening that the joint Israel-US campaign was “systematically crushing” the Islamic regime while removing existential threats to the Jewish State.

Addressing the nation in Hebrew ahead of the Jewish festival of Pesach (Passover), Netanyahu stressed that “sooner or later” the Iranian regime will fall, while Israel creates “new alliances with important countries in the region” against the shared threat emanating from Tehran.

The Israel prime minister did not mention any country but in the passing simply said he hopes that “soon, I will be able to tell

you more about these vital alliances”. “On the eve of this Festival of Freedom, Israel is stronger than ever. The entire world hears our lion’s roar in our struggle against the evil regime in Iran, a struggle in which we have achieved immense, enormous accomplishments,” Netanyahu said.

The address came at a time when the nation is mourning the deaths of four soldiers in the ground operation in Lebanon. He expressed condolences saying that these achievements also come with “painful costs”.

“Marking one month of our joint campaign with the US, we are systematically crushing the terrorist regime that for decades cried: ‘Death to America, Death to Israel.’... the regime of the Ayatollahs made a massive effort to annihilate us, to take over the



Middle East, and to threaten the entire world”, the Israel Prime Minister claimed.

“It tried to promote these murderous ambitions through the development of nuclear programmes and ballistic missiles, the funding and arming of terror proxies around us, and by weathering the heavy sanctions imposed upon it”, Netanyahu said.

“Now, I want to tell you: Over the years, all of this has

cost Iran nearly a trillion dollars. And now it can be said: That trillion has gone down the drain”, he asserted. Drawing parallels with the legend of Passover, the Israel premier stressed that “we have dealt ten plagues upon the axis of evil” — the blow to Hamas in Gaza, the blow to Hezbollah in Lebanon, the blow to (Bashar) Assad in Syria, the blow to terrorist organisa-

tions in Judea and Samaria, the blow to the Houthis in Yemen, and five more blows to Iran.

Among the blows to Iran, Netanyahu counted the hit on “their nuclear programme, their missiles, the regime’s infrastructure, its forces of oppression, and the ‘Plague of the Firstborn’, or in our case, the blow to the senior leadership”.

“From the tyrant Khamenei, to the nuclear scientists, and onto the master-murderers of the Revolutionary Guard and the Basij, not to mention Nasrallah, Haniyeh, Deif, Sinwar, and many, many more”, Netanyahu said naming leaders of Iran, Hezbollah and Hamas assassinated by Israel since October 7, 2023.

Contending that Iran is “weaker than ever” and Israel “stronger than ever”,

the Netanyahu vowed that the campaign against the Islamic republic “is not yet over”. He also claimed that Israel had awakened the world to the dangers posed by Iran with most of the leaders quietly acknowledging but some also acting against it.

“I spoke with leaders in the Middle East in secret and in public meetings. I spoke with leaders in Europe. I also spoke with leaders in the US, with US presidents.

They did not internalise the danger. Today, there is no one who does not understand the magnitude of the threat. There are those who tell me in private conversations: ‘Prime minister, we understand. We are afraid to say it, but we understand’. And there are those who say: ‘We understand’, and, thank God, they are also acting”, he said. (PTI)

29 killed after Russian military plane crashes in Crimea



ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Moscow

A Russian military plane crashed in annexed Crimea, killing six crew and 23 passengers on board, Russian news agencies reported in the early hours of Wednesday, citing the country’s Defence Ministry.

The An-26 military transport plane was carrying out a scheduled flight over the Crimean peninsula, which Russia illegally annexed from Ukraine in 2014, the reports said. The military lost contact with the plane around 6 pm on Tuesday.

Russia’s top investigative agency, the Investigative Committee, said a total of seven crew members and 23 passengers were aboard the plane. It wasn’t immediately

clear from official statements if one crew member survived the crash. Russian news agency Interfax quoted the Defence Ministry as saying that they believe the crash was caused by a technical malfunction and that there was no “damaging interference” with the plane.

The plane crashed into a cliff, sources at the site of the crash told state news agencies Tass and RIA Novosti.

The Investigative Committee said it has launched a criminal probe on the charges of violating flight regulations, and a search operation was underway in a mountainous forested area in Crimea. The An-26 is a Soviet-designed military transport turboprop aircraft.

Judge halts WH ballroom construction

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Washington

A federal judge ordered the Trump administration to suspend construction of a \$400 million ballroom it demolished the East Wing of the White House to make space for, barring work from proceeding without congressional approval.

US District Judge Richard Leon in Washington granted a preservationist group’s request for a preliminary injunction that temporarily halts US President Donald Trump’s White House ballroom project.

The White House quickly filed a notice to appeal while Trump fumed at the ruling. “We built many things at the White House over the years. They don’t get congressional approval,” he told reporters in the Oval Office a short time later.

He also noted that the ruling will allow work on underground bunkers and other security measures around the White House grounds to continue — even though those will be paid for by taxpayers, not the private donors and Trump himself that the president has promised will cover the cost of the ballroom.

Leon, who was nominated to the bench by Republican President George W Bush, concluded that the National



Trust for Historic Preservation is likely to succeed on the merits of its claims because “no statute comes close to giving the President the authority he claims to have.”

“The President of the United States is the steward of the White House for future generations of First Families. He is not, however, the owner!” the judge wrote at the beginning of his opinion. The ruling was the first major rebuke of Trump’s sweeping efforts to overhaul the White House. But it wasn’t immediately clear what it would mean for a sprawling project in which crews have long since torn down the East Wing, radically transforming the look and feel of the historic grounds.

The White House has only released a partial list of the companies and individuals donating to build the ball-

room, and not said how much each is giving. Still, Trump rejected Leon’s ruling, saying, “This is being financed privately. It’s a donation.”

Biggest structural change to White House since Truman years: Construction of the ballroom would mark the most significant structural change to the White House since President Harry S Truman added a balcony on the south side of the mansion.

The judge’s decision came two days before the National Capital Planning Commission, the agency that signs off on construction on federal property in the Washington region, is expected to approve the addition. Stephen Staudigl, a spokesperson for the commission, said the judge’s ruling does not affect the schedule for Thursday.

Protests erupt in West Bank over Israeli death penalty law

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Jerusalem

Hundreds of protesters took to the streets across the embattled Palestinian territories on Tuesday, a day after Israel’s parliament passed a measure establishing the death penalty by hanging for Palestinians convicted of murdering Israelis. Palestinians young and old held sit-ins and marches in the Israeli-occupied West Bank, the territory where the new law is most sweeping. The Fatah political party has called a general strike in the northern part of the West Bank for Wednesday.

The legislation orders West Bank military courts - which try only Palestinians — to make the death penalty the default sentence for those convicted, except in special circumstances.

“Time is running out and silence is deadly,” read the signs carried by protesters in the central West Bank city of Nablus, which showed an animation of a prisoner wearing the Palestinian keffiyeh scarf next to a noose. “Stop the law to execute prisoners, before it’s too late.” The bill passed its final vote in the Israeli parliament late Monday to cheers and applause. Itamar Ben-



Gvir, the Israeli firebrand minister of national security who spearheaded the push for the legislation, described the law as long overdue and a sign of strength and national pride.

The law is set to take effect in 30 days but its implementation could be delayed by pending court proceedings at Israel’s highest tribunal.

The measure is not retroactive and won’t apply to current prisoners. Still, it signalled an extreme hardening of Israeli penal policy that elicited fear from the protesters for all Palestinian prisoners in Israeli jails — emblems of national resistance. “You are the symbol of struggle, You are the symbol of steadfastness,” the protesters in Nablus chanted, some holding up signs with the faces of friends and family currently in Israeli prisons. Palestinian

officials released statements saying the death penalty measure violated international law and asking other countries to intervene. Amnesty International has said that the use of the death penalty under the new measure could violate the right to life and the prohibition of torture and other cruel, inhuman or degrading treatment or punishment, as enshrined in international law. The Palestinian Foreign Ministry called for sanctions on Israel’s parliament and its suspension from international bodies.

“The law represents a critical turning point in the formalisation of extrajudicial killings under a legal guise,” the statement said, adding that the ministry “stresses that this law, in its essence, constitutes an institutionalised policy of field executions based on discriminatory and racist standards.”

Trump signs executive order on national voter list

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Washington

President Donald Trump signed an executive order creating a nationwide list of verified eligible voters, a move that is sure to draw legal challenges as the president continues to demand further restrictions on voting ahead of this year’s midterm elections.

The order calls on the Department of Homeland Security, working in conjunction with the Social Security Administration, to make the list of eligible voters in each state. It also seeks to bar the US Postal Service from sending absentee ballots to those not on each state’s approved list, although the president likely lacks the power to mandate what the Postal Service does.

Trump is also calling for ballots to have secure envelopes with unique barcodes for tracking, according to the executive order, which

was first reported by the Daily Caller.

“I think it’s going to be really great,” Trump said.

Yet Tuesday’s order is expected to prompt legal challenges, as the president continues to try to interfere with state-run elections.

Trump’s first election executive order in March sought sweeping changes to how elections are run across the country, including adding a documentary proof-of-citizenship requirement to the federal voter registration form and requiring mailed ballots to be received at election offices by Election Day.

Much of it has been blocked through legal challenges brought by voting rights groups and Democratic state attorneys general who allege it’s an unconstitutional power grab that would disenfranchise large groups of voters. He also said in a February interview with a conservative podcaster that he wants to “take over” elec-



tions from Democratic-run areas, citing fraud allegations that numerous audits, investigations and courts have debunked.

Tuesday’s voting order shows he hasn’t learned from his previous, blocked efforts to assert control over elections, said David Becker, a former Justice Department lawyer who leads the Center for Election Innovation and Research. “The Constitution is very clear - the president has no power over elections

in the states,” Becker said. “This will be blocked as soon as lawyers can get to the courthouse.”

Elections in the US are unique because they are not centralised. Rather than being run by the federal government, they’re conducted by election officials and volunteers in thousands of jurisdictions across the country, from tiny townships to sprawling urban counties with more voters than some states have people.

Kidnapped journalist warned of threats: US, Iraqi officials

QASSIM ABDUL-ZAHRA
■ Baghdad

An American journalist who was kidnapped in Baghdad had tried to cross from Syria into Iraq three weeks earlier and was initially turned back, an Iraqi official said on Wednesday.

US and Iraqi officials said Shelly Renee Kittleson had also been warned of threats against her in the days before her abduction. A freelance journalist who has worked for years in Iraq and Syria, Kittleson was kidnapped from a street in the Iraqi capital Tuesday and remains missing.

Hussein Alawi, an adviser to Prime Minister Mohammed Shia al-Sudani, said Kittleson had sought to enter via the al-Qaim crossing from Syria on March 9 but was turned back because she did not have a press work permit and because of security concerns due to “the escalation of the war



and aerial projectiles over Iraqi airspace as a result of the war on Iran.”

She later entered the country after obtaining a single-entry visa to Iraq valid for 60 days issued to allow foreign citizens stranded in neighbouring countries to “transit through Iraq to reach their home countries via available transport routes,” he said. Kittleson entered Baghdad a few days before she was kidnapped and was staying in a hotel in the

capital, he said. “The incident is being followed closely by Iraqi security and intelligence agencies under the supervision of” al-Sudani, Alawi said. He noted that one suspect believed to be involved in the kidnapping plot has been arrested and is being interrogated. Iraqi security forces gave chase to her captors and arrested one suspect after the car he was driving crashed, but other kidnappers were able to escape with the journal-

ist in a second car. An Iraqi intelligence official who spoke on condition of anonymity because he was not authorised to comment, said Iraqi authorities believe she is being held in Baghdad and are trying to locate her and secure her release. He said authorities “have information about the abducting party” but declined to give more details.

US officials have alleged that Kittleson was taken by Kataib Hezbollah, an Iran-linked Iraqi militia that has been implicated in previous kidnappings of foreigners. The group has not claimed the kidnapping and the Iraqi government has not publicly said anything about the kidnappers’ affiliation.

The Iraqi intelligence official said that prior to Kittleson’s abduction, Iraqis had contacted US officials to notify them that there was a specific kidnapping threat against her by Iran-affiliated militias. (AP)

Maritime company seeks probe into tanker hit that killed Indian crew

YOSHITA SINGH
■ New York

A global maritime company has called for an independent international investigation into an attack on one of its crude oil tankers last month that killed an Indian crew member, describing it as a threat to global shipping and trade stability.

Safesea Group Chairman Dr SV Anchan has sought a probe into the March 11 attack on MT Safesea Vishnu, saying that the “sequence of events indicates a highly coordinat-



ed and premeditated operation involving reconnaissance, precision execution, and apparent real-time monitoring, raising serious concerns for global shipping.”

The Marshall Islands-

flagged vessel was operating in Iraqi territorial waters when it was attacked off Khor Al Zubair port near Basra in Iraq, allegedly by an Iranian “suicide” boat. Mumbai resident

Deonandan Singh, 55, a senior crew member, was killed in the attack.

The tanker was anchored at Khor Al Zubair and was engaged in routine ship-to-ship loading operations. It had already completed part of its cargo operations alongside the berth and had shifted to anchorage to complete the loading of approximately 53,000 metric tonnes of naphtha. In a statement to PTI, the company said that “unidentified high-speed boats were observed conducting repeated movements

around anchored vessels a day prior, suggesting possible reconnaissance and target mapping”. “The subsequent use of unmanned explosive-laden craft points to a high degree of planning and operational capability,” it said.

Safesea said the matter warrants a “transparent international investigation, potentially under” the oversight of the International Maritime Organisation (IMO) and the United Nations. “This incident is a stark reminder that maritime security cannot be taken for granted. (PTI)

Sanctioned Russian tanker docks in Cuba

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Matanzas (Cuba)

A Russian tanker docked Tuesday at the Cuban port of Matanzas laden with 730,000 barrels of oil, marking the first time in three months that an oil tanker reached the island.

The administration of US President Donald Trump had allowed the Anatoly Kolodkin to proceed despite an ongoing US energy blockade. Cubans including Energy and Mines Minister Vicente de la O Levy cheered the ship’s arrival. A shortage



of petroleum has exacerbated a deep economic crisis that has left the population mired in long blackouts and facing a severe shortage of food and medicine. “Our gratitude to the

Government and People of Russia for all the support we are receiving. A valuable shipment that arrives amid the complex energy situation we are facing,” de la O Levy wrote on X.

PROSPECT



CM Himanta Biswa Sarma at Vijay Sankalp Samaroh at Belsor, Tihu in Assam



Nagaland BJP President Benjamin Yephthomi held a meeting with the Yimden of Chungtia village alongside minister Temjen Imna Along and adviser Kropol Vitsui

COAL INDIA PRODUCTION DIPS 1.7% TO 768.1 MT IN FY26



Coal India Ltd on Wednesday said its production dropped by 1.7 per cent to 768.1 million tonne in the just-concluded FY26. The company, which accounts for over 80 per cent of domestic coal output, produced 781.1 million tonne (MT) in FY25.

According to the provisional data of Coal India Ltd (CIL), the output in March dropped to 84.5 MT from 85.8 MT in the year-ago period. The company's coal offtake, the quantity of coal dispatched from mines to consumers, during FY26 also declined by 2.4 per cent to 744.8 MT from 763 MT in FY25. Coal India Ltd is the main fuel supplier to the country's power sector, providing the bulk of coal required by thermal power plants. Its role is central to energy security, especially as coal still accounts for roughly 70 per cent of India's power generation, even amid rapid growth in renewables.

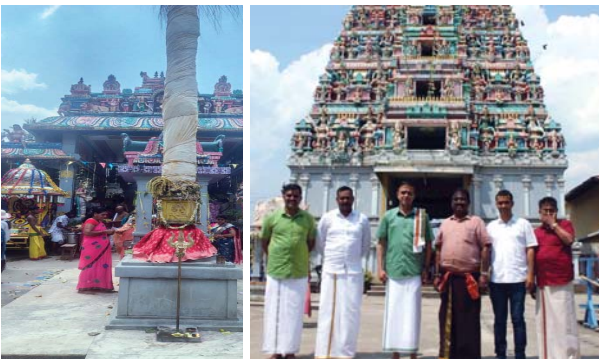
Assam Rifles bolsters fire-walking festival

TONY DAS
■ Moreh

In a significant move towards fostering cultural and social harmony in the sensitive border town of Moreh, the Assam Rifles provided comprehensive security and logistical support for the 59th Fire-Walking Festival. The ten-day event, which concluded on Wednesday at the Shree Angala Parmeshwari Shree Muneeshwarar Temple, served as a vibrant symbol of cultural synergy amidst the ongoing efforts to maintain peace in Tenguoupal district.

Organised by the Tamil Sangam, the festival commenced on March 23 and saw a massive turnout of devotees not only from the Tamil, Meetei, Nepali, and Bihari communities but also from neighbouring Myanmar. The tradition, rooted in faith and resilience, transformed the temple premises into a hub of social integration.

"The successful conduct of the festival stands as a testament to the enduring spirit of



unity and cooperation in the region," a senior official remarked.

Assam Rifles personnel provided robust security arrangements that ensured a peaceful environment for all rituals, facilitated the smooth movement of devotees across the border township, and organised a daily community kitchen (langar) serving approximately 450 to 500 devotees throughout the festival period.

The event was graced by the Deputy Inspector General of Assam Rifles, whose presence was hailed by local

leaders as a vital factor in ensuring the stability of Moreh. Local residents and members of the Tamil Sangam expressed their gratitude for the sustained outreach, noting that such initiatives go a long way in strengthening the bond between the "Sentinels of the North East" and the civilian population.

The festival concluded with community feasts across various localities, reflecting a collective resolve to preserve regional traditions and restore a sense of normalcy to the area.

Dharmendra Pradhan attends inaugural ceremony of Birla school in Odisha

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Sambalpur (Odisha)/New Delhi

Strengthening the educational landscape of western Odisha, Birla Open Minds International School has proudly inaugurated its new campus in Sambalpur. The inauguration ceremony was graced by the Union Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan. The event witnessed enthusiastic participation from esteemed guests, educators, parents, and members of the local community.

Speaking on the occasion, Pradhan said, "Education is the foundation of a strong and self-reliant India. It is encouraging to see institutions like Birla Open Minds International School bringing world-class, future-ready learning environments to emerging cities like Sambalpur. Such initiatives play a crucial role in nurturing young minds, fostering innovation, and preparing students to contribute meaningfully to the nation's growth and global progress."



The inauguration ceremony concluded with cultural performances by students and interactions between the minister, school management and attendees, marking the formal opening of the new educational institution in Sambalpur.

In a post on social media platform X, Pradhan said, "I am excited to inaugurate Birla Open Minds International School in the Sambalpur parliamentary constituency. On this important occasion, I extend my heartfelt congratulations to the school family and best wishes to the citizens of Sambalpur, the students,

and their parents." Echoing this vision, Nirvaan Birla, Managing Director, Birla Open Minds Education, stated, "At Birla Open Minds, our vision has always been to make quality, holistic education accessible beyond metropolitan cities. The launch of our Sambalpur campus reflects our commitment to nurturing well-rounded individuals equipped with the skills, values, and mindset required for the future. We are proud to be part of Sambalpur's educational journey and look forward to shaping young learners into confident global citizens."

Trade unions observe Black Day against Labour Codes

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Following a call by a joint platform of ten central trade unions, workers across the country observed a 'Black Day' on Wednesday to protest against the Union Government's four controversial Labour Codes. Workers donned black badges and headbands, asserting that the new legislations would push the country's "wealth producers" back into a colonial-era state of exploitation.

The demonstrations, which included dharnas, black-flag marches, and motorcycle jathas, were spearheaded by a united front of major unions, including the Indian National Trade Union Congress (INTUC), All India Trade Union Congress (AITUC), Hind Mazdoor Sabha (HMS), and Centre of Indian



Trade Unions (CITU).

Other participating organisations included the All India United Trade Union Centre (AIUTUC), Trade Union Coordination Centre (TUCC), Self-Employed Women's Association (SEWA), All India Central Council of Trade Unions (AICCTU), Labour Progressive Federation (LPF), and United Trade Union Congress (UTUC), alongside several independent sectoral federations.

In a joint statement, the unions alleged that the Government is prioritising "Ease of Doing Business" over the fundamental rights of the proletariat. They argued that the new codes threaten nearly a century of hard-won legal protections, including those enshrined in the Trade Unions Act of 1926.

"These labour codes are designed to push the workforce into conditions akin to slavery. They contravene the

spirit of the Indian Constitution, International Labour Standards, and basic human rights," the platform stated.

The agitators are demanding the immediate scrapping of the "pro-employer" codes and have called for an urgent Indian Labour Conference to facilitate genuine tripartite consultations. The unions reminded the Centre that the current legal framework — comprising 44 central laws and approximately 150 state legislations — was achieved through decades of post-Independence struggle.

Following the momentum of the general strike held earlier this February, the unions congratulated workers for their resolve and warned of "bigger struggles" ahead if the Government continues to ignore the demands of the labour and farming communities.

CBI registers case against Reliance Communications, Anil Ambani

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The CBI on Wednesday registered a fresh case against industrialist Anil Ambani and Reliance Communications Ltd for allegedly causing a loss of ₹3,750 crore to Life Insurance Corporation (LIC) of India, officials said.

The CBI has filed the case for the alleged offences of conspiracy, cheating and misappropriation and under the provisions of the Prevention of Corruption Act on a complaint from the LIC, making it the fourth case against the company and Anil Ambani, they said.

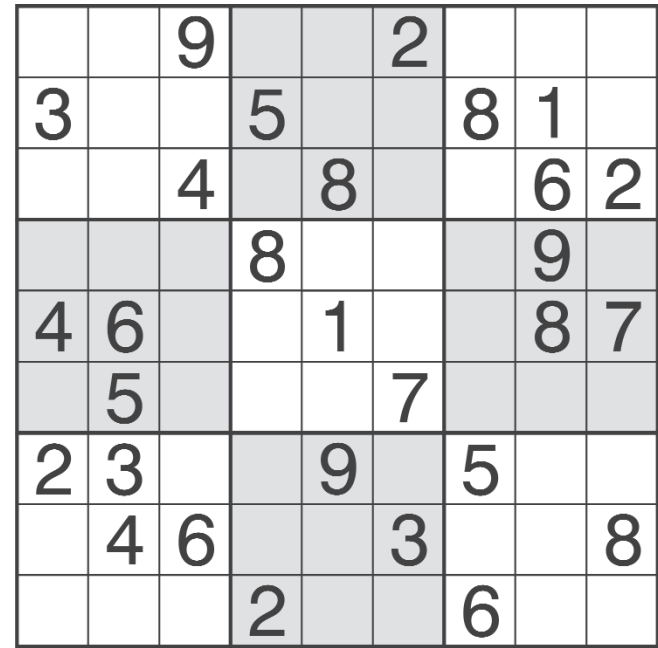
The agency has alleged that LIC was fraudulently induced to subscribe to Non Convertible Debentures (NCDs) worth ₹4500 crore between 2009 and 2012 on



the basis of false representations made by Reliance Communications Ltd and its management regarding the financial health of the company, and security and asset cover offered to LIC while subscribing to the NCDs.

The insurer suffered a loss of over ₹3,750 crore and ordered a forensic audit against the company.

DAILY SUDOKU



DIFFICULTY RATING: ★★☆☆☆

HOW TO SOLVE IT !

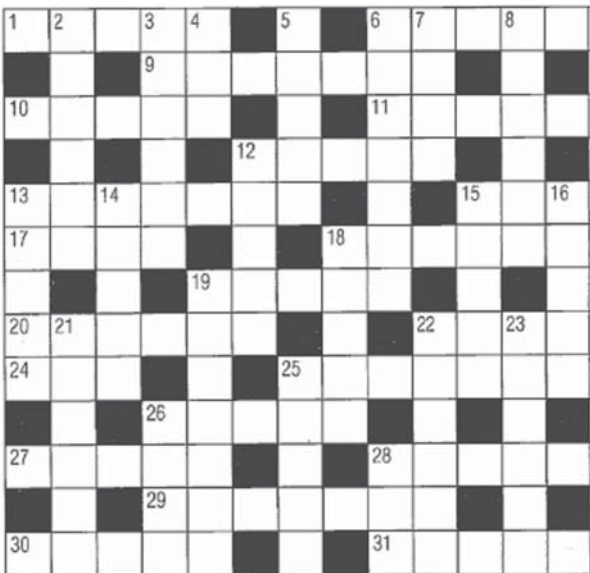
Sudoku is a logic puzzle where you fill a 9x9 grid so that numbers 1 to 9 appear once in every row, column, and 3x3 box, using elimination and logical deduction-no maths involved.



SOLUTION (01.04.26)

7	6	4	8	9	5	1	2	3
1	8	9	3	6	2	5	4	7
2	5	3	1	7	4	9	6	8
4	1	7	2	3	6	8	5	9
8	3	6	9	5	7	2	1	4
5	9	2	4	8	1	3	7	6
6	4	8	5	2	9	7	3	1
9	7	5	6	1	3	4	8	2
3	2	1	7	4	8	6	9	5

DOUBLE CROSSWORD
THURSDAY | APRIL 2, 2026



ACROSS

- 1 The one woman every political party should have (5)
6 Dog in a coop, perhaps, at a hotel (5)
9 A growth maybe considered ugly (4,3)
10 All this, to me, is incomprehensible (5)
11 Haughty letters to a public relations officer (5)
12 Feel uncertainly that Reg maybe out of work (5)
13 He lacks a full can, when paint is spilt (7)
15 Thus, at opening time, he fancies a drink (3)
17 But commonly halved (4)
18 Restraint on anaesthetic at the treatment centre (6)

DOWN

- 2 He made a conquest (6)
3 Went in some style to make a score (6)
4 Animal talk (3)
5 Forbidding rents to be revised (5)
6 Pops out for something to eat and some flowers (7)
7 Awesome character in two Greek plays (4)
8 He changed course and got shipwrecked (6)
12 At heart, forgiveness is never withheld (5)
13 Supposedly comfortable, it causes Charlie a cry of pain (5)
14 Beg to be given a quiet hint (5)

- 19 Tasteful listeners to the piano (5)
20 Scared to take a cottage soccer fans will have heard of (6)
22 It's strange for a nut to taste of fish! (4)
24 Caught in possession? (3)
25 Henry has just one objection to this on the menu (7)
26 Michael, with a charm that seems endless (5)
27 A greeting for everybody in the house (5)
28 Tom's mate? (5)
29 Photographed what was broken (7)
30 Where the Italians have no age difference? (5)
31 Approaches one's heart of hearts in various ways (5)

- 15 Be quiet and massage with a twiggy thing (5)
16 Handle with generosity (5)
18 Experimental cause of a rail crash at Acton Central (5)
19 Pearson's unusual character (7)
21 Wreak havoc with a grave consequence(6)
22 Tub-thumper's line in business? (6)
23 Comparatively insensitive song, say? (6)
25 Makes things easier when he's holding the record (5)
26 How a London orchestra gives an encore (4)
28 Then not a hot number? (3)

SOLUTION (01.04.26)

- ACROSS
3 Command (5)
8 Romantic flowers (5)
10 Sensational (5)
11 Afflict (3)
12 Prize (5)
13 Booby (7)
15 Based on truth (5)
18 Animal doctor (3)
19 Erase, renege (6)
21 Say in passing (7)
22 Plant ovule (4)
23 Jumps on one foot (4)
24 Gaseous element (7)
26 In error (6)
29 That man (3)
31 Skinfrit (5)
32 Permission, permit (7)
34 Hardresser's shop (5)
35 Decompose (3)
36 Post off (5)
37 Honor and glory (5)
38 Requires (5)
DOWN
1 Marsupial (5)
2 Dear (7)
4 Spool (4)
5 Number (6)
6 Rustic (5)
7 Call on (5)
9 So or thus (3)
12 Game of chance (7)
14 Farmer's bird (5)
16 Fruit (5)
17 Thick (5)
19 Marine mammal (7)
20 Religion (5)
21 Thaw (5)
23 Baseball term (4,3)
24 Martial art (6)
25 Facial twitch (3)
27 Flank (5)
28 Tree sap (5)
30 Theopist (5)
32 Noisy (4)
33 Signal agreement (3)

Vamsi Rama Mohan Burra takes over as CMD of POWERGRID

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Gurugram

Vamsi Rama Mohan Burra has assumed the charge as Chairman and Managing Director (CMD) of Power Grid Corporation of India Limited (POWERGRID), a Maharatna Central Public Sector Undertaking under the Ministry of Power. Prior to his elevation to the top post, he was serving as Director (Projects) within the organisation.

An engineering graduate with a Post Graduate Diploma in Planning & Project Management, Vamsi also holds a PG Diploma in Management from the Management Development Institute (MDI), Gurugram. His academic credentials are supplemented by the Harvard Manage Mentor (HMM) programme and advanced management programmes at Indian School of Business (ISB), Hyderabad.

His appointment marks a significant milestone for the corporation as he belongs to the first batch of Executive Trainees inducted into POWERGRID in 1993. With an extensive career spanning over 33 years in the power transmission and telecom sectors, Vamsi has held several strategic and policy-making roles at both regional and corporate levels.

His expertise covers a wide spectrum of business domains, including procurement, commercial, regulatory affairs, asset management, and projects. Notably, he was a founding member of POWERGRID's Regulatory Cell and a key architect in positioning the company within the competitive bidding market for power transmission.

During his tenure as the CEO of POWERGRID Teleservices Limited, he was credited with leading the expansion of the telecom business and initiating the organisation's maiden Data Centre project. A staunch advocate for mechanisation and digitalisation, Vamsi has been instrumental in introducing reforms in project monitoring, aimed at enhancing transparency and efficiency in large-scale infrastructure delivery.



Mopin Marathon celebrates fitness and festive spirit in Arunachal

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Itanagar

In a spirited celebration of community, culture and wellness, the Mopin Marathon was organised in Aalo, West Siang district of Arunachal Pradesh on March 31, 2026, in conjunction with the Mopin festival celebrations. Rooted in the festive ethos of Mopin, one of the most important agricultural festivals of the Galo community, the event reflected the values of togetherness, prosperity and collective well-being that define the occasion.

Conducted in two categories, 5 kilometres and 10 kilometres, the marathon witnessed enthusiastic participation by over 200 local residents along with 50 Army personnel. The event

brought together civilians and soldiers on a common platform, reinforcing mutual trust and shared purpose through sport. The vibrant turnout and energetic atmosphere highlighted the growing appeal of fitness-oriented public events in the region.

Cash prizes were distributed to winners in both the men's and women's sections of the 5 kilometre and 10 kilometre races.

The Mopin Marathon stood as a fitting expression of Aalo's festive spirit, cultural pride and commitment to healthy living.



 BRIEFLY

Graham Potter to dust off his cowboy hat

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Stockholm

Graham Potter said he will “dust off my cowboy hat” after fulfilling his short-term mission to get Sweden to the World Cup. The English coach was hired by Sweden in October after the national team's abject qualifying campaign that contained two draws and four defeats from its six group games.

The Swedes were afforded a second chance to qualifying through the playoffs by virtue of winning its lowly Nations League group the previous year and they took full advantage, beating Ukraine in the semifinals on Thursday and then Poland 3-2 in Stockholm on Tuesday.

Sweden will be playing Tunisia, the Netherlands, and then Japan in Dallas in Group F at the World Cup being held across the United States, Canada and Mexico starting in June.



Messi shines in likely last Argentina home game



DEBORA REY ■ Buenos Aires

In what was likely his final home appearance for Argentina's national squad, Lionel Messi scored a goal and provided an assist in a 5-0 rout of Zambia on Tuesday night in a farewell friendly ahead of the World Cup.

The 38-year-old Messi set up Julian Alvarez in the fourth minute and then scored in the 43rd at La Bombonera stadium in Buenos Aires. The crowd gave him a standing ovation and pleaded with him to help Argentina win another World Cup. The global tournament kicks off June 11 in the United States, Mexico, and Canada.

Nicolas Otamendi and Valentin Barco also scored for Argentina. The defending world champions raised some concern after their lackluster performance last Friday in a 2-1 victory over Mauritania. In the lead-up to the Zambia friendly, coach Lionel Scaloni had warned that if the team didn't improve its performance he would take drastic measures regarding the 26-man World Cup squad, which must be submitted by May 30.

For the last home game before the World Cup, Scaloni started with a lineup similar to that one that defeated France in the 2022 final, with the notable exclusion of midfielder Rodrigo De Paul, who is recovering from a muscle injury and performed poorly against Mauritania. (AP)

Woods to seek treatment after pleading not guilty to DUI

MIKE SCHNEIDER ■ Orlando

Tiger Woods said he is stepping away to seek treatment, four days after his vehicle crashed in Florida and he was arrested on suspicion of driving under the influence. He will miss the Masters for the second straight year.

“This is necessary in order for me to prioritise my well-being and work toward lasting recovery,” Woods said in social media posts.

Woods pleaded not guilty in his driving under the influence case in Florida on Tuesday, hours after a sheriff's report said deputies found two pain pills in his pocket and he showed signs of impairment after his SUV clipped a trailer and rolled over on its side.

The online court docket for



Martin County showed Woods entered a written plea of not guilty and planned to waive his April 23 arraignment hearing. It's the second time Woods has taken a leave following a car

crash. In 2009, after his SUV plowed into a fire hydrant and tree outside his home near Orlando, he took a leave of absence to work on being a better person. That lasted



four months and he returned at the Masters.

Woods showed signs of impairmentWoods' eyes were bloodshot and glassy, his pupils dilated and he had opioid pills — identified as hydrocodone — on him when interviewed at the scene of the crash, according to the arrest report released by the Martin County Sheriff's Office.

Woods' movements were slow and lethargic, he was sweating as he talked to deputies in the back seat of an air-conditioned car and he told them he had taken prescription medication earlier in the morning, according to the report.

Woods told deputies he had

ITALY OUT OF WORLD CUP AGAIN

ANDREW DAMPFAP
■ Zenica (Bosnia)

One of soccer's historic powers has reached a once-unfathomable low.

Four-time champion Italy failed to qualify for a third straight World Cup after getting beat in a penalty shootout with 10 men at 66th-ranked Bosnia and Herzegovina in the European playoffs on Tuesday.

Moise Kean scored early on for Italy but then Azzurri center back Alessandro Bastoni was sent off with a direct red card before the break and Bosnia substitute Haris Tabakovic equalised in the 79th to send the game into extra time at 1-1.

The defeat added more misery for Italy's once-proud national team after being eliminated by Sweden and North Macedonia, respectively, in the qualifying playoffs for the last two World Cups.

“It's too easy to say what's working and what's not working,” Italy coach Gennaro Gattuso said. “The fact is that Italy has failed to qualify for three World Cups. We're having a tough time achieving our goals, both with the national team and with our clubs.”

Bosnia won the shootout 4-1 and qualified for the first time since 2014 — its only previous



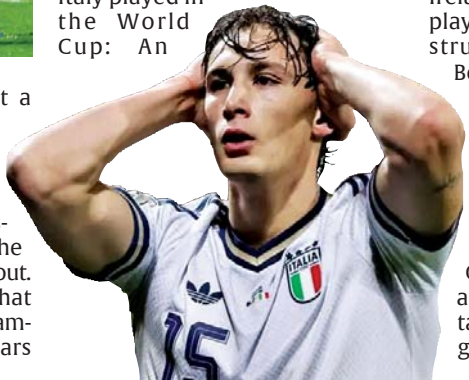
appearance. In the shootout, Pio Esposito and Bryan Cristante missed their spot kicks and US-born Esmir Bajraktarevic converted the decisive penalty for Bosnia.

“We still don't believe it — that we're out and that it happened in this manner,” Italy defender Leonardo Spinazzola said. “It's upsetting for everyone. For us, for our families, and for all the kids

who have never seen Italy at a World Cup.”

In Tuesday's other European playoff finals, Sweden, Turkey and the Czech Republic each qualified. Sweden beat Poland 3-2; Turkey beat Kosovo 1-0; and the Czechs beat Denmark in a shootout.

Italy's latest ouster means that the 1934, 1938, 1982 and 2006 champions will go at least 16 years



without even playing a match at soccer's biggest event.

Italy's World Cup struggles go back all the way to 2010 and 2014, having failed to advance from its group on both occasions. Although the Azzurri did win the European Championship in 2021. Italy's last World Cup knockout match was when it won the title in 2006 by beating France in a penalty shootout.

“We realise we're in a huge crisis,” Italian soccer federation president Gabriele Gravina said.

The only other World Cup that Italy did not qualify for was in 1958.

Lost generationAn entire generation — basically anyone under 15 — has no memory of the last time Italy played in the World Cup: An

elimination loss to Uruguay in 2014 in Brazil remembered for Luis Suarez's bite of Giorgio Chiellini's shoulder.

None of Italy's current players have participated in a World Cup finals. The defeat will raise questions about the status of Gattuso, who took over from the fired Luciano Spalletti in June with the squad already in crisis mode following a defeat at Norway in its opening qualifier.

The Azzurri then went on a six-match winning streak before losing again to Norway in November to finish second in their group and end up in the playoffs again.

Gattuso's Italy overcame a nervy scoreless first half to beat Northern Ireland 2-0 at home in last week's playoff semifinals. But the Azzurri struggled even more against Bosnia inside the intimate but imposing 14,000-seat Bilino Polje Stadium in Zenica, which is surrounded by apartment towers overlooking the field.

“I want to personally apologize since we didn't make it,” Gattuso said. “Today talking about my future is not important. Today it was important to get to the World Cup.” (AP)

Christian Pulisic scoreless streak for US extends to eight games

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Atlanta

As the World Cup nears, Christian Pulisic's scoreless streak for the United States stretched to a career-high eight games. “It's frustrating, but I'm just going to stay positive,” he said after Tuesday night's 2-0 loss to Portugal in a friendly. “A lot of big things ahead, and I know I'm going to get to the other side.”

Pulisic hasn't scored an international goal since a CONCACAF Nations League quarterfinal against Jamaica on November 18, 2024, and he's scoreless in 12 games with AC Milan since December 28.

US coach Mauricio Pochettino moved the 27-



year-old from a wing to striker for the first time since taking over in October 2024 in an effort to get him more chances closer to goal. Pulisic had 28 touches, up from 24 in the first half of Saturday's 5-2 loss to Belgium.

Pulisic missed the ball on

an open volley from a Tim Weah cross in the 22nd minute and was just wide from outside the penalty area in the 36th. Pulisic got a yellow card for dissent in first-half stoppage time for kicking Samu Costa after he was pushed off the ball.

Coach Gattuso not interested in talking about his future after Italy miss out on World Cup

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Zenica (Bosnia)

Italy coach Gennaro Gattuso said it is not the time to talk about his future despite the Azzurri failing to qualify for a third straight World Cup.

Even if Gattuso hasn't made up his mind whether to stay or not, the Italian soccer federation gave a clear sign it would like him to remain on Tuesday.

Four-time World Cup winner Italy lost a penalty shootout at 66th-ranked Bosnia and Herzegovina in the European playoffs on Tuesday, after playing most of the match with 10 men.

“I'm not interested at all in talking about my future today,” Gattuso said. “It



hurts, it really hurts. More than hurting me, it hurts to see this group which has really given everything in these months and I think we deserved to get back what we put in and I honestly think it's too reductive and too immature to be talking about my future today.

“Here we should be

talking about Italy, about the national team shirt, that it's yet another blow even though this time we didn't deserve it. We deserved more and that's why my future doesn't matter.”

Italy was eliminated by Sweden and North Macedonia, respectively, in the qualifying playoffs for the last two World Cups.

Tuchel confident England's 1-0 friendly loss to Japan won't hurt

MEGAN JANETSKY ■ London

Thomas Tuchel insisted England's dispiriting 1-0 loss to Japan in a friendly will have no bearing on the team's chances at the upcoming World Cup. England has lost some of the momentum built up under Tuchel by drawing with Uruguay at Wembley Stadium on Friday and then succumbing to Kaoru Mitoma's first-half goal for Japan at the same venue four days later.

Tuchel has fielded experimental lineups for both games, with key regulars like captain

Harry Kane, Declan Rice and Bukayo Saka missing because of minor injuries.

The German coach also said many of his players are “heavily invested” in their club campaigns at this stage of the season. For that reason, Tuchel felt sure “this camp will not define us.”

“It's just a reality



if teams like Uruguay or Japan come well-drilled, with their top lineup, it's a difficult task,” Tuchel said.

“It was not necessary to lose the match. Unfortunately, we lost it, which is disappointing, and I hate losing, like no one else, and it will take a while to digest. But it will not affect us massively for when we arrive in the US.”

Cole Palmer and Phil Foden are star players in the Premier League but battling to simply

make England's squad for the World Cup, and were given another chance to impress Tuchel after being handed starts against Japan. They failed to take it, with England especially poor in the first half when the team failed to score a shot on target for the first time in a friendly match since 2017, according to statistics company Opta.

With Morgan Rogers and Jude Bellingham other options as attacking midfielders, Palmer and Foden face anxious waits to see if they make the plane for the tournament. (AP)

World Cup qualifying marathon ends with Iraq securing final spot



ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Monterrey (Mexico)

The 48-team field for FIFA's biggest ever World Cup is complete after a qualifying process that spanned more than two and a half years.

Iraq edged Bolivia 2-1 in an intercontinental playoff at Monterrey in northern Mexico on Tuesday to secure the 48th spot, hours after Bosnia and Herzegovina upset four-time champion Italy on penalties in European playoffs.

Eight teams from Europe were competing for four places on the last day of qualifying. The new intercontinental tournament staged in Mexico determined the other two remaining places. The next-to-last nation to advance was Congo, which edged Jamaica 1-0 in extra time at Guadalajara, Mexico.

Sweden, Turkey and the Czech Republic each qualified in European playoff finals.

Sweden beat Poland 3-2; Turkey edged Kosovo 1-0; and the Czech Republic beat Denmark in a penalty shootout.

The World Cup kicks off June 11 and will be co-hosted by the United States, Mexico and Canada. With its big upset victory of Italy, Bosnia and Herzegovina qualified to join Canada, Qatar and Switzerland in Group B.

Sweden will play in Group F with the Netherlands, Japan and Tunisia. Turkey will be in Group D with the United States, Paraguay and Australia.

After reaching its first World Cup since 2006, the Czech team will play in Group A with Mexico, South Africa and South Korea.

The World Cup qualifiers for the 2026 tournament started Sept. 7, 2023 with matches in South America.

World Cup groups

Group A: Czechia, Mexico, South Africa and South Korea
Group B: Canada, Bosnia and Herzegovina, Qatar and Switzerland
Group C: Brazil, Haiti, Morocco, Scotland
Group D: Australia, Paraguay, Türkiye and United States
Group E: Curacao, Ecuador, Germany and Ivory Coast

Congo beats Jamaica in extra time to qualify for World Cup

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Guadalajara (Mexico)

Congo scored in extra time to edge Jamaica 1-0 and become the 47th of 48 teams that will play at the World Cup.

Axel Tuanzebe scored following a corner kick in the 100th minute of the intercontinental playoff. The Jamaican defenders failed to clear the ball and Tuanzebe, who plays for Burnley in the English Premier League tapped it into the net. Congo has never played in a World Cup under that name, although it participated in the 1974 edition in Germany as Zaire.

With its victory in the intercontinental playoff at the Akron Stadium in Guadalajara, Mexico, the Congolese team completes



Group K at the World Cup, where it will face Colombia, Portugal, and Uzbekistan.

“We're going to enjoy the qualification, but we'll keep working. We know we'll be facing top nations who play in the World Cup every four years,” Congo captain Chancel Mbemba said.

Portugal beats US 2-0 in World Cup warmup

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Atlanta

Francisco Trincao scored in the 37th minute, Joao Felix added a goal in the 59th and Portugal beat the United States 2-0 in a friendly on Tuesday night to deal the Americans their eighth consecutive defeat against European opponents.

US star Christian Pulisic was moved from a wing to the top of the attack but failed to convert a pair of good scoring chances.

Pulisic, who played only the first half, is scoreless in eight national team games dating to November 2024 and in 12 games with AC Milan since December 28.

Preparing to co-host the World Cup, the US has been outscored 22-6 during its losing streak against Europe and is winless against the continent in 10 matches since 2021.

US coach Mauricio Pochettino announces his World Cup roster on



May 26, and the Americans play their last warmups against Senegal five days later and Germany on June 6. The Americans open the World Cup on June 12 against Australia, face Paraguay a week later and close the first round vs. Turkey on June 25.

Before a pro-US crowd of 72,297 at Mercedes-Benz Stadium, Portugal went ahead after American midfielder Weston McKennie knocked a hard-to-control pass from Alex Freeman to Vitinha, who played a through ball to Bruno Fernandes.

Rizvi smashes unbeaten 50 as DC crush LSG by six wickets

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Lucknow

Sameer Rizvi gave ample display of his talent, coming in as an 'Impact Substitute', as Delhi Capitals canted home by six wickets against Lucknow Super Giants despite initial stutters to make a winning start in the IPL here on Wednesday.

Chasing a lowly target of 142, DC were reduced to 26 for 4 within first five overs but Rizvi (70 not out off 47 balls), substituting T Natarajan, conjured an unbroken 119-run stand for the fifth wicket with the seasoned Tristan Stubbs (39 not out off 32 balls) to ensure full points in just 17.1 overs.

Rizvi showed exemplary maturity as he first saw off a spell from Mohammed Shami (1/28 in 4 overs), Mohsin Khan (1/19 in 4 overs) and Prince Yadav (2/20 in 3 overs). In all,

he hit five fours and four sixes to make a chase look ridiculously easy on a seamer-friendly track.

Once he played the ramp shot over keeper's head for a six off Anrich Nortje, he opened up. The turning point was Shahbaz Ahmed's lone over -- the 10th of the DC innings. Rizvi slog swept him behind square, pulled him to the square leg and tickled one through fine leg with 16 coming off that over.

After that, there was no stopping Rizvi, who lofted Aiden Markram over long-on and pulled Mohsin for good measure as he slowly and surely knocked the stuffing out of LSG's sails.

To defend a small total, LSG needed early breakthroughs and Shami was right on the money as KL Rahul was gone for first-ball



duck trying to slash one over point. Mohsin, who was playing his first game in one year, got one to bounce a tad bit extra and had Nitish Rana caught at slip.

Pathum Nissanka's first game ended in a disappointing note as he mistimed a pull off Prince Yadav with Rishabh Pant taking a well judged catch running backwards. DC's most dependable player, their skipper Axar Patel got a beauty from Prince Yadav, a delivery that tailed in getting him clean bowled.

But then, Rizvi and Stubbs had other ideas as they slowly and surely ensured an impressive win.

Earlier, LSG put up an embarrassing batting display with some questionable tactical calls to be shot out for 141 in 18.4 overs after Delhi Capitals skipper Axar opted to bowl first.

Even though the Ekana Stadium wicket wasn't a belter, there couldn't be any tangible excuse for LSG unit for its pathetic batting display.

A fit-again T Natarajan (3/29 in 4 overs), Kuldeep Yadav (2/31 in 4 overs) and the brilliant Lungi Ngidi (3/27 in 3.4 overs), who bowled perhaps a contender for the 'ball of the tournament', made life miserable for the home team, which looked as bad on field as it had seemed on paper as per the pre-tournament predictions.

Captain Rishabh Pant, in a surprising move from the team's perspective, broke a successful opening pair of Aiden Markram and Mitchell March and promoted himself at the top of the order.

Pant (7 off 9 balls) started with a nice bowler's back-drive off Mukesh Kumar but in the next over was run-out at the non-striker's end when the bowler was able to get finger tip onto a smashing straight hit from Marsh.

But to be frank, Pant didn't look comfortable for once despite that opening boundary and it seemed more like a desperation to get his India T20 slot back.

Aiden Markram (11) hit a six and a four but DC skipper Axar Patel's wicket-to-wicket delivery breached his defence.

The highly-rated Ayush Badoni (0) edged one from T Natarajan that was angled across but it was Ngidi's new found confidence with execution of slower deliveries which became the standout moment of the first half.

Wasn't an easy wicket, conditions make big difference, says Patel



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Mullanpur

It wasn't an easy wicket to bat on, said Gujarat Titans assistant coach Parthiv Patel, citing the challenging pitch as the primary reason for his team's three-wicket loss to Punjab Kings in their IPL opener.

Punjab Kings chased a 163-run target with five balls to spare on Tuesday.

"As a team you want them to fight. I am happy that we took the game to the last over," Patel said in the post-match press conference.

"It wasn't the easiest

wicket to bat on. It's been raining here for the last three-four days and the grounds-men did a really good job to prepare the wicket. Once the ball was old, it was reversing a bit, it was also holding up a bit. After powerplay, batting was not easy," he explained.

However, Patel also stated that the difficult pitch does not take away credit from the effort of Punjab's bowlers.

"As I said, the Punjab bowlers, the way they bowled in the final overs, they bowled cleverly towards the end," Patel said.

Shreyas Iyer fined ₹12 lakh for slow-over rate

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Mullanpur

Punjab Kings captain Shreyas Iyer was fined ₹12 lakh after his team maintained a slow over-rate during their IPL match against Gujarat Titans. Punjab Kings defeated GT by three wickets to start their IPL 2026 campaign on a winning note.

"As this was his team's first offence of the season under Article 2.22 of the IPL's Code of Conduct, which pertains to minimum over-rate offences, Iyer was fined INR 12 lakhs," stated a media release.

Pacer Vyshak Vijayakumar



and leg-spinner Yuzvendra Chahal shared five wickets among them as PBKS limited GT to 162 for six.

Despite a stuttering batting effort, Punjab went past the line in 19.1 overs.

Connolly's debut knock shows maturity: Chahal

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Mullanpur

Punjab Kings spinner Yuzvendra Chahal believes young Cooper Connolly will be one of the "finds" of this season, praising the young Australian batter's maturity after he scored a match-winning fifty on his IPL debut. The 22-year-old Connolly announced himself in style, smashing an unbeaten 72 to guide Punjab Kings to a nervy three-wicket win over Gujarat Titans in their IPL campaign opener here on Tuesday.

"He's only 20 something but has a hunger. The way he performed in his very first match, batting at number 3, playing a match-winning innings, shows how mature he is mentally," Chahal said at the post-

match press conference. Walking in at number 3, Connolly held firm even as wickets fell at the other end, showing remarkable composure for a newcomer.

"He knows what the situation is. He knows that if I am there till the end, then I have to finish the game. And that shows maturity. That is a good sign for our team.

"And the way he is batting, I think he will be one of the finds of this season," Chahal said.

C h a h a l



himself played a key role with the ball, returning figures of 2/28 in his four overs. His experience shone through as he applied pressure in the middle overs, restricting GT to 162/6.

Speaking about the bowling plans, he said: "Because the wicket was a little slow, we didn't want to give pace. We wanted to bowl as many cutters as possible. The plan was that if the batsmen hit on longer boundaries, it would be

good for us." Despite Connolly's heroics, Punjab Kings suffered a middle-order collapse, with Priyansh Arya (7), captain Shreyas Iyer (18), Nehal Wadhwa (3), Shashank Singh (4) and Marcus Stoinis (0) failing to make an impact. However, Chahal played down the concerns.

"Every year you have one or two matches like that, and we are lucky that the first match was like that. So, it's nothing to worry about right now. The way we have been playing since last year, we will go to the ground with the same positive energy and there is a hunger, which we missed last year," he said.

PBKS, who moved to fourth spot on the point stable, will next take on Chennai Super Kings in Chennai on Friday.

KKR seek spin revival against SRH in crucial home phase

TAPAN MOHANTA ■ Kolkata

Kolkata Knight Riders will be desperate for their spinners to rediscover the bite against Sunrisers Hyderabad in an IPL match involving two batting-heavy sides on Thursday.

This fixture also marks the start of a crucial home stretch for the three-time champions, who will play three matches in seven days and another on April 19 before the Kolkata leg pauses for nearly a month due to the upcoming assembly polls.



With four away games to follow and their next home fixture scheduled only on May 16, KKR know it is

imperative to build momentum in this phase. Historically, Eden Gardens has been a stronghold of

KKR, winning 54 out of 95 matches since 2008. However, KKR's start has already hit a few early bumps as expectedly with their thin bowling resources. They seemed to have assembled a well-rounded pace attack but injuries and availability issues had blunted their firepower.

Harshit Rana and Akash Deep are ruled out, Matheesha Pathirana is yet to get an NOC from Sri Lanka Cricket, and Cameron Green — their ₹25.20 crore overseas acquisition — is currently available only as a batter.

(PTI)

India to tour Zimbabwe for T20I series in July

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Mumbai

India will head to Zimbabwe for a three-match T20I series in July for their first assignment since clinching their World Cup title this year.

The BCCI informed in a statement on Wednesday that the Indian men's team will play three games against the hosts at the Harare Sports Club on July 23, 25 and 26 respectively.

This will be the first of the two bilateral series slated for the 2026-27 season between India and Zimbabwe, who are slated to travel for a three-match ODI series to be played on January 3, 6 and 9 in Kolkata, Hyderabad and Mumbai



respectively.

India had won the T20 World Cup for a second consecutive time last month, beating New Zealand in the final in Ahmedabad. India have pre-

viously won the T20 World Cup in 2024 and 2007.

India had last toured Zimbabwe for a five-match T20I series in 2024, which they had won 4-1.

McIlroy to return for DP World India Championship at Delhi Golf Club

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ New Delhi

Five-time Major winner Rory McIlroy will tee up at the DP World India Championship at the Delhi Golf Club for a second consecutive season from October 15 to 18.

The World Number 2 and career Grand Slam winner made his first ever appearance in India last season and is now confirmed to return for the \$4,000,000 event.

The reigning Race to Dubai champion confirmed his position as a golfing icon when he



completed the career Grand Slam in memorable fashion at the Augusta National last year. The Green Jacket added to his four

previous Major victories at the 2011 US Open, the US PGA Championship in 2012 and 2014 and The Open in 2014. "I've always enjoyed playing a global schedule so I was excited to visit India for the first time last season to be part of the inaugural DP World India Championship," McIlroy said in a press release.

"The golf fans in India were so welcoming, and the whole experience was truly memorable, so it's a pleasure to be returning to Delhi in October." The Irishman's stellar 2025 season also included

a second Amgen Irish Open title and two more victories on the PGA TOUR, as well as helping Europe earn their first away win in the Ryder Cup since 2012 at Bethpage Black, New York.

He rounded out the year by being crowned Race to Dubai champion for a seventh time — and fourth in succession. Alongside McIlroy, 2025 winner, world No. 4 and reigning FedExCup champion Tommy Fleetwood has also confirmed his participation. Global smart logistics provider DP World and

the DP World Tour launched the DP World India Championship in 2025.

Co-sanctioned by the DP World Professional Golf Tour of India (PGTI), the tournament features the largest prize fund ever offered for a DP World Tour event in India.

Hemant Kumar Ruia, Country Manager, DP World India Subcontinent said, "This tournament reflects our long-term commitment to strengthening trade and connectivity across the region.

Abhishek, Kishan stay 1-2 in ICC T20I rankings

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Dubai

Swashbuckling India batters Abhishek Sharma and Ishan Kishan retained the top two spots in the latest ICC T20I player rankings released on Wednesday. Abhishek leads the chart with 875 points, followed closely by Kishan at 871. They are joined in the top 10 by Tilak Varma, who is placed sixth, and India T20I captain Suryakumar Yadav is in seventh position. Veteran

England wicketkeeper batter Jos Buttler (up one place to eighth) and New Zealand's Tim Seifert (down one spot to ninth) are the only players within the top 20 to register movement this week.

South Africa batter Connor Esterhuizen has continued his recent rise by making giant strides. Esterhuizen made an immediate impact when commencing his international career during South Africa's recent T20I series in New Zealand, with the 24-



year-old amassing a total of 200 runs to be adjudged the Player of the Series. It helped him jump from outside the top 100 spots for T20I batters

to 39th overall, capping a fine fortnight for the hard-hitting right-hander and the Proteas as they claimed a narrow 3-2 series triumph. Esterhuizen's

haul of 200 runs was double more than anyone else managed across the five-game series, with New Zealand keeper Tim Robinson (up two places to equal 32nd) also making ground on the list for T20I batters following his 81 runs against the Proteas. Among bowlers, Afghanistan spinner Rashid Khan continued to lead the charts with India spinner Varun Chakaravathy and pace spearhead Jasprit Bumrah

holding on to their second and fifth spot respectively.

A host of South Africa players were the big winners following their efforts against New Zealand. The pace trio Gerald Coetzee (up 36 spots to equal 52nd), Otneil Baartman (up 10 places to 56th) and George Linde (up six rungs to shared 62nd) have made some ground, while inexperienced New Zealand seamer Zakary Foulkes (up 11 slots to 70th) has also been rewarded.

Dreamt of it for long: Ryan Williams on India debut

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Kochi

Ecstatic after scoring on debut, India's Australian-born striker Ryan Williams said that he had replayed the moment in his head so many times before the match that when it actually happened, he felt a bit "blurry". Williams made a dream India debut as his fourth-minute strike set up the home side's 2-1 win over Hong Kong in an inconsequential Asian Cup qualifying round match on Tuesday.

"It's a strange one. I have been dreaming about this for a long time and done a lot of work to make this happen. You know, you couldn't write this, in Kerala, the home of football, scoring within five minutes and winning," Williams said in a short video posted by the All India Football Federation (AIFF). "It just went blurry. I



think I just slipped over and ran away and didn't know what to do. Because having, in my mind, scored that goal so many times and then it happening is just special and just, you know emotions take over," he said.

Akash Mishra scored the other goal for India in the 50th minute, also his first international strike, to help the Khalid Jamil-coached side notch its first victory of the third round of the qualifiers.

Weatherald, Doggett handed CA central contracts



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Melbourne

Cricket Australia on Wednesday handed maiden central contracts to opener Jake Weatherald and pacer Brendan Doggett while all-rounder Glenn Maxwell and opener Sam Konstas were among those dropped ahead of a demanding 2026-2027 season.

Weatherald and Doggett,

who both made their Test debuts during the Ashes, were rewarded for their performances, while pacer Michael Neser retained his place after his contributions in the series.

Off-spinner Todd Murphy also returned to the list ahead of the five-Test tour of India early next year.

Murphy had been drafted into the Test squad during the Ashes following Nathan Lyon's injury but did not get a game.